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# SEXTUS AURELIUS VICTOR
## A HISTORIOGRAPHICAL STUDY

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## A HISTORIOGRAPHICAL STUDY

H. W. BIRD

FRANCIS CAIRNS

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# PREFACE

In the past few years the fourth century AD has attracted considerable attention and the minor Latin writers of the period have benefited from this interest. Among those authors Aurelius Victor is surely the most engaging. His *De Caesaribus* generally follows the orthodox tradition, a mixture of fact and fancy, of imperial and senatorial propaganda, but it also contains a number of personal comments and judgements. These, together with his occasionally idiosyncratic selection of material and emphasis on particular topics, give us some insight into the feelings of members of his class in the middle of the fourth century. Unfortunately, in spite of the promising preliminary work by S. d'Elia (Naples, 1969), a thorough review of the text by a competent critic is still needed, for the 1982 Teubner fourth edition is merely an unchanged reprint of the 1966 third edition. My own interests lie elsewhere.

The present study was commenced with no preconceptions regarding Victor's manner of composition, the authenticity of the information he provides, or the priority of the *De Caesaribus* with respect to the *Historia Augusta*. The conclusions reached, therefore, are based solely upon the investigations undertaken over the last decade.

It is a pleasure for me to thank Professor R.C. Blockley of Carleton University and Professor R.J. Penella of Fordham University. Both were kind enough to read through the first draft of the manuscript and they made numerous helpful suggestions and astute criticisms which have undoubtedly improved the present study.

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H.W.B.
Windsor, Ontario
August 1983

## CHRONOLOGICAL TABLE

AD

*ca* 320 Birth of Sex. Aurelius Victor and Constans?

324 Defeat of Licinius by Constantine at Adrianople, Chrysopolis and the Hellespont. Constantine sole ruler of the Empire. Construction of Constantinople begins. Licinius and his son executed.

325 Council of Nicaea.

326 Executions of Crispus and Fausta.

330 Dedication of Constantinople. Birth of Ammianus Marcellinus?

332 Defeat of Goths on the Danube: large-scale admittance of Sarmatians into the Empire.

337 Death of Constantine: succession of Constantius II, Constans and Constantine II: murder of eight members of the imperial family.

338 War with Persia: Sapor besieges Nisibis.

340 Constantine II invades Italy and is killed: Constans takes over his part of the Empire.

341 Franks and Alamans invade Gaul.

346 War with Persia: Sapor again besieges Nisibis.

348 War with Persia: 1100th anniversary of Rome's foundation.

349 Sapor again besieges Nisibis.

350 Magnentius, of German origin, declared emperor in Gaul. Constans killed. Vetranio proclaimed emperor at Sirmium (March 1st). Magnentius master of Rome. Conference of Constantius with Vetranio (December 25th). Vetranio steps down and is pardoned by Constantius.

351 War between Constantius and Magnentius. Battle of Mursa.

352 Magnentius loses Italy, falls back on Gaul.

353 Constantius marries Eusebia. Magnentius is defeated and commits suicide.

354 Constantius at war with Alamans. Execution of Gallus. Augustine is born at Thagaste.

355 Constantius still at war with Alamans. Revolt of Silvanus in Gaul, Silvanus killed. Franks, Alamans and Saxons invade Gaul. Julian declared Caesar, married to Helena, sent to Gaul.

356 Julian retakes Cologne, held by Germans for 10 months.

357 Julian, commander in Gaul, defeats Alamans near Strasbourg. Constantius visits Rome. Victor goes on to Sirmium with Constantius?

358 Victor commences work on the *De Caesaribus* sometime after August of this year.

359 Persians under Sapor cross Euphrates, besiege and capture Amida.

360 Further operations of Sapor: Constantius prepares to meet him. Soldiers proclaim Julian Emperor in Gaul. Eusebia dies. Completion of the *De Caesaribus*.

361 Constantius marries Faustina. Julian crosses the Rhine, Constantius the Euphrates. Both are successful. They then march against each other. Julian enters Sirmium after October 10th, meets Victor there. Julian at Naissus (late October), sends for Victor and appoints him Governor of Pannonia Secunda. Constantius dies at Tarsus (November 3rd).

# INTRODUCTION

For the Roman Empire the period between AD 235 and 284 was one of almost constant civil conflicts, German and Persian invasions, localized disorders and natural calamities. Emperors were acclaimed and assassinated in frightening succession and the whole fabric of the empire appeared at times to be in tatters. Despite the straitened circumstances a series of determined soldier-emperors, mainly from Pannonia or the adjacent provinces, held the empire together. They made it possible, first for Diocletian and the tetrarchs and subsequently for Constantine, to undertake the difficult task of rehabilitation. Nevertheless the very process of reconstruction in the half-century following Diocletian's elevation ensured that society would undergo further momentous upheavals.[1]

It was into this turbulent world that Aurelius Victor was born shortly after 320. In 324 Constantine defeated Licinius to become sole master of the whole empire and he quickly began work on his new capital, Constantinople. The following year the Council of Nicaea met at the instigation of the emperor, with far-reaching implications. Thus, while Victor was growing up in North Africa Christianity was being fashioned into the religion of the empire and the new city in the East was growing to rival Rome. In reaction the senatorial aristocracy began its bitter rearguard fight to defend the old, established conceptions of religion and ethics. It was recognized that the way of life of both individual and state was being threatened by the new imperially-supported movement[2] and by the system of reorganization which was designed to preserve the empire. Furthermore, those Roman armies whose duty it was to protect the citizens of the vast state were rapidly becoming armies of barbarians, in the main Germans, in the service of Rome. The landed aristocracy was busily devising means of escaping payment of necessary impositions at the very time that the prodigious building schemes of Constantine, following so soon after those of the tetrarchs, were draining away

precious resources. To compound the problem there were three courts for a time after Constantine's death, each with its mass of supernumeraries, and the new Church had also produced another favoured hierarchy which further strained an economy already weakened by an overblown bureaucracy which was riddled with corruption. Finally, a series of costly civil wars erupted and renewed hostilities with the Persians and Germans brought devastation to certain parts of the empire. The hard-pressed taxpayers, tied to their hereditary occupations, were consequently saddled with a monstrous burden which they could hardly support.

Such was the world in which Victor spent his first thirty to forty years. He was a man of his time; he was also a fervid moralist and a firm believer in the empire. In addition he was, we may presume, fairly representative of his class, that is to say those self-made men who had risen through the ranks of the imperial service because of their talents and their education. Like many others he resented the powers of the uncouth barbarians (Germans) and Pannonians and, though he shared in general the views of the upper classes to which he aspired, he blamed the aristocracy for its subservience and short-sighted preference for riches and leisure which had allowed, in his estimation, the enemy within to take over the reins of government. Yet Victor was not as pessimistic or as fearful as den Boer avers,[3] for he believed that those in power could alter and had, in fact, altered the general state of affairs. Unfortunately he did not realize that the massive infrastructure of the empire possessed a dynamism of its own which, as Julian discovered, was frequently not susceptible to the control of an emperor. Nor did he fully understand that the state had failed as a protector and just as it was compelled to crush resistance so it simultaneously extinguished that independence of spirit necessary for restoring vitality and initiative. Victor's history also lacks a sense of historical development and is ambivalent with respect to causation. Yet it is not coloured by that *animi desperatione* with which Victor characterized the reign of Gallienus. After all, Alexander had allegedly saved the state from imminent collapse[4] and Constantius, only a few years before Victor wrote, had prevented a civil war by the force of his eloquence and his clemency.[5] Good princes could still preserve the peace of the state and the safety of their subjects.[6]

Tacitus, one may claim, showed greater zeal in indicting evil than in showing virtue. Men of his era served the Principate, acknowledged its necessity, but judged it by the values of the

Republic. Victor could be more even-handed and could approach his subject without similar prejudice. The system was taken for granted, the rulers were what mattered and their appointees were of principal importance. Accordingly, whatever else we may read into the *De Caesaribus*, one of the major themes is that of exhortation by example, and one notes right through the work an abundance of *exempla* designed to illustrate those qualities and actions which would best serve the state and those which should be shunned. Victor's final words, surely appended after he had decided to back Julian, underline the point he constantly reiterated: the choice of subordinates is critical and even a good emperor could vitiate his reign by elevating those who were unprincipled or incompetent. Julian was impressed: he was of similar intent. Indeed, despite the necessity for compromise and conciliation and the desire for vengeance, an attempt was made to clean up the court and promote the honest and competent to positions of responsibility. Clearly Victor had fortuitously written the right things at the right time. He was, after all, among the first to be promoted by Julian.

The present study commences with an attempt to reconstruct the background and career of Aurelius Victor and notes those people and places that may have influenced the author's points of view. It then considers Victor's probable mode of composition and suggests the most likely sources of his information.

Chapters three to six deal with those topics which Victor judged to be of cardinal importance: first the emperors and their role in the life of the state, and, *pari passu*, the senate,[7] its relationship with the emperors, its weakness and what Victor believed to be its proper functions. Next Victor's attitude to the army and the bureaucracy, his particular *bêtes noires*, is discussed. Both are outspokenly condemned for their greed and corruption and Victor makes it clear that these two segments of the state must be disciplined and honest. Victor's sentiments regarding Rome and the provinces are then examined, as is the author's distress at the declining importance of the eternal city. Finally, the singular importance which Victor attaches to education and culture is addressed in chapter six.

The study then turns from the central interests of the author to deal with the elements of causation in the *De Caesaribus*, Victor's style and language, and his literary indebtedness to Sallust and Tacitus.

Of the six appendices the first deals with Victor's use of *exempla* and the next three provide supplementary information on the

emperors and on the cities and provinces mentioned by Victor. Appendix five is devoted to certain topics which are of minor importance overall but still of much concern to Victor. Finally, appendix six examines the relationship between the *De Caesaribus* and the *Historia Augusta* and the significance of the former in the lengthy and heated controversy over the dating and authorship of the *H.A.*

Aurelius Victor was not a major fourth-century figure either historically or historiographically but he was highly regarded by three of the foremost personalities of his time, the emperor Julian, Ammianus Marcellinus, and the emperor Theodosius, who made him prefect of Rome in 388/9, and perhaps also by a fourth, Constantius II. It is to be hoped that the present work will facilitate an understanding of this sober, honest, well-intentioned bureaucrat and the milieu in which he lived.

# 1

## A RECONSTRUCTION OF THE LIFE AND CAREER OF SEXTUS AURELIUS VICTOR

Sextus Aurelius Victor, the author of the *Historiae Abbreviatae*, commonly called *Liber de Caesaribus*, is one of the more intriguing minor authors of the fourth century. His work survives in just two fifteenth-century manuscripts of which one, p, is to be found in Brussels, the other, o, in the Bodleian Library at Oxford.[1] Apparently, unlike his contemporary Eutropius, Victor was never a popular author and only recently has he begun to arouse scholarly interest.

Victor was born in a country district of the province of Africa and his father, so Victor himself indicates, was of humble means and not educated.[2] Nevertheless the father was probably not a mere peasant but rather a reasonably well-to-do farmer who, like Augustine's father, Patricius, sensed the importance of education and was prudent enough to provide his son with it. It is clear from Victor's statement that his father belonged to the ranks of the *humiliores* and was therefore not of decurion status,[3] but this may well have been a financial blessing since it meant escape from the fiscal responsibilities of the *curiales*.

The date of Victor's birth cannot be fixed with certainty but one can assume that he was born about or soon after 320 AD, for in 337 he appears to have been in Rome and to have witnessed the anger of the populace when Constantine was buried in Constantinople.[4] It is hardly likely that he would have been allowed to travel to Rome before his sixteenth or seventeenth birthday. Secondly, in 361 he was sufficiently mature and experienced as an imperial official to be appointed consular governor of Pannonia Secunda.[5] Moreover, as a non-military *novus* it is doubtful that he would have climbed the bureaucratic ladder with any great rapidity.

Victor's elementary education, then, like that of his more celebrated North African countryman, Augustine, was presumably acquired locally, since that was normally the case for upper and middle classes alike.[6] Augustine, born in 354 at Thagaste, received his elementary education there before going to the neighbouring town of Madaura, some twenty miles away, to study literature and begin rhetoric. At the age of sixteen he travelled to Carthage to further his studies in rhetoric.[7] Probably Victor also continued his studies in the African capital: he exhibits both a knowledge of and an affection for the city,[8] which was an outstanding educational centre at this time with a municipal professorship in Latin[9] as well as numerous schools both private and public. Victor's early years, then, were spent among people who could remember the depredations of Maxentius' lieutenants and who had felt the stress of corrupt officials. He may personally have witnessed the destruction of the seats of pagan worship and some of the religious and social struggles of his home province. Yet he was in reality quite fortunate, for Africa had, in his day, escaped the worst of the invasions and civil wars and Constantine, who valued the province as a granary for Rome, had rebuilt those cities damaged under Maxentius. Thus the relative prosperity of Africa may have helped Victor's father to provide the education necessary to launch him on his career in the bureaucracy.

Subsequently Victor appears to have left his native province for Rome, as did so many other upwardly-mobile provincials, for he notes with distress the bitter resentment of the Roman citizens when Constantine was not buried there, the shameful lack of celebrations upon the eleven-hundredth anniversary of the city and the name of one of the consuls of that year, Philip.[10] He may also have personally viewed the fratricidal war between Constans and Constantine II in 340 and the civil conflicts caused by Magnentius' seizure of power in 350. Between *ca* 337 and *ca* 354, then, Victor was probably at Rome. At first he may have studied law like Alypsius, the friend and student of Augustine, and numerous other students who streamed to Rome from all parts of the empire.[11] On the other hand, legal studies were not a prerequisite for entry to and advancement in the imperial bureaucracy. Symmachus noted that a literary education could open the way to various magistracies[12] and John Chrysostom depicts ambitious parents in Antioch urging their children to study literature in order that they might make their way into the government bureaucracy.[13] Ausonius encouraged his grandson to study rhetoric for the same reason.[14]

Whether he pursued legal studies or not Victor does seem to have obtained a position within the imperial civil service during his stay at Rome. As a provincial *parvenu* and in light of his frequent remarks favouring the promotion of men of culture and education he possibly benefited from the system later formalized under Valentinian in 370[15] whereby outstanding students had places found for them in the administration. Nevertheless the path upwards for this self-made man was presumably not easy and one is tempted to consider that what he writes of his fellow African, Septimius Severus, was perhaps a reflection of his own vicissitudes: *ortus medie humili, primo litteris, dehinc imbutus foro; quo parum commodante, uti rebus artis solet, dum tentat varia melioraque ...; post multos dubiosque eventus auspicia honorum ...; laborantibus secundarum initia earumque auctores memoriae sunt.*[16] There is no equivocation in his statement that he had reached his station in life as an *honestior* by virtue of his application to his studies.[17] Furthermore, he writes, it is generally accepted that good and sensible men are made more capable by experiencing misfortunes whereas those who have never suffered hardships are less understanding since they judge everyone by the yardstick of their own wealth.[18] Victor, in all probability, commenced his bureaucratic career at Rome in *ca* 345.

In which branch of the imperial service might Victor have worked? Not in the army: his denunciations of the military are frequent and bitter; nor with the *agentes in rebus* whom he acrimoniously stigmatizes by likening them to the pestilential *frumentarii*.[19]

He might have served in the corps of notaries, since his education and background would have equipped him admirably for such a post. Indeed, the corps underwent rapid expansion under Constantius II, who employed senior notaries on numerous important and confidential missions, and many members of the corps received notable promotions. Felix was appointed *magister officiorum*; Domitian became *magister sacrarum largitionum* and, later on, praetorian prefect of the East; Taurus was promoted to the office of *quaestor*, was praetorian prefect in 355 and consul in 361; Dulcitius rose to be consular governor of Phoenice and proconsul of Asia. All these, like Victor, were of humble origin: Domitian's father had been a manual worker, the father of Dulcitius a fuller.[20] Other celebrated *notarii* of the period were Procopius, a relative of Julian, and Jovianus, chief of the notaries in 363. The former was born *ca* 326 and was tribune and notary in 358. Julian promoted him to the post

of *comes* and allegedly promised him the succession, but Jovian the *primicerius domesticorum* was acclaimed emperor. In 365 Procopius was even proclaimed rival emperor to Valentinian and Valens, but was executed the following year. Jovianus, too, was nominated as a potential successor to Julian but was subsequently executed by Jovian.[21] Finally Flavius Philippus, whose father had been a sausage-maker, learned shorthand, became a *notarius*, rose to the rank of praetorian prefect and was consul in 348.[22] All in all the notaries were a powerful group and conspicuous promotions from their upper echelons took place under Constantius II and his successors. It was perhaps as a *notarius*, then, that Victor served at Rome. On the other hand, Victor's special knowledge of the imposition of taxation on "a part of Italy" (i.e. *Italia annonaria*) by Diocletian,[23] of the building schemes in Carthage, Nicomedia and Milan,[24] of the origins, nature and abolition of the special oil and grain taxes on Tripolis and Nicaea,[25] of the erection of statues in various notable places and the establishment of a Flavian priesthood in Africa and the reconstruction and renaming of Cirta (Constantina)[26] may indicate that Victor served in the *scrinium epistolarum* which drafted rescripts to judges and replies to delegations of provincial assemblies and cities. Members of the *scrinium* served both the *magister scriniorum* and the quaestor and promotion in this small but important secretariat depended upon education and seniority.

At Sirmium it seems likely that Victor served on the staff of the admirable Anatolius, praetorian prefect of Illyricum between 357 and early 360. Victor writes in his discussion of Trajan's reign *his annis suffectae vires Illyrico sunt praefecto medente Anatolio*.[27] He continues with a moralizing comment which he must surely have learned at school, that there is nothing in the state, good or bad, which cannot be reversed by the character of those in power.[28] "That Victor should even know to whom the credit belonged in this case is in itself surprising. Combined with the knowledge of Victor's presence at Sirmium in 361 I found this a tempting indication that he was working in the imperial bureaucracy at Sirmium at the time." This is the opinion of Nixon with whom I entirely concur. Ammianus informs us that Victor was at Sirmium in 361[29] and was summoned thence to Naissus by Julian to be made consular governor of Pannonia and to be honoured with a bronze statue.[30] Sirmium was extremely important at that period. It was the headquarters of the praetorian prefect of Illyricum[31] and of the governor of Pannonia Secunda,[32] and was one of the imperial residences. It boasted a senate

house, forum, barracks, a mint for gold, silver and copper, an imperial arms factory and a fleet station. Lying astride the great highway from Aquileia to Constantinople it controlled movements between the eastern and western halves of the empire. The city's territory extended westwards at least as far as Budalia, eight miles away, and probably northwards to the Danube, as well as eastwards and southwards for several miles. The countryside was marshy, interspersed with canals for drainage, but the hillsides were planted with an abundance of vineyards. Decius and Probus were native sons and Maximian was raised there. In Victor's day Sirmium was a bustling, prosperous frontier city, full of civil servants, soldiers, merchants and artisans, and possessing its own local aristocracy, baths, theatre and hippodrome. Constantius made great use of it for his Danubian campaigns between 357 and 359, as the vast numbers of coins minted in his reign and found there demonstrate.[33] The number of officials and administrators needed there at that time must have been great and it is possible that Victor was despatched there from Rome sometime in 357 when Constantius returned to Sirmium after his official visit to Rome.[34] In that case the statement that people working their way up remember their patrons (n.16) may refer to Constantius.

Victor's title and duties in Sirmium are, again, a matter for speculation, but a remarkable passage in the *De Caesaribus* may give us a clue to one aspect of his work. In 33.13 Victor vehemently attacks the *actuarii* for their greed and corruption. The *actuarii* were quartermasters with specific duties in the commissariat. They picked up from local storehouses the supplies (*pittacia*) needed by the various troop contingents, and distributed them. They may also have been responsible for the initial assessment. Hence they wielded considerable influence over the producers, the collectors who had to make up the shortfalls in the indictions, and the troops.[35] Victor's outburst is surely the result of bitter personal experience. His post was presumably by 359 in the senior ranks of Anatolius' commissariat, from where he could witness the latter's first-rate administration. This apparently brought him into contact with that particular group of venal officials and thereby created such deep-seated animosity.[36] The financial side of the praetorian prefect's administration was divided into four *scrinia* each headed by a *numerarius*. These were appointed according to seniority from the clerks (*scrinarii*) and in turn appointed their own assistants (*adiutores*) and secretaries (*chartularii*) from the remaining clerks of

their bureau. *Scriniarii* were also sent out annually to the provinces to supervise collection of the revenue, to extract arrears or to audit public works and military accounts.[37] In the *De Caesaribus* Victor mentions the *annona* and taxation on nine occasions,[38] four of them in the final four chapters with personal comments appended to three. In 9.12 Victor writes: *hac tempestate ... fecere nomen plerique potentia vacuum insolensque miseris, subiectum pessimo cuique et annonae specie rapax*. In 39.32, while discussing the imposition of taxation on Italy by Diocletian, he states that: *quae sane illorum temporum modestia tolerabilis in perniciem processit his tempestatibus*. Subsequently, in 39.45, he informs us that Diocletian carefully looked after Rome's grain supply and the welfare of the taxpayers by promoting more honest officials and punishing criminals, while in 41.20 he notes that in fiscal matters Constantine admitted to public office unworthy individuals. This circumstantial evidence leads me to conclude that the most probable bureau for Victor to have worked in at Sirmium was the fiscal *scrinium* of the praetorian prefect, and that Victor was possibly a *numerarius* in 361 when he met Julian.[39]

It was during this period that Victor composed the *De Caesaribus*, the only work, as far as we know, that he wrote. It was commenced at the earliest in 358, for the author notes an earthquake at Nicomedia during the consulship of Cerealis and this particular earthquake occurred in August of that year.[40] From internal evidence we learn that the work was completed between September 9, 359 and September 8, 360.[41] Julian's proclamation as Augustus took place at Paris in February 360 and Florentius, Julian's disaffected praetorian prefect, fled to Sirmium that month to take the place of Anatolius who had died in office.[42] Victor, therefore, may have been influenced by his superior's opinion of Julian while working on the final stages of his book, and this would explain the short shrift given to Julian in 42.17-18 where the author states that, though Julian won the military victories in Gaul, he did so *vi eius, fortuna principis tamen et consilio*. Victor goes on to say: *quod adeo praestat, ut Tiberius Galeriusque subiecti aliis egregia pleraque, suo autem ductu atque auspicio minus paria experti sint*.[43] Victor loathed civil wars and must have hoped that the one which loomed after Julian's acclamation might be averted. When that proved impossible he was compelled to take sides and, whether because of geographically imposed necessity or belief in Julian's qualities, he opted to support the new emperor.

Soon after the completion of the *De Caesaribus* and shortly before Constantius' death Julian arrived at Bononea, some nineteen

miles north of Sirmium, on or about October 10, 361. An advance party under Dagalaifus captured Lucillianus, the military commander of Pannonia, in his bed and Julian marched into Sirmium without opposition escorted by a throng of civilians and local soldiers. Clearly he had the support of a number of the senior officials there. He stayed only three days before resuming his march eastwards. Nevertheless he must have met the various officials of the imperial bureaucracy during those three days in order to establish an orderly and supportive continuation of the government and commissariat. Victor was plainly among those officials and Julian probably perused the recently completed *De Caesaribus*[44] either during the stay at Sirmium or in the following week. Victor must have made a favourable impression on Julian: the *De Caesaribus* did the rest. As Bowersock has recently stated: "Victor had concluded his work with the expected eulogy of the reigning monarch but his words had a curiously reticent quality. He managed to blend flattery of Constantius personally with a clear condemnation of Constantius' courtiers."[45] At any rate Julian seems to have been convinced that Victor was a clever and literate ally.

When Julian arrived at Naissus, probably one or two weeks later and certainly before news of Constantius' death (November 3) had become known, he requested that Victor leave Sirmium and meet him at Naissus, one may presume for a serious interview. The young emperor then made Victor an outstanding offer, the consular governorship of Pannonia Secunda and a bronze statue.[46] Several factors presumably influenced Julian in arriving at his decision. First, Victor had worked at Sirmium in the bureaucracy, almost certainly as a senior official, and knew Pannonia.[47] In addition, he was clearly a sound, dependable, man (*vir sobrietatis gratia aemulandus* is how Ammianus describes him[48]) with an obvious respect for honesty and good government.[49] Julian had angered his prefect in Gaul, Florentius, by intruding on the latter's competence and questioning his ability, and by his own efficiency in cutting down the levy from twenty-five to seven *solidi per caput* annually.[50] He would certainly have welcomed administrators of a disposition similar to his own. Again, like Julian, Victor had literary tendencies and probably agreed with the emperor in general philosophy. Both men admired Rome's ancient institutions and religion, even if Julian carefully concealed his paganism until Constantius had died and his own legitimacy had been accepted.[51] Finally, when Victor was offered his position Julian was a usurper and many officials refused

to serve him, whether through fear or principle, or fled to Constantius.[52] Julian was simply obliged to replace them.

Victor's new office was a momentous promotion for him. It carried with it the clarissimate, entry into the senate, and the possibility of achieving 'the one ancient Republican office which retained its glamour untarnished, the ordinary consulship".[53] Moreover, Victor was honoured with a statue. Nixon suggests that this may have been due to some "more important political service for Julian than the mere transference of his allegiance".[54] Possibly Victor was instrumental in winning over to Julian a number of officials in October 361. On the other hand, Julian may simply have been impressed by the *De Caesaribus* and have awarded the statue as a decoration for literary endeavour.[55] The moralistic tone of the work would suit Julian, who subsequently reduced the size of his bureaucracy and attempted to curtail corruption.

In the autumn of 361, therefore, Victor became the consular governor of Pannonia Secunda, which was a strategically vital province and had recently been upgraded in status.[56] The length of his term of office is not known for certain; Fortunatus held the post on May 28, 365.[57] It seems likely that Victor served during the reign of Julian and was then replaced by either Jovian or Valentinian in 363 or soon thereafter.

Approximately a quarter of a century now elapses before we reach the date of Victor's next known office, that of urban prefect of Rome.[58] It would, however, be unsound to imagine that Victor could step into the eminently prestigious position of urban prefect twenty-five years after holding a consular governorship without having held other positions in the interim. Jones points out that, for those with a senatorial background, a common minimum was consular, proconsul, city prefect; commoners such as Victor had to go through a longer series of offices, would start out later in life on the hierarchical ladder and might have considerable intervals between posts.[59] Victor, then, probably held the proconsulship of Africa or possibly the vicariate of Rome between the years 363 and 388, each post carrying the rank of *spectabilis*. Both the *fasti* of the proconsuls of Africa and the lists of the vicars of Rome are incomplete, and Victor was an African, a writer, and a man of notable *sobrietas*. Jovian and Valentinian did, indeed, replace a number of Julian's appointees, and Valentinian restricted the careers of many more senatorials between 368 and his death in 375.[60] The latter was the son of a Pannonian soldier, a Christian and a recently promoted commander

of one of the *scholae* when elected emperor. Under him Pannonians were given preferential treatment for "he hated the well-dressed and educated and wealthy and well-born".[61] Victor, in the *De Caesaribus* and presumably in his private life, was highly critical of the army, scornful of the *agrestes*, and a pagan. Nevertheless he was also educated and a career official. One may presume, therefore, that when Valentinian and Valens left Sirmium in August 364 Victor may have been given another post as a senior administrator. In any event it is likely that within the next ten to fifteen years he held the position of proconsul of Africa.

His immediate predecessor as urban prefect, Sextius Rusticus Iulianus, held the African post between 371 and 373 and was, like Victor, not of senatorial origin.[62] Furthermore three other urban prefects who held the post between 381 and 385, Flavius Afranius Syagrius, Valerius Severus and Q. Aurelius Symmachus, were all previously proconsuls of that province.[63] Soon after Valentinian had died in 376 Symmachus rose in the senate to make a speech thanking that body and the senior emperor, Gratian, for making his father consul.[64] Relations between the senate and the emperor improved somewhat and Victor possessed two advantages in dealing with the Pannonians: he had served at Sirmium, presumably in an honourable fashion, and he was not an aristocrat by birth but an African provincial.

Finally the emperor Theodosius appointed Victor *praefectus urbi et iudex sacrarum cognitionum*, as the inscription on the base of a statue dedicated to the emperor by Victor as urban prefect surely indicates.[65] The date of appointment was probably late August or soon after in 388, for Ammianus had completed his twenty-first book by 391 and Victor's office is noted there. Ceionius Rufius Albinus was urban prefect from June 17, 389 to February 24, 391 and Faltonius Alypius was prefect before June 12, 391. Victor thus served prior to June 389. However the *fasti* are complete between 384 and 388 and Sextius Rusticus Iulianus died in office in the latter year.[66]

This office was much sought after by members of the senatorial aristocracy as the crowning point of their careers[67] and was held at this period by such eminent individuals as Anicius Auchenius Bassus, Q. Aurelius Symmachus, Ceionius Rufius Albinus, Faltonius Probus Alypius and Nicomachus Flavianus. Victor, the self-made man from Africa, was in illustrious company and his *sobrietas* and integrity appear not only to have impressed Constantius II, Julian and Ammianus, but also Theodosius, a pious Christian.

Victor's term as urban prefect was short, at most nine months, but this need not indicate either that he died in office, as did his predecessor, or that Theodosius was displeased with his performance. The office was in great demand, and not only among the aristocracy who gained over half of the appointments.[68] In fact the list in Chastagnol's *fasti* shows 129 appointments in 133 years between 290 and 423, i.e. a normal tenure of approximately one year. Furthermore Theodosius was at Rome in the summer of 389 and the appointment of Albinus may have been part of his attempt at conciliation with the pagan aristocracy of the capital. The date of Victor's death, therefore, like that of his birth, cannot be fixed precisely. None the less it is likely that he died in or soon after 389, when he would have been well over sixty years old. In addition, Ammianus' mention of Victor in book 21 could be read as an obituary notice of a man who had recently held a prominent position and was admired by the historian.

Victor's career, like those of several of his contemporaries who were also *novi homines*, such as Domitian and Dulcitius mentioned above, indicates that the imperial bureaucracy of the middle and late fourth century AD admitted competent and reliable men from the ranks of the *humiliores*. The emperors of those days needed large numbers of such officials and presumably had this in mind when promulgating laws encouraging education.[69] Men such as Victor who had no curial duties awaiting them at home were suitable candidates for the administration. The criterion for first appointments was academic ability (though, naturally, knowing someone in a position of power helped then as now) and Valentinian's law of 370 (*Cod. Theod.* XIV. 9.1) probably regularized what had long been a practice, namely that the urban prefect should provide a list of outstanding students for placement in the bureaucracy. Hence Victor could say with candour that he had achieved his rank of *honestior* by means of his studies.[70] Thereafter Victor's career depended upon the manner in which he executed his duties, upon making himself stand out in some way, e.g. in writing the *De Caesaribus*, and upon *Fortuna*. It was his good fortune to be at Sirmium in an official capacity in October 361 when Julian arrived there and it was similarly fortunate that Julian needed administrators. It was also fortunate that he had just finished his history and had expressed sentiments which coincided with those of Julian. Lastly, Victor was lucky that Constantius died the following month. Nevertheless, without the education he had received and worked for, without his *sobrietas* so admired by

Ammianus, and without the publication of his little book, he would not have obtained his consular governorship or his urban prefecture, an outstanding achievement for a *novus*.

# 2

## THE SOURCES OF THE *DE CAESARIBUS*

In assessing the value of any historical work it is necessary for the investigator to undertake the often frustrating and tedious task of 'Quellenforschung'. In the case of the *De Caesaribus* the first substantial attempts began in Germany in 1873 and 1874 with the appearance of two important studies by A. Enmann and A. Cohn.[1] Enmann sought to explain the mass of verbal similarities, numerous errors and shared idiosyncrasies to be found in Victor's *De Caesaribus*, Eutropius' *Breviarium* 7-9, and parts of the *Historia Augusta* (*H.A.*) by postulating a common source which has subsequently come to be known as the 'Kaisergeschichte' (K.G.). He was so convinced by his findings that he stated (p.459), "Victor und Eutrop es beide als Haupt- wenn nicht als einzige Quelle benutzt haben."

Working quite independently, Cohn's examination of the first eleven chapters led him to conclude that from the beginning of Augustus' sole reign to the death of Domitian, Victor, Eutropius and the Epitomator followed a common source which he entitled *Suetonius auctus*, an account excerpted from Suetonius with some new material added.[2] Enmann, however, had already described the K.G.'s early chapters in this way and the two were readily identified.[3]

One major problem remained. The date of the completion of the *H.A.* was still believed to be 305/6; consequently, if the K.G. had been used by the authors of the *H.A.*, then the K.G. must have been written by that year. Nevertheless notable similarities between Victor and Eutropius continued apparently till 357 and Enmann therefore suggested a continuation of the K.G. until that date. This unsatisfactory hypothesis soon proved unnecessary. Dessau, in 1889, unmasked the pretensions of the *H.A.*, dating it to the end of the fourth century. He argued cogently that the close relationship between *De Caes.* 20.1 and 20.10-30 and *H.A. Sev.* 17.5 - 19.4, and between Eutropius' *Breviarium* 8.11-14 and *H.A. Marc. Aur.* 15.3 -

19.12, could only be explained by the hypothesis that the *H.A.* derived this material from Victor and Eutropius, i.e. the *H.A.* was composed after 370.[4] There seemed no further need to posit a continuation of the K.G.: it continued to 357. Nevertheless in two recent and notable studies it has been argued that the K.G. ends at 337, for after that date Victor and Eutropius "exhibit no example of either close verbal similarity or common error or shared idiosyncracy".[5] Verbal parallels do, however, persist although they are considerably less remarkable and less frequent. The two writers are particularly close in their description of Constantine's death and both refer to Constantinople as *urbem nominis sui*.[6] When discussing the character of the usurper Vetranio, Victor and Eutropius differ markedly. Victor denigrates Vetranio for his stupidity, low birth and rustic *vecordia* whereas Eutropius emphasizes his uprightness, his old-fashioned morality and his pleasant civility. Yet both note his lack of education with almost *verbatim* similarity: for Victor he was *litterarum prorsus expers*; Eutropius describes him as *omnium litterarum expertem*.[7] Nixon notes that he is "beguiled by the notion of a common source here because of Eutropius' 'omnium litterarum expertem adeo ut ne elementa quidem prima earum . . .' Even if he read Victor he evidently also used a source which supplied full details."[8]

When Constantius deposed Vetranio both Victor and Eutropius underscore the novelty of the circumstances.[9] They further remark that Nepotianus seized power with the help of a band of gladiators and described the followers of Magnentius as *Magnentiani*.[10] One should, of course, expect that Victor and Eutropius were personally better informed about recent events and consequently would have less need to follow their common source if it did, in fact, continue down to 357. As the evidence stands it is impossible to ascertain precisely when the K.G. terminated, so the two potential dates, 337 and 357, must remain open. Both were significant. In 337 Constantine died, thus providing a logical conclusion for any series of imperial biographies. On the other hand, 357 was the date of Constantius' only visit to Rome, and of the momentous Roman victory over the Alamanni at Strasbourg and the capture of their king, Chnodomar.

The existence of the K.G. has long been widely accepted, since it appeared to be a necessary postulate to explain the multitude of resemblances between the *De Caesaribus* and the *Breviarium*, and their common errors;[11] but recently several scholars have opposed

that view. In 1972 den Boer concluded: "This historian, manufactured in 1874, continues to make his presence felt in the literature of today."[12] Den Boer's book was subsequently praised by Oost with special reference to its author's refusal to accept the K.G., "a much cited product of nineteenth-century scholarship".[13] Just prior to this Chastagnol asserted that Eutropius had read Victor, which would render dependence upon a common source unnecessary.[14] Finally, in his edition of the *De Caesaribus* Dufraigne totally rejected the K.G. as a phantom work whose existence is nowhere attested.[15]

Chastagnol's view is bolstered by a single example and has already been dismissed.[16] Dufraigne's arguments are similarly weak, for he is himself compelled to create phantom sources to explain errors and resemblances between Victor and Eutropius on several occasions, and this, in effect, makes nonsense of his refusal to accept the existence of the K.G.[17] Den Boer offers a more intriguing explanation. He feels that the necessarily similar chronological framework of the *Breviaria*, a common heritage of rhetorical training and school text-books and a shared oral tradition account for the often verbatim parallels between the various fourth-century writers.[18] It would be foolish to deny the powerful influence of the relatively uniform Roman school system on historical and literary tradition in the empire[19] or the existence of a lively oral tradition concerning the basic outlines of Roman history. Victor and Eutropius, then, like countless others before them, were the products of a rather narrow education which, according to Marrou, followed a fixed methodology and a prescribed list of authors.[20] But private reading and personal preferences must be admitted and in no way can all the resemblances between Victor and Eutropius be ascribed solely to a common literary and oral tradition. Nor can the very disturbing shared errors which are quietly ignored by den Boer. Indeed, his approach is far too selective and he "seriously underestimates the number of verbal parallels in the various works".[21] Accordingly one is surely compelled to conclude that none of the aforementioned scholars has brought forward any convincing argument to controvert acceptance of the K.G. as the main source of Victor's *De Caesaribus* and Eutropius' *Breviarium*. A brief examination of Victor's account of Pertinax, Julianus and Septimius should reinforce this view.

Victor clearly knew very little about Pertinax, as his five lines of description demonstrate. He calls him *Aulus* Helvius Pertinax, a mistake not shared by any other writer, and pads his account with a

republican *exemplum* and a pejorative note on the army. He also informs us that Pertinax was urban prefect, a scrap of information found in Eutropius, the *Epitome* and the *H.A.*[22] Finally, he implicates Julianus in the death of Pertinax, as do the three other authors, which may have been a neat piece of Severan propaganda to be revived soon afterwards against Albinus.[23] Nevertheless their information is false; neither Dio nor Herodian carry it. Furthermore the short note in the *H.A.*'s *vita* of Julianus is at variance with the fuller account in the *vita* of Pertinax and the latter agrees with the account of Dio.[24] It appears, then, that for this error the *H.A.* follows Victor or a common source. Such a source cannot have been extensive, otherwise Victor would have known more about Pertinax, i.e. it could not have been Marius Maximus, Ignotus, Dio or Herodian. Eutropius' five-line account of Pertinax states, along with Victor, that the emperor died *octogesimo imperii die*, but mentions the praetorians, so that it was not copied from Victor, but depended upon a similarly uninformed source.

In discussing Julianus both Victor and Eutropius confuse Didius and Salvius Julianus[25] and note the *edictum perpetuum*. But while Victor believes that the emperor was responsible for its composition, Eutropius says the emperor's grandfather was responsible. Both authors then mention Julianus' defeat at the Milvian Bridge and his death in the palace. This battle that never was[26] is a reflection of the celebrated battle of 312 between Constantine and Maxentius and is recorded by Victor and Eutropius, but not by the Epitomator and the *H.A.* But Eutropius was not following Victor here either, despite the suggestion of Dufraigne,[27] for he does not note Julianus' prefecture of the *vigiles* or make him personally responsible for the *edictum perpetuum*. The last two mistakes are Victor's own; the fictitious battle at the Milvian Bridge and the misnaming of Didius Julianus are the inventions of the uninformed author of the K.G.[28]

When Victor comes to the reign of Septimius Severus his narrative expands noticeably, as does that of Eutropius to a lesser degree. None the less there is a series of errors running through the account which indicates that he was still following a circumscribed and occasionally inaccurate source. First he translated Severus' governorship to Syria, apparently a personal mistake[29] since Eutropius has nothing of this and the Epitomator correctly locates Severus in Pannonia.[30] Second, he has Niger killed at Cyzicus, as does Eutropius.[31] Third, he anachronistically cites Niger as *dux Aegypti* whereas Eutropius merely reveals that Niger rebelled in Syria

and Egypt (as does Orosius, 7.17.2) and the *H.A.* records that he declared himself emperor at the instigation of the Syrian armies.[32] Fourth, he shares a story with Eutropius and the *H.A.* that Albinus assisted in the murder of Pertinax, another blatant piece of Severan propaganda not to be found in Dio or Herodian and probably not in Marius Maximus or any other reliable, contemporary source.[33] Again, neither Eutropius nor the *H.A.* followed Victor here: they relate that Albinus allied himself with Julianus in the murder, whereas Victor baldly notes Albinus as the *Pertinacis auctor occidendi*. Finally Victor makes another error of his own by describing Abgarus as King of the Persians.[34] Dio and Herodian both cite him as King of the Osrhoënians.[35] Indeed, only the *H.A.*, in a passage manifestly lifted from the *De Caesaribus*, gives Abgarus the same title, *Rex Persarum*.[36]

It is true that Victor's account of the reign of Septimius Severus is considerably longer than his combined accounts of the reigns of Pertinax and Julianus and substantially fuller than the accounts of Eutropius and the Epitomator. Indeed, it contains details found in neither of the latter, though such details are found in the *H.A.* Nevertheless the abundance of errors, shared and personal, covering this period can only lead one to deduce that Victor did not have a reliable source for the period available at the time of writing or even the *texta ornatu et fide paribus* of Severus which Victor mentions.[37] The necessary inference is that Victor was working a) with an unreliable source, or b) from memory and his memory was faulty. Finally, a detailed investigation of *De Caesaribus* 26-27 by Nixon[38] reveals more evidence of shared errors and parallels of material in Victor's work and that of Eutropius which can only be explained by use of a common source. Further substantiation of the existence of the K.G. would appear to be superfluous: Victor and Eutropius used it, so did the Epitomator, the *H.A.* and others.[39]

But did Victor have any recourse to Suetonius and Tacitus for his account of the emperors from Augustus to Domitian? Dufraigne believes so: he tells us that Victor contaminated Suetonius, Tacitus and other Latin sources[40] and, in addition, was indebted to the scholarly tradition of the rhetors which would explain the topoi in the *De Caesaribus*.[41]

First of all it must be admitted that Victor, Eutropius and the Epitomator followed a basically biographical format and, as Nixon noted some time ago, it was virtually impossible in the fourth century to write an account of the early principate which was independent of

Suetonian material.[42] Second, it is highly likely that Victor had read the *De Vita Caesarum* and Tacitus' *Annals* and *Histories* or a *florilegium* of the latter two. Victor states plainly, and I see no reason to disbelieve him here, *ac mihi quidem audienti multa legentique* ....[43] Earlier, while discussing Agrippina and Nero, he wrote: *atque inter haec matrem etiam contaminavisse plures habent* .... *id ego quamquam scriptoribus diversa firmantibus verum puto.*[44] Several other comments also appear to indicate that Victor had read quite widely.[45] The further question which intrudes at this point, however, is which book or books might Victor have had before him when composing the *De Caesaribus*? Cohn has argued carefully and cogently against the direct use of either Tacitus or Suetonius[46] and the following indications would appear to add weight to his view.

Victor, as he depicts Caligula's popularity with the legions, comments: *tum quia natus in exercitu.*[47] The story is in *Annals* (1.41.3) but Suetonius, in a passage which could easily be a model for historical research, goes to great lengths to prove quite conclusively that this was not so and that Caligula was actually born at Antium.[48] In my opinion Victor could not possibly have had the *De Vita Caesarum* conveniently at hand when discussing Caligula's birth and still have written what he did. Suetonius is utterly convincing and Victor writes what he believes to be true, as he clearly states in 5.9: *id ego quamquam scriptoribus diversa firmantibus verum puto.* But did he use Tacitus directly?

Tacitus, when describing the death of Tiberius, informs us simply that Macro had *Tiberius* smothered[49] whereas Victor writes *Claudio febri an insidiis oppresso*, demonstrating knowledge of differing views to be found in Suetonius.[50] Eutropius has no comment on either matter. The Epitomator, however, who has apparently been following Victor closely to this point and afterwards, tells us that the emperor *insidiis Caligulae extinctus est* and that Caligula had received his nickname *quia natus in exercitu fuerat.*[51] Dufraigne's response to this mixture of Suetonian and Tacitean material is that Victor conflated Suetonius and Tacitus.[52] Nevertheless it is striking that Victor does not even mention Sejanus and only notes that Germanicus was the son of Drusus, whereas Tacitus, in the first six books of his *Annals*, accords great prominence to both. It is difficult for me to believe that an author with the *Annals* open before him would ignore these important personages although it is, of course, possible.[53] Perhaps, however, the most convincing passage is that dealing with the appearance of the Phoenix in Egypt,

which Victor places in the reign of Claudius.[54] Suetonius does not have the story; Tacitus and Dio set it in the reign of Tiberius.[55] Pliny the Elder informs us that the bird appeared in Egypt in AD 36 and was brought to Rome for the eight-hundredth anniversary of the city during the censorship of Claudius in AD 47.[56] Dufraigne admits that Victor's account owes nothing to Tacitus or Suetonius (or Dio) but thinks it stems from Pliny, Solinus or a handbook of curiosities.[57] Victor then links the sighting of the Phoenix with the sudden appearance of an island in the Aegean and a lunar eclipse. Seneca, Dio and Orosius all note the appearance of the island, only Victor has the eclipse.[58] Dufraigne admits that he cannot identify the source but it is perhaps that of Orosius[59] (whose account is fuller than that of Victor here so that he cannot be following Victor). Nothing precludes that source from being the K.G. Indeed the K.G.'s circumscribed account would already have telescoped events in the reigns of the early emperors by lessening the roles of Germanicus and Sejanus, abbreviating or probably omitting Suetonius' discussion of Caligula's birthplace and relocating the appearance of the Phoenix.

Victor did not research his material carefully: there are too many arresting errors. Nevertheless a comparison with Jerome has been made to support the contention that he did.[60] Jerome wrote to a friend asking for a copy of Victor's work before publishing his *Chronicle*.[61] In the preface to that work Jerome also informs the reader of his mode of composition: *nunc addita, nunc admixta sunt plurima quae de Tranquillo et ceteris inlustribus historicis curiosissime excerpsi*.[62] One must interpret this statement with equal care. We know Jerome possessed a powerful intellect, and was an untiring reader, a scholar, and a prolific writer and translator.[63] Yet even he, on his own admission, made his *Chronicle* a rushed composition and dictated it with unseemly speed to his stenographer. His carelessness and haste are evident from the numerous errors he committed, from his indifference to exact dating even when this was provided by his sources and from his unwillingness or inability to fill in obvious gaps in those sources.[64] His research for his *Chronicle*, then, was at best superficial[65] and presumably consisted of taking cursory notes from the sources available of whichever facts or anecdotes interested him, after which the consulted work would be firmly set aside. If, therefore, one is to maintain that Victor followed a similar *modus operandi*, one should infer that Victor's was similarly superficial.[66]

In conclusion it seems that if one concurs with den Boer, Dufraigne *et al.*, one has to accept that Victor used a substantial

number of sources including Suetonius, Tacitus and several unknowns and, at least in writing the first eleven sections (thirteen Teubner pages) of his *De Caesaribus*, that he hopped from one to another of these often extensive accounts. During this process he made a number of historical errors. From his recollections of the general historical tradition further errors accrued. Eutropius, in turn, also made use of the same sources and tradition and must have copied Victor for some, if not all, of their closely paralleled passages and common mistakes.

Dessau's view, on the other hand, remains both more economical and more logical. Victor followed and adorned with his own vocabulary and reflections one main source (the K.G.) which Eutropius reproduced more faithfully.[67] This would readily explain their undoubted similarities of expression, common selection of facts and, in particular, those striking errors which they alone shared and which they might have obviated by consulting any reliable source. Even Dufraigne, when confronted by the most notable of these common errors, is compelled to admit that they reveal the existence of a common source.[68]

Nevertheless this does not mean that all the material in the *De Caesaribus* or in Eutropius' *Breviarium* need derive from the K.G. As Nixon has pointed out: "All the extant histories, epitomes and chronicles of the fourth century have points in common. There seems to have been a common pool of information about the past which was utilized by each author according to his needs and objectives."[69] It was presumably from this general pool of information as well as from his recollections (occasionally faulty) of earlier authors and discussions with colleagues and others that Victor rounded out his basic account. Finally he infused the results of his own experiences and reflections, and it is this which sets the *De Caesaribus* apart from the other epitomes and chronicles of the fourth century.[70]

# 3

## THE EMPERORS AND THE SENATE

"The eternal duration of empire, the peace of nations, my safety and yours, rest on the security of the senate. This order, which was instituted under due auspices by the Father and Founder of the city, and which has lasted without interruption and without decay from the Kings down to the Emperors, we will bequeath to our descendants, as we have inherited it from our ancestors. For you give the state its senators and the senate gives it its princes."[1]

These are noble words when taken out of context. They were supposedly spoken by Otho to his rebellious soldiers in AD 69 and only after he had paid them 5,000 sesterces each. The senate, which had managed Rome on the basis of its supreme *auctoritas*, its monopoly of high office and the judicious use of bribery and patronage for more than four centuries, was finally and irrevocably dispossessed after a century of anarchy and twenty years of bitter civil wars. Its victor was the shrewdest and perhaps the most ruthless of Rome's military adventurers. Thereafter, despite fine words and protestations,[2] the truth about the empire was well known and Tacitus chronicled it in the first two chapters of his *Annals*: "Augustus, when the world was wearied by civil strife, subjected it to empire under the title of *princeps* . . . Augustus won over the soldiers with gifts, the populace with cheap corn and all men with the sweetness of peace, and so grew greater by degrees while he concentrated in himself the functions of the senate, the magistrates, and the laws."

This lesson was not forgotten by later generations of Romans and over two centuries after Tacitus' works appeared, Aurelius Victor began his short history of the empire with the words:

> "In about the 722nd year of the city, the custom originated at Rome of obeying one man absolutely. For Octavian . . .

> because the victory of his party had been exploited with restraint, was granted the *cognomen* Augustus by decree of the senate. He won over the soldiers with bribes and the populace by appearing to attend to the grain supply; the rest he subdued without difficulty."[3]

Almost four centuries had elapsed since Augustus had refashioned the Roman state, and republicanism was no longer conceived of as a viable alternative to monarchy. Indeed, Victor felt that the only opportunity for a resuscitation of the previous form of government had been lost forever after the assassination of Caligula in AD 41. Then Cassius Chaerea had acted with real Roman *virtus* and his deed, so Victor avers, might have been a repeat of that of Brutus in ejecting Tarquinius if only the army had been in the hands of *Quirites* rather than of foreigners or barbarians. For Victor liberty had been lost because of self-indulgence, sloth and moral failure. But in so brief a work there was neither need nor space for Victor to analyse the *libertas* which had disappeared.[4] The monarchy had become an established and accepted fact: one might admire the past but one must acquiesce in the present; one might pray for good emperors but one had to endure whoever ruled.[5] Republicanism, therefore, was merely the object of sentimental nostalgia. None the less admiration continued for 'heroes' such as the earlier Brutus and for his descendant and Cassius who were responsible for Caesar's assassination, and probably became a stock-in-trade of the rhetorical schools.[6] *Exempla* of this kind could readily be trotted out whenever an unpopular emperor was assisted from the throne by violent means.

From Augustus' time onwards imperial propaganda was directed towards one end, that of making the ruling emperor (or emperors) appear as the source of all state activities and more particularly of all successes, military, political or economic.[7] Suetonius, too, had a profound effect on subsequent generations. Imperial biography was fully in keeping with the manifest importance of the emperors and biography practically displaced history in the second and third centuries AD.[8] In the fourth century, following the autocratic tendencies of Diocletian and his successors, the emperor was even more clearly the central figure in the state and thus in any kind of historical writing.[9] The old, publicized ideal of the emperor as *primus inter pares* had disappeared. In Ammianus he was *orbis totius dominus* or *orbis terrarum dominus*;[10] in Festus' *Breviarium* he appeared as *totius orbis regnator* or *dominus rerum*;[11] for Victor he

was *rector gentium* or *summus rector.*[12] As a necessary corollary of this the emperor was widely regarded not only as a symbol of Rome's greatness but also as the agent responsible for whatever was wrong in the state. Accordingly Ammianus "blamed him for the abuses of government, which in the propaganda are either ignored or absorbed by other functionaries".[13] Ammianus was not the first writer to do so. Victor's views coincide.

For Victor the individual is impotent,[14] bad administrations are supported through fear[15] and consequently the emperor must be virtuous, and an example to all. This theme is well-worn: it goes back to Homer and was transmitted through the rhetorical schools, and the effect was not wasted on Victor.[16] In an anecdote told about Trajan he writes:

> "He was so confident of his integrity that when he gave the praetorian prefect ... the dagger that was the symbol of his office, as was customary, he warned him frequently, 'I am entrusting you with this for my protection, if I govern properly, if I do not, use it on me,' for it would not be right for the ruler of all to make errors."[17]

The story may derive from the K.G. but if so Victor chose to repeat it and added his own edifying comment: *quod moderatorem omnium vel errare minus fas sit.*

On several occasions Victor returns to this theme. While discussing Trajan's exemplary reign the author notes that "there is nothing good or bad in the state which cannot be turned into its opposite by the character of those in power".[18] Further on he informs us that Septimius Severus was aware that crimes are committed because of the faults of the state's leaders or factions.[19] Those actions which disgrace the humble and the powerful alike are worse for an emperor who regulates governments, armies and even vices.[20] Again, when he describes Constantine's destruction of Maxentius' tyranny, Victor writes:

> "No one is more popular or admired than those who have driven out tyrants and their reputation will be even greater if they themselves are moderate and restrained. On the other hand the hearts of the people are offended more grievously if they are frustrated in their expectations of improvement and their burden of troubles remains despite the removal of a vicious ruler."[21]

Finally, in summing up Constantine's reign, Victor concludes:

> "Everything would have appeared to have been done according to divine principles if he had not allowed access to public office

> to men unworthy of it. Now although this occurs rather frequently, nevertheless in the case of an emperor with an excellent character and at a time when the state enjoys the highest standards of morality, even though these faults are small, they are more conspicuous and therefore easily censured. To be sure, they often create greater harm because, on account of the esteem of their author, they are readily accepted as virtues and are an inducement to imitation."[21]

Several emperors, in Victor's estimation, were exemplary: Augustus, Vespasian and Titus, Trajan, Antoninus Pius, Marcus Aurelius, Septimius Severus, Alexander Severus, Aurelian and Probus. That is not to say they were all faultless, but in those cases where their faults are cited these either appear minor if weighed against their virtues or are explained away. For example, Vespasian's weakness for money is described as untrue (9.6), while Trajan's addiction to wine is shown to have been controlled by him (13.10). Antoninus Pius was not energetic in war, but that was because he was not a glory-seeker, and foreign nations feared him nevertheless (15.5). Septimius Severus' initially excessive clemency and subsequent cruelty and harshness are justified (20.7; 20.10).[23]

Diocletian, Constantine and Constantius II, although generally commended, seem to have been placed in a slightly lower category by Victor. The first-mentioned is, indeed, highly praised by Victor but he demonstrated a number of unacceptable vices (as did Galerius and Constantius I). Constantine and Constantius II are described in glowing terms, too, but apart from Constantine's excessive ambition and munificence (40.2; 40.15) he and his son shared that unforgivable weakness noted above, they allowed unworthy men to hold powerful public offices (40.20; 42.24-25). There are some surprises in Victor's list of 'good emperors'. Septimius Severus is treated extremely well but the K.G. seems to have been quite kind to him, as Eutropius' account shows,[24] and he was a fellow countryman of Victor. Alexander Severus seems to have been idealized in the K.G.[25] and certainly was in the *H.A.* Probably Victor was deceived by a fabricated tradition and may even have contributed to it unwittingly.[26] The reason is not too difficult to discern: the state apparently enjoyed a renaissance under Alexander, as the events of 238 demonstrate,[27] and its members fashioned the tradition.

It was presumably this same senatorial tradition which saddled Gallienus with the disasters of the sixties and defamed him.[28] For Victor this emperor was the yardstick by which all the worst

emperors would be measured since emperors and the best of men are judged by mankind on the basis of the glory of their lives rather than by their titles.[29] No emperor is vilified by Victor at all as much as Gallienus. The list of his faults seems endless and surpasses that of any other 'bad emperor' in the *De Caesaribus*.[30] The emperor was blamed for all the disasters which unhappily coincided in his turbulent reign, even the plague (33.5). Again the reason is clear: by means of the so-called Edict of Gallienus the emperor insulted senators by forbidding them to follow a military career or have anything to do with the army.[31] Eutropius, who is also critical of Gallienus and his father, at least realized that the misfortunes of the reign may have been attributable to bad luck (*infelicitate*) and states that Gallienus ruled *primum feliciter, mox commode, ad ultimum perniciose*. Nevertheless he adds: *diu placidus et quietus: mox in omnem lasciviam dissolutus, tenendae rei publicae habenas probrosa ignavia et desperatione relaxavit*.[32]

On the basis of Victor's selection of facts and anecdotes about the emperors and his personal descriptions and comments[33] one can readily construct a sort of mosaic of what he conceived to be an ideal emperor and a 'bad emperor'. His ideal emperor would be educated, refined, gentle, merciful, just, sensible, intelligent, self-disciplined and energetic. He would take care of and embellish Rome and the provincial cities, enact fair laws, respect Roman traditions, be successful in war, show loyalty to his friends and run an efficient administration by advancing honest and capable officials. On occasions he might even retire from office, like Nerva or Diocletian. Finally, and very significantly, he would respect the senate. Perhaps Victor's clearest general statement on the emperors appears at the end of chapter eight, after the death of Vitellius had been described:

> "All these whom I have briefly touched upon, and especially the family of the Caesars, were so cultivated in the field of letters and eloquence that, if they had not been, with the exception of Augustus, excessive in all kinds of vices, such great accomplishments would certainly have concealed their moderate crimes. Therefore, although it is generally agreed that moral character is pre-eminent, nevertheless both qualities alike are needed in every good man, and especially in the supreme ruler, if at all possible. But if this cannot be, and the design of life must be compromised, at least let him assume the air of refinement and erudition."[34]

This was what Victor found lacking in Diocletian and the Illyrian emperors[35] despite their manifestly outstanding natural

qualities. His description of the tetrarchs should perhaps be compared with that of the *H.A.*: "Four rulers of the world who were brave, wise, kind, completely generous, of one mind regarding the state, very respectful regarding the senate, moderate, friends of the people, reverend, serious and pious, the kind of emperors we have always prayed for." The deficiency of *humanitas* (i.e. *elegantia et eruditio*) which Victor explicitly noted seems to have been tacitly accepted by the *H.A.*[36]

Victor, in common with the other fourth-century epitomators, uses a biographical format which results in generally conventional characterizations. Indeed, he seems to have made up his mind about most of the emperors prior to writing and may even have moulded some material to suit his preconceptions, as for example with Nerva and Septimius Severus. Thus the typically 'bad emperor' would not necessarily be uneducated but he would show lack of *humanitas* in one way or another, as was the case with Tiberius, Caligula, Nero and Gallienus. In general he would be cruel and merciless, unjust, cowardly and indolent, avaricious and sexually aberrant, and above all he would treat the senate badly and even go so far as to execute members of that *amplissimus ordo*. It was this facet, Victor's constant interest in the senate (it is mentioned thirty-five times by him in this short work[37]), which caused one eminent scholar, A. Alföldi, to describe the author as "brimful of senatorial arrogance".[38] Both Starr and den Boer explicitly disagree[39] and the former goes on to say in a succinct and sympathetic summary that Victor's "judgement on the upper classes of the Early Empire was far from flattering". From what follows it will become clear that the estimation of den Boer and Starr is the more accurate one.

**The Senate**

It should be noted at the outset of this investigation that the fourth-century senate of Rome still viewed itself as the *pars melior humani generis*[40] and that its power and prestige had actually grown with the departure of the emperor from Rome and the fact that the prestigious urban prefect was a member of its body[41] and presided over its meetings.[42] A tradition which carefully recorded the attitude of every emperor towards the *patres* had long been in existence and was to continue after the writing of the *De Caesaribus*.[43] Cassius Dio informs us that Titus, a 'good emperor', refrained from executing senators (66.19.1), while Domitian, a 'bad emperor', did not (67.2.4). Nerva and Trajan took oaths not to kill senators (68.2.3; 68.5.2);

M. Aurelius and Pertinax (71.28.2; 72.8.5) did not execute senators, while Septimius Severus broke his oath and did so (74.2.1).[44] Victor was heir to this tradition yet, like Tacitus, another *novus homo*, and Ammianus he could see through some of the social pretences and conventional attitudes of that august body.[45]

While discussing Claudius' acclamation Victor writes that when the senators learned of it they quickly sent out agents to see if they could check the attempt. Nevertheless, the state had been torn apart by strife and all classes gave in as if on command. *Ita Romae regia potestas firmata proditumque apertius mortalium conatus vacuos a fortuna cassosque esse.*[46] Claudius, however, made many excellent decisions, primarily on the advice of the nobility which he respected out of fear. He checked vices at their instigation for, as Victor puts it, stupid people do what their advisors tell them.[47]

Subsequently, Victor praises Vespasian for holding a census in the traditional manner and for purging the senate of its more worthless elements while choosing the best men from the empire to make up its numbers to a thousand *gentes*. Previously he had been hard-pressed to discover two hundred, so many having been murdered through the *saevitia tyrannorum*.[48] The message is clear. The senate should comprise the best men from the empire (Victor was African) and the unworthy should be weeded out. Victor may have been a snob but his upper classes would hold their position through merit, not through heredity: *quasi naturae lege, quae crebro tamquam ex industria malos e bonis, agrestes ex doctioribus et ceteros huiuscemodi seu contra gignit.*[49] Vespasian, himself a senator but of a new family, was widely held to be *nobilis* because of his energy and exploits in civil and military matters.[50]

But the emperor must also be merciful to the senators. Hence Victor retails the story of two senators caught plotting against Titus and condemned by their peers. Titus pardoned them, the action of a 'good emperor', after taking them to the games, making them sit on either side of him and handing them each in turn a gladiator's sword. "Do you see," said Titus, "that the imperial power is granted by Fate and it is senseless to dare a crime either in hope of acquiring power or in the fear of losing it?"[51] The anecdote comes from Victor's source, the lesson is probably aimed at Constantius. By showing understanding and consideration to that *amplissimus ordo* might he not enjoy a reputation similar to that of Titus and be hailed as the *generis humani deliciae*?

Trajan, too, though he hailed from Spain, was still a member of

that *amplissimus ordo*. His final act, according to Victor, was to try to return to Italy when the senate requested him to do so. The story may not be authentic but it does reveal what the author felt should be the relationship between the emperor and the senate. The emperor should respect the senate's wishes and do his best to carry them out.

Victor's first real criticism of the senatorial class is somewhat veiled. He notes with disapproval the fact that Hadrian built himself a palace near Tivoli and busied himself with feasts, statues, paintings and all the other trappings of luxury and excess "as is the custom of those who are fortunate and rich".[52] Victor did not belong to that group and disliked such frivolous occupations. The chapter concludes with the strange story that Hadrian ordered a large number of senators to be executed by Antoninus and on that account the senate was unwilling to deify Hadrian despite Antoninus' pleas. None the less, when the supposedly dead senators suddenly reappeared, the senate decreed what it had originally refused.[53] It is plain that Victor thought that Antoninus had saved the senators whom his predecessor had ordered executed. That is why, so Victor avers, Antoninus was able to obtain his request and acquired the *cognomen* Pius.[54] The story is repeated in the *H.A.*[55] and undoubtedly belongs to the world of fable, but Victor's inclusion of it reflects his sentiments. Emperors should not execute senators; 'good emperors' did not do so.

The next mention of the senate is short and pointed. On the death of M. Aurelius "the *patres* and the *vulgus*, who in other matters are separated, decreed everything, temples, columns and priests, to this dead emperor alone". In general Victor was not sympathetic to the *vulgus* but in this instance it behaved well, i.e. it did the same as the senate.[56] A similar mention is made of their joint action on the *abolitio memoriae* of Commodus at the end of the following chapter, when the synonymous term *plebes* is used.[57] During the reigns of the Severi, particularly that of Septimius Severus, the senate is passed over in silence. The reason is manifest. Severus hardly treated that august body with kid gloves and his immediate successors did little to change the picture, so Victor is discreet. Only in his heavily eulogized account of Severus Alexander does he write that the emperor, by favouring the jurists Ulpian and Paul, showed himself well-disposed towards the *optimi* and justice.[58] At this juncture Victor pauses to give his lengthy reflections on the decline of Rome.

Victor's subsequent statement continues his theme of a breakdown in Roman traditions. After Alexander's death C. Julius

Maximinus, an unlettered soldier, seized power as the choice of the legions. The senators even approved the choice, for they deemed it dangerous to oppose a man backed by arms.[59] Yet the senate a short time afterwards actually enjoyed a brief period of glory and performed its ancestral functions. Amid the confusion and riots at Rome after the news of Gordian's death had reached the city the senate acted with promptness and vigour to prevent worse atrocities. It first chose a commission (*vices potestatum*), then conscripted troops and appointed two of its own members, Calvinus Balbinus and Clodius Pupienus, joint Caesars.[60] What the author fails to observe is significant. The very titles of the senate appointees denote clear acceptance of the imperial system whereas the appointment of two *principes* may well be an echo of republican usage.

> "The constitutional position of these two Emperors was unique in the history of Rome. Neither had precedence over the other and each was given the dignity of *pontifex maximus*. The settlement was probably an intentional imitation of the consulship but with this important difference, that the duties of government were divided between the two Emperors, Balbinus being entrusted with the civil administration and Maximus appointed to command the army against Maximinus."[61]

Much might have been made by Victor of this clear indication of senatorial resurgence under Severus Alexander but obviously the author did not see the implication of the events and presumably his source was similarly obtuse.

Soon afterwards the African soldiers acclaimed Gordian II (in fact Gordian III) Augustus, and the nobility (i.e. senate) acquiesced. When he had been summoned to Rome the praetorians opposed these actions but were defeated by the senatorial recruits (including gladiators). Meanwhile Pupienus was supposedly active at Aquileia where he defeated and killed Maximinus and his son. But the senatorial resurgence was short-lived: both senate nominees were killed in a military revolt at Rome after reigning a little over three months.[62]

Nevertheless the senate still continued to perform its symbolic functions and in the reign of Decius it decreed Priscus a public enemy.[63] Afterwards it bestowed imperial power on Gallus and Hostilianus and made Volusianus Caesar.[64] But Victor was obviously aware of the vanity of this senatorial prerogative for he remarks that the senate one moment decreed Aemilianus a public enemy and soon after, upon the deaths of Gallus, Hostilianus and Volusianus, it was forced to bow to fortune, *uti solet*, and acclaim

Aemilianus emperor.[65] Subsequently, the senate had to decree Gallienus *Caesar* after his father, Valerian, had been proclaimed emperor by the army.[66] Yet Victor was far more incensed by the actions of his heroic Claudius Gothicus when the latter compelled the senate to deify its *bête noire*, Gallienus.[67] *Quod sane extortum*, writes Victor, using his favourite expression of disgust, "for the crimes of Gallienus will never be concealed as long as cities exist and all wicked men will always be compared with him".[68] This follows Victor's lengthiest and most acrimonious personal intervention in his history. In fact there is no other evidence of Gallienus' deification. The emperor's name was actually erased from many monuments. Victor's story, therefore, is either exaggerated, totally fabricated,[69] or confused because of careless reading of his source. This is not surprising. "The spirit of the historians of the age was entirely senatorial ... historical works lay wholly in the hands of senators and their adherents."[70]

Victor proceeds to inform us that the senate turned its resentment on the supporters and relatives of Gallienus and ordered them dragged headling to the Gemonian Steps. The populace joined them and prayed to the gods of the Underworld to provide a resting place for Gallienus there. Fortunately Claudius gave orders that the survivors should be spared otherwise the *nobilitas* and the *plebes* would have committed even more heinous acts. Again the nobility and the populace are linked: they supposedly suffered equally under the 'bad emperor'. But Victor, plainly shocked by the behaviour of the senators, is at pains to explain or excuse it:

> "Even the senators were roused by the abuse of their own order, which was added to the common misfortune of the Roman world, because he (Gallienus), through fear that by his own indolence the empire might be transferred to the most worthy of the nobility, had been the first to forbid senators to undertake military service and join the army."[71]

As I have stated earlier, this is the major reason why Gallienus was so traduced by Latin writers. Whether by edict or, more probably, by general policy, senators henceforth ceased to play a military role in the empire and it was from the ranks of the soldiers, particularly the Danubian officer corps, that emperors would normally be chosen. This is viewed by Victor, following the Latin tradition, as the final humiliation of the senate. Ammianus generally echoes Victor's reproaches of Gallienus[72] but his use of a Greek source or sources favourable to the emperor compels him at least once to modify the picture.[73]

Claudius II, on the other hand, a 'good emperor' (he was later 'discovered' to be the ancestor of Constantine and thereby of Constantius II), supposedly regarded himself as the senior member of that *amplissimus ordo*, as *senatus atque omnium princeps*.[74] Therefore, according to the Sibylline Books, he felt it was his duty to sacrifice himself for the state. The sacrifice of this model emperor is a fiction. Claudius died of the plague at Sirmium.[75] None the less this fabricated account may have appeared in the K.G. as a variant since the epitomator has the story but adds the identity of the leading senator of the day, (T.) Pomponius Bassus.[76] What is most instructive here is again Victor's choice of material. The worst thing that Gallienus did was to insult the senate. Claudius' best action, in Victor's view, was to give up his life for the state and consider himself *princeps senatus atque omnium*. "So much dearer to good emperors than life itself are the safety of their citizens and their own enduring reputation."[77] Ammianus shares this sentiment: "for the aim of a just emperor (so the philosophers teach) is the welfare and safety of his subjects."[78] Whether Victor is guilty of distorting history deliberately here or accidentally is uncertain but he was indubitably directing his remarks at Constantius II as his following sentence demonstrates: *hoc siquidem Constantius et Constantinus atque imperatores nostri****.

The senate was briefly granted its former prerogative, according to Victor, immediately after the death of Aurelian. Then the army had supposedly invited the senate to elect Aurelian's successor. The senate had apparently informed the soldiers it was their responsibility, but they had again referred the matter back to the senate. What moderation and decency on both sides! Victor is astounded. Such virtue is rare among men and practically unheard of in the army.[79] Aurelian had achieved this by means of sternness and incorruptibility which all goes to show that crises can be overcome by the good qualities of emperors and stable situations ruined by their vices.[80] The glorious *interregnum* which then occurred allowed the senate, so writes Victor, to choose one of its own, Tacitus, as emperor. Practically everyone was happy because the senate had recovered from the unrestrained soldiers its right to elect emperors.[81]

Victor was deluded and fanciful. His 'engaging theme', so it appears, was eagerly seized upon by the author of the *H.A.* and shamelessly developed.[82] In all likelihood the officer corps chose Tacitus, one of their own, at Caenophrurium. But where did the notion of senatorial involvement arise? Tacitus had held the ordinary consulship in 273 and 276[83] and was therefore a member of the

senate. His career may have been similar to that of his colleague in office in 273, Julius Placidianus, who had commanded an army corps in Narbonensis in 269 and subsequently became praetorian prefect.[84] At any rate Victor's source, which clearly knew very little about Tacitus,[85] may have included some such descriptive phrase as *vir consularis*, a point which Victor could readily enlarge upon and adapt to his idea of what the *interregnum* meant. Further fiction ensues when Victor notes that Florianus, Tacitus' 'brother' (in reality his praetorian prefect) seized power without consulting the senate or the soldiers.[86]

After the death of Quintilian's successor, Probus, Victor returns to the subject of the notorious "Edict of Gallienus". Here he makes it abundantly clear that he realized that the senate itself was largely responsible for its own downfall:

> "Hereafter (i.e. 282) the power of the military grew and the senate's prerogative and right to designate an emperor was snatched away up to our own day. It is uncertain whether the senate itself desired this through apathy or because of fear or through its hatred of strife. Indeed, military service, which had been lost through the Edict of Gallienus, could have been restored while the legions were modestly submissive and Tacitus ruling, nor would Florianus have rashly seized power and the empire would not have been granted to anyone, however good, by the decision of the common soldiers if that most splendid and noble order had been serving in the army. Nevertheless, while they enjoyed their leisure and at the same time feared for their riches and considered the use of these riches and their abundance more important than immortality, they paved the way for the soldiers and almost for the barbarians to dominate them and their descendants." (37.5-7)

The senate missed its chance to have any control of the army and thus gave up its opportunity to influence the selection of emperors. It had proven weak and selfish and had thereby allowed the army to continue to be administered by uncouth, unlettered military men like Magnentius, Vetranio, Nepotianus and Silvanus, some of whom (Magnentius and Silvanus) were actually of barbarian extraction.

This "highly significant" passage is more a reflection of fourth-century thought than an accurate estimation.[87] The process of senatorial debilitation had begun as early as 133 BC, had accelerated in the first century BC and merely culminated in the third century AD. Doubtless the senate still cherished fond illusions of power and prestige and in 238 such illusions became a reality, though short-lived. Victor, however, is clearly deluded in considering that any real

improvement in the position of the senate occurred under Tacitus and that this felicitous situation terminated suddenly with the assassination of Probus. Unable to adduce any positive evidence, the author had recourse to rhetorical commonplaces in blaming the senate for losing its golden opportunity because of its sloth and addiction to luxury. Gallienus, too, had become a useful senatorial scapegoat whom Victor could neatly (if unrealistically) contrast with the gentle senator-emperor, Tacitus, under whom, so we are told, the legions behaved with disciplined calm.

It has been pointed out by den Boer that Victor's historical focus is increasingly on the relationship between the emperor and the senate and that this should cause no surprise since the problem was still relevant in his own time.[88] A similar notion had occurred to Alföldi who considered that Victor was really depicting the current struggle of the nobles for power.[89] Nevertheless two questions supervene. What power were the nobles fighting for, and was Victor truly representative of that order?

First, it would appear from the writings of the class in the fourth century that its main concern was to preserve the powers and prerogatives which it already possessed. In those provinces which senators regularly governed, in Italy and Africa, their political, social and economic influences coincided. Victor is correct, it seems, in writing that they preferred *otium* to public office, but when in office they apparently used their powers to protect and foster their private interests. They maintained and were interested in maintaining their dominant economic and social standing at Rome, in Italy and in Africa.[90] There is no hard evidence that they desired to follow military careers or aspired to loosen the military stranglehold on the throne at this time. Indeed, there were ample opportunities for the more energetic senators to perform public service, as Symmachus' career demonstrates,[91] and they enjoyed several important fiscal and legal privileges in the mid-fourth century. These comprised freedom from extraordinary levies and *sordida munera*, immunity from torture, and the jurisdiction of the urban prefect if sued on criminal or civil charges.[92] Of these the most important privilege was to be relieved of curial taxation and responsibilities; scores of *curiales* sought entry into the senatorial order for this reason. Finally, the senators enjoyed considerable prestige and honour whether they performed public service or not.[93] There were, of course, certain responsibilities and financial obligations to which the order was subject. All but those of the highest rank were expected to attend

provincial or diocesan assemblies. Senators were obliged to attend senate meetings, though standing permission to be absent was frequently granted to senators who preferred to live in the provinces. Financial obligations included occasional levies of horses and recruits, a gift of gold (*aurum oblaticium*) to the emperor on his accession and at five-year intervals thereafter, and a small surtax (*gleba* or *follis*) on their lands. In addition, and more seriously for the less wealthy, quaestors, praetors and suffect consuls were expected to pay for games at Rome and praetors (from Constantius II's time) at Constantinople. Members of the high aristocracy vied with one another in the splendour (and expense) of these games and complaints from the poorer senators caused the emperors periodically to curb such extravagance so that by the century's end the poorest were compelled to perform only the cheapest of such shows, the quaestorial games. Finally, senators were expected to attend the games they provided or pay a fine of 50,000 *modii* of wheat to the public granaries of Rome.[94] In view of the great desire of the middle class to join the ranks of the senatorial order it is clear that the privileges and perquisites it enjoyed more than outweighed the duties and responsibilities it was compelled to undertake.

The second point concerns whether Victor was representative of the senatorial order. Den Boer believes that Victor was a senator when he wrote the *De Caesaribus* and "proud of his senatorial rank, but in moderation". That is highly improbable.[95] Victor doubtless aspired to join that august body, an aspiration which would make the relationship between emperor and senate personally relevant to him, but he does show considerable moderation in his attitude towards the senate. Hence he could both criticize those of humble birth who reached high position and behaved with excessive arrogance and ambition, and also express surprise that many people (i.e. of his own standing) considered the nobility arrogant. He proceeds to inform his readers that nobles, mindful of their patrician origins, really had some right to be pre-eminent as a compensation for those burdens with which they were afflicted. According to Tacitus, Asinius Gallus argued along the same lines in the senate in AD 16 and gained assent by means of his specious phrases and confessions of failings with which his audience sympathized.[96] None the less, Victor could also write soon afterwards that it was common opinion that adversity taught men to be good and sensible whereas those who had always been fortunate tended to judge others by their own experiences and were less considerate.[97] To my mind this demonstrates unequivocally

that Victor was not representative of that leisured and privileged class but had known at least some of the difficulties and adversities to which he here alludes. Eutropius, on the other hand, is quite different. Possibly because of what den Boer describes as a "senatorial sense of honour" he is never critical of the senate and conscientiously describes the lineage of most of his emperors and their *consecratio* (or lack of it) by the senate.[98]

It appears, then, that Victor, like his contemporary Ammianus, had a somewhat ambivalent attitude to the nobility. He admired and respected it for its traditions, its culture, its splendour. It represented for him the ancient order, *mos maiorum*, Rome as it ought to be, the class to which he aspired. Although he acknowledged the imperial monarchical system he felt not only that it was the right of the senate to elect emperors (*senatui imperium creandi ius principis ereptum* [37.5]; *legendi ius principis proceres recepissent* [36.1]), but also that it was its duty. Thus Victor criticized its feeble abdication of this duty, not its privileged position. He clearly recognized the short-sighted self-indulgence of the senators, their preoccupation with pleasures, their inertia and cowardice. For this he censured them. It was understandable and permissible that they should enjoy the rewards of their position but this should not interfere with their traditional obligations and responsibilities. Yet he was realistic enough to realize that it was futile for an unarmed senate to oppose a general with an army at his back.[99] Thus it was not without reason that he noted in the second sentence of his work that Augustus won over the soldiers with donatives and the mob with his apparent concern with the grain supply, and thereby subdued the rest (including the senate) without difficulty.

What Victor would have liked to see was a just, cultured emperor of good character who would show deference to the senate. This, in turn, should be revitalized, should comprise the best men of the provinces as well as of Italy (as it did under Vespasian) and should elect the emperors and energetically manage the affairs of the empire, both military and civil. He, of course, hoped to play *his* part some day. The notion was a pipedream, despite Constantine's employment of many senators in his administration. It was the army that counted and Victor was painfully aware of this. But this awareness did not preclude hopes, or perhaps dreams, of a happier state of affairs, a return to the 'democratic' days (in aristocratic terms) of Antoninus Pius or Marcus Aurelius.[100] Victor opted for a turning back of the clock, a return to an earlier (and hypothetical)

situation, in effect something quite impracticable. The senate, on the other hand, had by the middle of the fourth century become comfortably complacent, as Victor himself notes.[101] It "was still a hereditary governing class whose pre-eminence had not been undermined, but rather enhanced, by the changes which had taken place in the political structure of the Roman empire".[102] Thus, in all probability, it neither needed nor wanted change; the *status quo* was altogether too gratifying. One should not expect a former *humilior* and imperial bureaucrat to comprehend this.

Nevertheless Victor's hopes seem to have foreshadowed future trends. In the West the senatorial aristocracy had acquired an enormous amount of landed wealth without real access to imperial authority, whereas the emperors had lost control of that much-needed source of income. The disasters and tensions of the late fourth and early fifth centuries created a situation which Victor could not have foreseen. Partly to protect their interests, partly to satisfy an old senatorial desire for high office and power, the nobility of Italy and Gaul became increasingly involved in imperial politics and this resulted in the usurpations of the senators Attalus in 410 and Jovinus in 411. Three of the ephemeral emperors of the period 455-476 were also western aristocrats, Petronius Maximus, Avitus and Olybrius. In the twilight of the Western Empire more members of its landed aristocracy were willing to do what Victor had hoped for, to forgo their *otium* and undertake their 'traditional' roles in the empire. In the event, it proved nugatory.

At the beginning of his Panegyric, Pliny states explicitly that speeches of this kind served "to make good emperors realize what they were doing and bad ones realize what they ought to do". His speeches appear to constitute a senatorial manifesto of the theory of a good *princeps*.[103] The *De Caesaribus*, in similar manner, might be said to constitute the personal manifesto of Victor, addressed both to the reigning emperor and his successors and to the senate, advising them of their time-honoured responsibilities:

> "If faith in history did not stand in opposition, since it neither allows honourable men to be cheated of the reward of being remembered nor permits an eternal, glorious reputation to the wicked, virtue would be sought in vain, since that true and unique honour might be granted to the worst of men through partiality and impiously snatched from the good."[104]

Victor's pleas did not fall on deaf ears. As one modern scholar writes, it was no accident that Julian appointed him governor of Pannonia and had a bronze statue of him set up. The emperor was impressed by

and had a bronze statue of him set up. The emperor was impressed by Victor as a *vir sobrietatis* and by his arguments, and sincerely sought to turn back the clock, to behave not like a god but like a reasonable and approachable *primus inter pares*.[105] This idea died with him; Festus and Ammianus leave no room for doubt.[106]

# 4

## THE ARMY AND THE BUREAUCRACY

### The Army

"We are accustomed to learn from the works of ancient historians, who were mostly staunch supporters of the senate and opponents of military influences, which rulers they considered 'good' and 'bad'. Looked at from the standpoint of the army, the good and bad rulers often turn out to be quite different . . . it was on the army, in the last resort, that everything depended."[1]

It has been made clear in the preceding chapter that Victor was, in the main, just such a supporter of the senate, and his antipathy towards the army is revealed by over a score of negative comments. Indeed, he does not once make an unequivocally favourable remark about the military. He understood, as had his fellow Romans for centuries, that the army was the dominant factor in the state. This he found deeply distasteful and he may not even have realized to what extent the army was essential to the continued existence of the empire. Seizing upon an idea in his source he noted with pleasure the supposed remark of Probus, that when all parts of the empire had been restored and pacified, soldiers would become superfluous.[2] Perhaps he did not fully comprehend the problem presented by the need for an army strong enough to defend the empire and therefore strong enough to threaten whoever sat on the throne. Augustus certainly had. He created a large professional army but he staffed it with officers whose promotion and advancement depended on their civil, not military, careers, in which loyalty to the emperor was essential.[3] He thus avoided what was to occur in the third century, the creation of a purely professional officer corps divorced from and not loyal to the civilian government.

Victor's caustic comments, echoing those of Tacitus, begin in his first chapter when he informs us that Augustus won over the

soldiers by gifts.[4] Presumably the material was in his source but it is clear that Victor accepted its testimony; the power of the military was an established fact and its susceptibility to rewards had to be put on display. Yet it was in Tiberius' reign, according to Victor, that Rome's military was allowed to run down.[5] It appears that the K.G. was again responsible for this view since Eutropius states that Tiberius ruled with *socordia* and never himself fought, while the Epitomator, though citing the emperor's creation of Cappadocia as a province and the putting down of the Gaetuli, notes the devastation of Armenia, Moesia, Pannonia and Gaul and uses Victor's descriptive phrase *resolutis militiae artibus*.[6] Victor's assessment of Rome's second emperor follows the stereotyped portrayal of him and is hardly to be trusted.

Caligula's reign is more significant. His assassination demonstrated the essential weakness in the army which was to be ruinous for the state. If only the *Quirites* had controlled the army Rome would have enjoyed a repeat of Tarquinius Superbus' ejection by Brutus. Unfortunately their apathy had allowed an influx of foreigners and even barbarians into the army, resulting in wantonness, moral bankruptcy, greed and destruction of liberty.[7] This is the only occasion on which Victor uses the term *Quirites*, subsequently explained as *cives*, and he links it with *Romana virtus*. For him the decline towards barbarism commences with the introduction of barbarians (sc. Germans) into the army. There seems to be little doubt that Victor is thinking of his own day as he writes this. The Pannonian emperors, and particularly Constantine who had been helped to the throne by the Alamannic king Crocus, had accorded rank and favour to numerous German units and generals. Furthermore Sarmatians and barbarians had been incorporated in the new cavalry and infantry wings.[8] Victor serving at Sirmium must have been struck particularly sharply by the barbarian (i.e. German) influence in the army, and possibly he recalled somewhat hazily that Augustus had recruited a band of Germans as his bodyguard.[9] At any event he specifically mentions that it was an Epirote centurion called Vimius who was responsible for finding Claudius and inciting his fellow soldiers, *si sapiant*, to put him on the throne.[10] It was this action, states Victor, that confirmed the monarchy at Rome.[11]

Victor then notes the concealment of Claudius' death by Agrippina and the corruption of the guards who supposedly ensured Nero's accession.[12] What he fails to point out here and on almost all subsequent occasions is that it was the officers of the guards or

armies who made and unmade emperors. In this case it was, in fact, Burrus, the praetorian prefect, who won over the guard with a 15,000 sest. per man donative and aided Agrippina in her designs.[13]

Shortly afterwards Otho is depicted as seizing power by inflaming the guards.[14] The German legions responded by acclaiming Vitellius; the legates of Pannonia and the Moesian *legati*, following the lead of the Syrian troops, *aemuli, ut inter se solent, ne dissimules viderentur*, opted for Vespasian.[15] Victor has here put his finger on the chronic cause of Rome's instability, the preoccupation of the Roman armies with emperor-making and their mutual and pernicious rivalries. He returns to this theme forcefully and explicitly in a later chapter.[16]

Domitian's assassination in AD 96 is the next juncture at which Victor finds himself able to criticize the military. The soldiers were exceedingly angry at Domitian's murder because under him they had received generous benefits at state expense. Furthermore the senate had dishonoured him with a gladiator's funeral and an *abolitio memoriae*. Inflamed by this the soldiers sought his assassins *more suo seditiosius*. They even stirred up war on their own since they resented a change of government *ob amissionem praedarum per dona munifica*.[17] Neither Eutropius nor the Epitomator seems to have been interested in this phenomenon so that one may safely assume that Victor is here expressing his own feelings. Ammianus apparently shared them, for some years later he was to note the *intemperantia militis, quae dispendiis gravibus saepe rem Romanam afflixit*.[18]

A strange series of errors occurs in Victor's account of Nerva's reign.[19] The mistake which concerns us here is the statement that Nerva took office *arbitrio legionum*. In fact, the new praetorian prefects Petronius Secundus and Norbanus, the chamberlain Parthenius, the *a libellis* Entellus and a number of senators made the decision and orchestrated the assassination of Domitian.[20] Eutropius has the facts and two of the names; the Epitomator in general agrees.[21] Victor was confused. The legions remained watchfully quiet throughout the proceedings but the praetorians demanded and obtained the execution of Petronius and Parthenius. Nerva, realizing the damage which had been done to his prestige and perhaps knowing that he was soon to die, wisely adopted Trajan, the governor of Upper Germany, whom he had appointed but a few months before, and proclaimed him Caesar. The other titles and trappings of power were granted to Trajan on January 1, 98. Nerva's plan succeeded: civil war was averted and the legions acquiesced.[22]

For almost a century after Nerva's accession the imperial system functioned smoothly. The senate, but for a brief period under Hadrian, cooperated with the reigning emperor and the armies were either occupied with foreign wars or enjoyed a disciplined peace. Accordingly Victor could cite no example of military turmoil or iniquity and therefore omitted mention of the army. The situation changed after the assassination of Commodus.

Pertinax came to the throne in January 193. Victor described him as a man *moribus antiquissimis, immodice parcus*. No wonder the soldiers murdered him at Didius' behest, "for nothing satisfies them even when the world is exhausted and in ruins".[23] Eutropius rightly blames the praetorians without edifying comment.[24] The reason for Victor's generalized denunciation, for he merely had the same information as Eutropius before him (as his next sentence demonstrates), seems to be his overall antipathy for the military. He is more precise when he informs us that Julianus rose to imperial power relying on the praetorians whose support he had won by large-scale bribery.[25] This authentic fact did not interest Eutropius or the Epitomator, who ignore it, but Dio, Herodian and the *H.A.* carry it.[26] Victor was happy to relate that Septimius Severus dismissed the praetorians immediately upon coming to power because of their murder of Pertinax, his hatred of crimes, his indignation and anger.[27] The real reason was that he could not trust them and he substituted picked Pannonian legionaries, thereby rewarding the latter and ensuring a loyal guard at Rome.

The next mention of troops occurs when Victor briefly discusses the elevation of Macrinus and his son. The legions demonstrate their duplicity by first acclaiming the new emperors, then murdering their own appointees.[28] Victor is here merely repeating his source: Eutropius also notes that both emperors died *seditione militari*.[29] Unfortunately for his theme Victor seems not to have access to further material, since the Epitomator informs us that Macrinus was killed because he restricted the luxury and excessive pay of the army.[30] It is unlikely that Victor would have ignored this additional example of military greed and intemperance had he lighted upon it.

After briefly divulging that Heliogabalus was murdered in the praetorian camp[31] Victor proceeds to the reign of Alexander Severus whom he, following the K.G. it seems, rather fancifully extolled.[32] The popular prince was granted imperial power *militibus quoque annitentibus*. He immediately defeated the Persians and speedily

marched to Gaul which was being devastated by the Germans. There he resolutely suppressed the *rebellious* legions which brought him glory for the moment but subsequently proved his undoing. The soldiers were horrified by his severity (whence his *cognomen* Severus) and cut him down.[33] Perhaps by design Victor had now reached the middle of his work and what he estimated to be the watershed of the empire. He pauses here to reflect at some length on the decline of Rome and what he considered to be the causes:

> "Although he (Alexander Severus) governed for more than thirteen years he left the state strengthened in all respects. From Romulus to Septimius it evolved gradually and stood at its summit, so to speak, through the policies of Bassianus. To prevent its sudden collapse was the task of Alexander. Thereafter, as long as its leaders were more concerned to dominate their fellow citizens than to subjugate foreign peoples and took up arms against each other, they cast down the Roman state headlong, as it were, and good men and bad, the noble and the lowly, even many of barbarian background, were indiscriminately put in power. Indeed, where there is universal chaos and affairs are not conducted in their accepted manner, all think it right, in the manner of the mob, to seize the offices of others which they cannot manage, and they foully corrupt knowledge of the liberal arts. Thus the violence of fortune, once it has acquired uncontrolled licence, drives men on with destructive lust. It was, indeed, kept in check for a long time by virtue, as if by a wall, but, after almost all had been broken by criminal acts, it entrusted the state even to men of lowly birth and inadequate training."[34]

The whole story of Alexander's severity and suppression of the rebellious legions is a myth, almost certainly stemming from the K.G.:[35] Herodian gives quite a different version.[36] Alexander had, in fact, received no military training and numerous revolts had broken out in the east.[37] However, the attribution of his *cognomen* to his severity may be Victor's personal contribution; Victor's statement to that effect is paralleled only in the *H.A.*[38] That work also appears to echo Victor's sentiments regarding a natural break in the course of the history of the empire after which various pretenders seized power amid mutual rivalry.[39] One further point needs to be noted here. Victor's reflections upon the empire, rather than his reliance upon any source, appear to be responsible for his clear understanding that it was the civil wars occasioned by an excessive desire to rule on the part of various pretenders which caused the decay.[40] He may have been thinking of the recent civil wars of his own lifetime. Constans had defeated his brother in 340 only to be defeated and killed by the

barbarian officer Magnentius in 350. That year Vetranio was selected as emperor in Illyricum, although this appears to have been an engineered coup and, in view of subsequent events, connived at by Constantius, and Nepotianus seized power in Rome. The disastrous Battle of Mursa took place the following year when Constantius II won a costly victory over Magnentius which weakened the Roman army for years to come.[41] Magnentius retained Gaul until the summer of 353 when he was utterly defeated and committed suicide. Meanwhile a rebellion of the Jews had broken out in 352[42] and Silvanus subsequently revolted in Gaul in 355.[43] Finally, as the year 360 progressed and while Victor was in the process of writing his *De Caesaribus* rumours of the impending rebellion of Julian must have been one of the main topics of conversation in the bureaucracy at Sirmium. Victor, horrified at the thought of further civil wars, may in fact, in the last few lines of his book,[44] have been addressing himself to Julian. *Mortalium conatus vacuos a fortuna cassosque*.[44]

Following the death of Alexander the army placed Maximinus on the throne. Victor notes the transition with disapproval, for the new ruler *primus e militaribus, litterarum fere rudis potentiam cepit suffragiis legionum*.[46] The senate could only acquiesce since it was perilous for unarmed men to oppose a general with an army behind him. It hardly comes as a surprise, therefore, that Victor's next description of the soldiers is so negative: *milites . . . genus hominum pecuniae cupidius fidumque ac bonum solo quaestu*.[47]

The sad story continues. Pupienus and Balbinus were killed in a military coup;[48] Philip's son was killed in the praetorian camp;[49] Jotapianus died *militum arbitrio*;[50] Aemilius Aemilianus seized power by corrupting the soldiers; Gallus and Volusianus were murdered by their own men "in the hope of greater rewards from Aemilianus".[51] Upon the death of Aemilianus the soldiers made Licinius Valerianus emperor for even though he was *genere satis claro* he was a military man.[52] Yet worse was to follow. Amid the mass of barbarian incursions, Valerian's defeat and capture by the Persians and the onset of the plague, Gallienus indulged himself shamefully at Rome: *qua causa etiam civiles motus longe atrociores orti*.[53] Postumus in Gaul defeated Laelianus but refused to allow his troops to plunder Moguntiacum, which had assisted the latter. They therefore rebelled and killed him; and an ex-blacksmith, Marius, who was not even a distinguished soldier, seized power. "Accordingly everything had totally degenerated so that such men as this ruled and the dignity of all good qualities had become an object of derision."[54]

Victorinus was selected to rule after Marius had been strangled, but his excessive lust was his undoing. A military coup resulted in his death.[55] What comes next is somewhat different from Victor's normal strictures: it is a striking denunciation of the army actuaries whom the author plainly loathes:

> "So powerful were the companies of quartermasters, in whose ranks Attitianus was serving, that their crime succeeded even though they were attempting a difficult task. They are a type of people, particularly nowadays, who are worthless, venal, underhand, rebellious, greedy and, as it were, naturally gifted for committing and concealing frauds. They control the supplies and therefore pose a threat both to those responsible for collecting produce (*utilia curantes*) and to the fortunes of the farmers since they are versed in the opportune bribery of those through whose folly and loss they have amassed their wealth."[56]

Den Boer believes that Victor dwells upon the *actuarii* here, in this unique passage, because they threatened the *boni*, especially since they could influence the army which the *boni* could not after the edict of Gallienus.[57] This does not appear correct. The *actuarii* were military officers or quartermasters in charge of specific functions in the commissariat (e.g. *sarcinalium*, *ex ratiociniis scrutandis*).[58] Collections of the *annona* (here the annual taxes in kind) were the responsibility of curial officials called *procuratores* or *susceptores* who were elected by city councils. These worked in groups whose duty it was to collect separate commodities from village headmen, *praepositi pagorum*, or, at least in Egypt, *exactores civitatis*. The curial collectors were liable for the full amount due, which was probably assessed initially by the *actuarii*. Frontier garrisons were supplied locally, as far as possible, hence the power of the *actuarii* over both curial and village officials and the farmers. The *actuarii* picked up supplies (*pittacia*) from the *mansiones publicae* and distributed them to the troops, hence their power over the latter. A law of Valentinian (*Cod. Just.* 12.38) by which the *actuarii* were held accountable for supplies not delivered within thirty days of the appointed date implies that their graft was widespread and notorious.[59] One *actuarius sarcinalium*, Dynamius, forged incriminating evidence against Silvanus and brought about his downfall; another *actuarius a rationibus scrutandis*, whose accounts were being investigated by Jovian, conscious of his deceit and crimes, fled to the army and stirred up a rebellion against the emperor. Julian, however, seems to have had honest and popular *actuarii*: at his acclamation in

Paris the *Petulantes* and *Celtae* begged that certain of them be given provincial governorships, a request denied by the new emperor.[60] Corruption in the commissariat was hardly a recent phenomenon: Agricola made a serious attempt to stamp it out in Britain in AD 78.[61] In the third century and after, however, corruption appears to have invaded all aspects of the bureaucracy.[62]

In this important passage the very vehemence of Victor's feelings seems to indicate that the author had personal acquaintance with the actuaries' machinations and crimes. Victor's father may have had dealings with the *actuarii* as a local collector but it is more likely that he felt their pernicious influence as a farmer.[63] In that case Victor must have heard a good deal about their rapacity. Furthermore, as an imperial official, Victor would certainly have known of their reputation and may have witnessed the power of the actuaries over the farmers and those local officials responsible for collecting the *annona* and delivering it to the *mansiones publicae*.[64] It is probable, then, that he used the term *utilia curantes* as a general description covering all those local functionaries. What is significant here is Victor's overwhelming display of bitterness and moral indignation which must have been caused by something far more immediate and urgent than an objective observation. It was not the *boni* (or *optimi*) who were threatened by the actuaries, as den Boer believes, but the farmers and those who collected the necessities from them. These were the people who had most to lose and enjoyed the least protection.

Victor straightway reverts to his more general theme. Victoria, on the death of her son Victorinus, set Tetricus up as Gallic emperor by means of massive bribery of the legions.[65] Soon afterwards Gallienus himself fell victim to his own troops whose officers had been deceived by Aureolus' cunning stratagem.[66] At this point the author is able to distinguish between officers and men, for he notes that it was Aurelian's plan which created the opportunity to cut down the emperor. His death passed unavenged either through ignorance of the identity of the person responsible or because it was for the public good, Victor declares. This conclusion, Victor's own it would appear, is followed by a long, personal disquisition on the decline of moral standards. Men act for themselves rather than for the state, for power rather than for reputation. Thus the meaning of achievements and titles has been corrupted; the man who has acquired power through crime, once he has won his position by force of arms, calls the publicly ruinous oppression of his opponents a

suppression of tyranny.[67]

The author demonstrates here a thoroughly clear-sighted understanding of what had regularly occurred during the imperial period. While we may take issue with his views regarding some of Rome's emperors, we can only concur with his general sentiment that throughout history military success has all too frequently conferred legitimacy on the conqueror. Victor, however, pinned his faith on the ultimate judgement of history, unaware that his own work might be partially responsible for the propagation of certain mendacious inexactitudes which he plainly deplored.

Claudius' rule, so Victor affirms, was approved of and praised by the soldiers. They, upon realizing that everything was in a state of chaos, actually accepted good counsel *fere contra ingenium*.[68] Totally lacking in sympathy for the army, Victor could even construe positive actions negatively. He did so again when he praised Aurelian for punishing greed and embezzlement and those who plundered the provinces (i.e. soldiers and officials). This Aurelian did "contrary to military custom, though he came from their ranks".[69] Finally, in his subsequent description of the supposed *interregnum* following the treacherous assassination of Aurelian he informs us that the legions "on both sides vied in honour and discipline, a rare virtue in men, especially in circumstances of this kind, and practically unheard of among the soldiers".[70]

Wherever they were stationed or fighting the soldiers were unreliable. It mattered little whether their choice as ruler was the unmilitary Tetricus in Gaul or such an outstanding general as Aurelian – the result was the same. The first-mentioned had found his troops seduced by one of his governors, Faustinus, and actually deserted his own army and surrendered to Aurelian.[71] Even Eutropius remarks upon this, adding that Tetricus was not able to endure his troops' constant rebelliousness.[72] Like Aurelian, Probus was a first-class general and emperor who crushed the barbarians in Gaul, Pannonia and Moesia which they had invaded "because our emperors had been killed by the criminal actions of their own men, as were the usurpers Saturninus in the East and Bonosus at Cologne". Probus was himself then killed by his troops because he had used them for drainage work near Sirmium and had allegedly stated that since the empire had been pacified there would soon be no need for them.[73]

The murder of Probus was a monstrous outrage as far as Victor was concerned. His righteous indignation compelled him to focus

upon the emperor he felt responsible for the whole sad situation. It was Gallienus who had prohibited the senatorial class from serving in the army by imperial edict, so Victor affirmed, in order that the imperial power might not be transferred to the best of the nobility. Victor also believed that it was the common soldiers, not the generals, who had referred the choice of emperor to the senate after the assassination of Aurelian. When the senate chose Tacitus the edict might have been repealed and senators could again have served in the army which would have prevented Florianus from seizing power and ensured that no one else obtained the throne on the decision of the common soldiers (*iudicio manipularium*). Here Victor, (followed by the *H.A.*, with modifications), shows a considerable ignorance of the workings of the military hierarchy. It was not the common soldiers who made and unmade emperors but the predominantly Pannonian officer corps which provided the empire with its emperors, first Decius, then practically all those who succeeded Gallienus.[74]

Further examples of the duplicity and greed of the soldiers are enumerated. Severus was deserted by his troops while attacking Maxentius and Galerius had to abandon Italy to Maxentius for fear of the same thing happening.[75] Silvanus, who had rebelled in Gaul relying on the support of his legions, had been deceived by them and killed in a military uprising.[76] It is, therefore, with hearty approval that Victor described Constantine's disbanding of the praetorians after the Battle of the Milvian Bridge in 312. He adds that they had become more suited for factional struggles than for protecting Rome.[77]

As a civilian official in the bureaucracy Victor bitterly resented the power of the generals and officers of the army, the tyranny of its petty functionaries and the uncouthness of the average soldier. Altogether too many of them were actually barbarians or semi-barbarians, *litterarum prorsus expers et ingenio stolidior, idcircoque agresti vecordia pessimus* like Vetranio, born in *locis squalidioribus* such as Upper Moesia.[78] Magnentius, even though he was born in Gaul, was of barbarian (i.e. German) extraction and accordingly of a cruel and fierce disposition.[79] That should not surprise one: the first emperor chosen by the army from its ranks was *litterarum fere rudis*, Maximinus.[80] Victor appears envious, indignant, a jealous protector of the endangered rights of the civilized and educated segments of society. In his sombre meditations over the imperial period he discovers the origin of the disintegration of the soldiers' morality and

morale in the reigns of the early emperors, Augustus and Caligula. Then it was that the troops had first been seduced by bribery and the *Quirites* had ceased to serve in the army because of their *desidia*. Foreigners and barbarians had taken their place. The final phase of this process of disintegration is ascribed by Victor to Gallienus whose supposed edict precluded senators from military service. That, combined with the *desidia* of the senators and their preoccupation with their *otium* and their wealth, had led to the emergence in senior commands of semi-barbarians and barbarians. Victor was not alone in making these criticisms. Julian reproached Constantine for being the first to advance barbarians (Germans) to the consulship but is, in turn, reprimanded by Ammianus (21.10.8) for granting the consulship soon afterwards to Nevitta, a Frank, who was *inconsummatus et subagrestis et crudelis*.

Victor's depiction is not really accurate. In fact he demonstrates a perceptible ignorance of the gradual breakdown of the old legionary system and fails to comprehend the vital role played by his own countrymen, Septimius Severus and his son Caracalla, in changing the nature of the army. Severus had, in effect, been one of several contestants for the throne in 193 and it was the Pannonian soldiers, a rough lot even then, who had fought to make him emperor. They therefore expected to be rewarded. The praetorians, on the other hand, had made Julianus emperor and had opposed Severus. He could hardly trust them. Accordingly he solved two problems simultaneously by disbanding the guard and by reforming it with men picked from the Pannonian legions.[81] It was these same Pannonian and other Danubian troops who subsequently defeated Niger's eastern army and the British-Gallic forces of Albinus. They had been battle-trained in the wars of M. Aurelius and had achieved some prominence, but it was from the reign of Septimius Severus onwards that their potential to make and unmake emperors stems.

The true horrors of civil war were not unknown to Victor, who had lived through the turmoils of Magnentius' rebellion, the (probably staged) revolt of Vetranio and the ruinous seizure of Rome by Nepotianus. Hence he praised the lenient conduct of Diocletian after the latter had come to power:

> "This policy was new and almost unheard of in human memory, that in a civil war no one was deprived of his property, reputation and rank, for we are pleased if a war is waged altogether honourably and mildly and if a limit is placed upon exiles, proscriptions and even executions and slaughter."[82]

Other writers also noted Diocletian's initial clemency, including Lactantius who was generally a bitter denigrator of that emperor.[83] But what impressed Victor just as much as Diocletian's moderation was the harmony he inspired in his fellow tetrarchs which forestalled the sort of civil conflicts which erupted after his abdication.[84] Victor's personal experiences possibly compelled him to warn Julian against embroiling Rome in a further round of *intestinae clades* which would culminate in the *fragor status Romani*.[85]

In summary then, Victor seems to present three main motifs in discussing the army. First, its barbarization, which began with the ranks in the early days of the empire and was caused by the *desidia* of the citizens and which progressed to the officer corps after the Edict of Gallienus. This subsequent stage is ascribed to that emperor's *socordia* and the senate's selfishness, fear or *desidia*. It produced commanders who might be semi-literate and semi-rustic or even totally uneducated and *stolidi ingenii*. Second, the army had become corrupt and venal, its units were ready to sell themselves to the highest bidder. If not suitably rewarded or, conversely, if compelled to undertake unpopular construction tasks, the various armies would quickly replace their emperors, generally without heeding the consequences. Finally, in the latter connection, the army groups were held responsible for the destructive and almost incessant series of civil wars from Alexander Severus' time onwards which *Romanum statum quasi abrupto praecipitavere*. Victor had perceived that the greatest danger to the continued existence of the empire lay with the professional army which had discovered its indispensability and was thereby able to impose its terms on emperor and senate alike.[86] For Victor the nationality of its members, their lack of education and their "rustic stupidity" were contributory factors in the army's general instability. What is unfortunate, from our point of view, is Victor's inability to give the army (as opposed to the emperors) credit for its numerous military successes, its incredible engineering and construction feats, and its major role in Romanizing the various provinces of the empire.

**The Bureaucracy**

A further object of Victor's interest and criticism was, not unnaturally, the imperial bureaucracy. In Claudius' reign the author maintains that the emperor's administration was laudable at the beginning because he, through apprehension, accepted good advice, especially that of the nobility: *quippe stolidorum ingenia proinde agunt*

*uti monitores sunt*.[87] That changed, however, when his wife Messalina and his freedmen gained control over him.[88] This may well be Victor's first hint to Constantius that wives are not to be trusted in affairs of state and that he must be careful in his selection of and reliance upon his *apparitores*.[89]

Vespasian's reign was clearly one of good government as far as Victor was concerned. Despite inheriting a bankrupt treasury and an empire in which so many cities had suffered severely the emperor undertook enormous restoration projects without causing the ruin of the farmers, which demonstrated his prudence rather than his avarice.[90] Furthermore, by advancing Titus to the post of praetorian prefect he made that post second in rank to the position of emperor. That was all very well under a sensible emperor like Vespasian, but in his own time, Victor notes, "when the integrity of public affairs is despised and the uneducated are mixed with the well-bred, stupid men with the intelligent, many have made the office a sinecure, a source of arrogance to the poor, given to the worst possible individuals and rapacious under the guise of collecting provisions."[91] By Constantine's reign the most important fiscal responsibilities had been granted to the praetorian prefects. These responsibilities included the collection of the *annona* which represented the largest source of public revenue. Abuses in collection were widespread and had become a commonplace in fourth-century writers. It is to this that Victor here alludes.

There is again praise for the bureaucracy in Trajan's reign but once more it is the emperor who is the major beneficiary. He reorganized Rome's grain supply, revived and consolidated the bakers' guild and moved closer the intermediate stations on the public post:

> "This reasonably useful public service has been turned into the ruination of the Roman world by the avarice and arrogance of posterity, except that in these years (357-359), through the remedies of the prefect Anatolius, resources have proved adequate for Illyricum. Indeed, there is nothing good or bad in the state which cannot be reversed by the character of those in charge."[92]

The accuracy of Victor's remark about Anatolius is confirmed by Ammianus[93] who, it will be remembered, was very appreciative of Victor's level-headedness.[94]

Victor also realized how easy it was for those who had the emperor's ear to line their own pockets or fail to perform their duties. He had briefly referred to this in discussing the reign of Claudius, a notorious example, and again he mentions it when describing

Septimius Severus. The latter was implacable concerning crimes but rewarded the industrious. Furthermore he did not permit even small acts of robbery to go unpunished and carefully monitored his closest associates for he was an experienced man who understood that such transgressions took place because of the weakness of commanders or through the actions of a group.[95] The basic statement concerning Severus' qualities almost certainly stems from the K.G., as a confrontation with the text of Eutropius demonstrates,[96] but the choice of material served the double purpose of describing and praising Severus while at the same time intimating, presumably to Constantius, that this was to be expected of a good emperor.[97] After all, "people defend slack reigns more readily than useful ones because of their desire to sin with impunity".[98]

Aurelian's reign was stern but successful. Under him denunciations of private citizens for tax evasion by fiscal agents or private informers were allegedly eliminated, their accounts and records burned and an amnesty decreed. In addition he savagely prosecuted those guilty of greed, embezzlement and extortion in the provinces. For this reason his confidential secretary, who had profited through the criminal use of his office and realized he was about to be caught, cunningly composed a list of officers allegedly marked down for execution and handed it to one of them. They, in fear, assassinated Aurelian.[99] Again the story was probably in the K.G.[100] but only Victor connects Aurelian's death with his sternness in repressing embezzlement and extortion. The *H.A.* picks up on this theme of Aurelian's sternness subsequently but without the connection.[101] Neither Eutropius nor the Epitomator gives the details of the plot and both omit Victor's antecedent causes. Similarly Victor is the only writer to moralize upon the results of Aurelian's reign:

> "So much had that man achieved by his severity and incorruptibility that the news of his murder brought death to its authors, fear to the wicked, a stimulus to the doubtful, a cause of regret to all good men, an excuse for insolence or ostentation to no one."[102]

Victor's next comment on the administration deals with the imposition of that "great evil the tribute" on part of Italy. All Italy, Victor remarks, had paid a moderate amount to support the army and the emperor. Now a new taxation law was introduced. "What was surely tolerable in those days of restraint has become ruinous in these [turbulent] times."[103] The author uses the expression *his tempestatibus* (contrasted with *illorum temporum* in the first half of

the sentence) to imply stormy times and to denote indignation with the conditions of his own day.[104] Moreover the use of the term *sane* is another plain indication of Victor's sentiments.[105] He felt, probably quite unreasonably, that the bureaucracy had declined since Diocletian's day. That emperor had supposedly restrained his officials by means of extremely fair laws and had disbanded the vicious *frumentarii* or secret police. These, according to Victor, appear to have been appointed to investigate and report rebellions in the provinces. In reality they criminally fabricated charges, inspired terror in all, especially those in the remotest districts, and shamefully seized everything. Victor lamented the fact that the *agentes in rebus* of his day were all too similar.[106] Finally, Diocletian carefully and solicitously looked after Rome's grain supply and the welfare of those on state salaries, promoted respectable men and punished criminals. These actions, as far as Victor was concerned, resulted in a greater concern for honesty.

The *agentes* seem to have acquired their bad reputation under Constantius II when several members incurred considerable notoriety for their intelligence work, but they were overshadowed in that suspicious emperor's reign by the notaries who clearly enjoyed greater political and social prominence.[107] Some of these, like Paulus and Gaudentius, were responsible for spying on and arresting political suspects; others, like Decentius, were trusted to take command of army groups in difficult situations. One wonders, therefore, why Victor made no reference to the notaries yet felt free to name and stigmatize both the *actuarii* and the *agentes in rebus*. Perhaps Victor did not feel personally threatened by either of the latter groups because he was substantially senior in the bureaucratic hierarchy. Such was not the case with the powerful notaries.

Victor's views on the restrained nature of Diocletian's bureaucracy and its demands were not shared by the emperor's contemporary, Lactantius, who bitterly complained about the subdivision of the empire and the provinces. This necessitated a monstrous increase in the army and the bureaucracy and was accompanied by proscriptions, exactions and general corruption. For Lactantius the futile edict of Maximum Prices was a consequence of Diocletian's "iniquities".[108] Nevertheless Diocletian has left over twelve hundred rescripts or edicts in which he undertook to suppress fraud, protect the weak, the slaves, women, debtors, poor men against the rich, labourers against their masters. He also undertook a total economic reorganization of the empire, abolishing the mass of

unwieldy and inequitable local practices and substituting a system of land tax and poll tax based upon land and manpower which, however, still took into consideration local variations in custom.[109] Even Lactantius had to admit that his reign was singularly felicitous "as long as he kept his hands from the blood of the just" (i.e. Christians)[110] and Eutropius succinctly notes that Diocletian providently organized and arranged many things which were still in effect in his day, i.e. in 369.[111]

When Victor came to write about Constantine and his son, the reigning emperor Constantius, he had to be cautious. While gentle criticism might be accepted, outspoken censure would not.[112] Thus Constantine is credited with limiting fiscal oppression but he is also criticized for admitting to public office men who were unworthy of it. This may happen all too often, observes Victor, yet when a man of Constantine's standing permits it he encourages others to imitate him.[113] Indeed, his son Constans was detested because of the depravity of his ministers and his greed. Eutropius' account concurs, that of the Epitomator notes that Constans selected provincial governors on the basis of what they would pay rather than on merit.[114] The notion that the emperor should set an example has been discussed earlier, but Victor was so intent upon this that he could not resist finishing his work with a restatement: "Constantius realizes that the tranquillity of the state is regulated by the way of life of good rulers." This is where I consider the *De Caesaribus* originally concluded.[115] Soon afterwards, however, Victor threw in his lot with Julian and then added a postscript to his book:

> "These great, renowned qualities of his have been marred by his lack of care in appointing provincial governors and military commanders, by the worthless character of the majority of his ministers and, in addition, by his neglect of all men of quality. And to end on a brief note of truth, just as no one is more outstanding than the emperor himself, so no one is more frightful than the majority of his subordinates."

Victor is just as aware as the author of the *H.A.* that biographies of living emperors cannot be written *sine reprehensione*.[116] Had Constantius lived to defeat Julian, then the author realized he would suffer the regular fate of those who supported usurpers, despite Constantius' pardon of Vetranio. It is therefore reasonable to infer that Victor believed what he wrote in his postscript and was giving a piece of gratuitous advice to Julian, whose propagandistic Letter to the Athenians, written soon after he had met Victor and presumably read the *De Caesaribus*, echoes these views. Victor's condemnation of

bureaucratic corruption and the recent emperors' inability to promote competent or honest men was certainly justified and probably occasioned by numerous instances of personal experience. Corruption had become endemic and other fourth-century writers paint still grimmer pictures.[117] Ammianus described the court of Constantius as *vitiorum omnium seminarium*[118] and subsequently informed the reader that Romanus, Valentinian's *comes Africae*, aided and abetted by his kinsman Remigius, the *magister officiorum*, plundered his province and cunningly deceived the emperor.[119] Mamertinus felt that under Constantius the state suffered financial ruin because of the corruption of its administrators, its lavish court and the fact that the emperor was a victim of the jealousy and intrigues of his servile courtiers. He contrasts the ease of Julian's campaign against the Germans with the difficulty of the fight against the corrupt governors.[120] Rutilius Namatianus lamented that a blind love of gold led to every kind of crime; Sulpicius Severus adds that at the court of Gratian everything was for sale because of the power and licence of the few.[121] The mass of legislation under Constantine and his successors which was aimed at checking official corruption merely proves just how ineffective the law had become in this respect. Indeed it has recently been argued that none of the emperors of the later empire was foolish enough to suppose that the government could combat one of the major aspects of corruption, namely *suffragium*, for it had become an acceptable feature of everyday life. Consequently the emperors from Constantine onwards were not so much concerned with eradicating *suffragium* as with preventing those who utilized the system from escaping their respective *munera*.[122]

Corruption affected all walks of life, but especially the bureaucracy and the army where opportunities abounded.[123] Not even the high nobility were free of it.[124] Victor twice asserts that the prosperity of the state depends on the character of those in power[125] and he returns to this theme in his final summation. It was clearly a matter of importance for him and he did the only thing he could to alter the situation. He praised the efficient prefect Anatolius and those emperors whose administrative reputation stood high, who promoted honest and competent officials. In addition he criticized instances of corruption and whichever emperors promoted unscrupulous and incompetent officials.[126] In Victor's opinion, and one must remember he was a contemporary, Constantine, Constans and Constantius were all guilty on this count. Ammianus concurred:

"The first to open the jaws of those nearest him was Constantine, but it was Constantius who fattened them with the marrow of the provinces."[127] The last-mentioned was too receptive to flattery, *quae res perniciosa vitiorum est altrix*,[128] too trustful of friends and familiars.[129]

Victor's initial design seems to have been to influence Constantius, in as much as he could, to mend his ways with respect to his appointments of civil and military commanders. This could only be done indirectly as long as he owed his allegiance and his career to Constantius.[130] When that was no longer the case Victor, in his postscript, was forthright and frank in criticizing the emperor who had perhaps disappointed him. *Quippe humanae mentes frustratae boni spe asperius offenduntur, cum mutato rectore flagitioso aerumnarum vis manet.*[131] Victor's final statement is sharp and telling: *apparitorum plerisque magis atrox nihil.* It appears that Victor deliberately uses the word *apparitores* as a pejorative.[132] The term denotes not only court flunkeys but also those ministers, governors and commanders who obtained their positions through sycophancy and obsequiousness, *officia quae regere nequeunt.*[133] Clearly Victor believed that the continuity of *Roma aeterna* required the successful defence of the empire but that it also needed internal justice, peace and low taxation.[134]

Julian made numerous attempts to correct abuses and to improve the bureaucracy both before and after his acclamation. His curtailment of corruption in the collection of the *annona* in Gaul allowed him to reduce the standard levy from twenty-five to seven *solidi* per *caput* per year. He reduced the *aurum coronarium*, increased immunity from capitation to those who performed other functions, allowed no indiction to be made without his knowledge and insisted that all charges, including the *cursus publicus*, be inscribed. Furthermore he refused to allow arrears to accumulate and then be written off since he realized this benefited the wealthy. Issues of warrants for the public post were curbed and the *cursus velox* in Sardinia was altogether abolished as an unnecessary drain on the provincials. Finally he drastically cut the number of notaries and *agentes in rebus*.[135] Military and civil appointments were made on the grounds of proven competence and senior government officials were generally professional administrators and intellectuals from whom Julian demanded honesty and hard work. As one scholar puts it: "None pursued this policy so systematically as Julian."[136] Yet even Julian, when faced with the widespread practice of *suffragium*, did not

attempt to make it illegal. It was too widely accepted and deeply rooted. His law of 362 seems merely to have protected the *suffragatores* from their clients who took back property paid in advance after they had gained the favours they sought.[137]

Victor's work may have had some impact on Julian whose natural disposition appears to have led him to prefer honesty and competence. Unfortunately the bureaucracy, like the army, possessed a durability and a potency of its own: "the thousand heads of the hydra grew again as fast as they were cut off."[138]

# 5

## ROME AND THE PROVINCES

### Rome

Rome was already in Diocletian's day an anachronism. From 284 it had ceased to be the capital of the empire in any but a formal sense. Even as an administrative centre it was of no greater importance than a dozen other cities which were capitals of dioceses. It had never possessed industries serving more than local needs and had long since stopped being a major commercial centre.[1] In the fourth century it had become a kind of sanctuary where certain rites were performed, a unique museum visited by emperors only infrequently and for very short periods.[2] Like Athens its reputation was founded upon what it had been rather than what it was. Its large underemployed or unemployed populace was fed at state expense, entertained by magistrates whose wealth derived from elsewhere. Thus the populace together with the great households of the wealthy constituted a constant and massive drain on the provinces, particularly Africa, and southern Italy. Nevertheless, its imposing temples, baths, circuses, fora, palaces, theatres, gardens and markets proved an awe-inspiring sight which astounded the emperor Constantius II when he finally visited Rome in 357, twenty years after his father's death.[3]

In Victor's day, despite the development of Constantinople and various provincial centres, Rome was still the finest city in the empire, the place in which to live or to complete one's education for a westerner of any means. Its great families continued to make Rome the centre of fashionable life and it attracted recently ennobled senators of the West long after the founding of its rival, Constantinople. Even the ordinary citizens were better off than those of other cities. Beside the profusion of public spectacles and sporting events, free bread was distributed daily to 120,000 holders of *tesserae* (bread tickets) and cheap bread was available in addition to the free

supply. Furthermore, gratuitous distributions of oil and pork, wine sold at 25 per cent below market price, an abundant supply of water and free entry to the eleven huge public baths made Rome very attractive to the lower classes. Yet the city had its drawbacks. Riots occurred with some frequency and it was difficult to quell them in the fourth century for there were no armed forces at the disposal of the urban prefect after Constantine had disbanded the guards in 312. There were also occasional shortages of bread, wine and other commodities. Finally, as Victor himself informs us, Rome experienced terror and hardships during the usurpations of Maxentius (306-312), Nepotianus (350) and Magnentius (350-353).[4]

Nevertheless Rome remained an idealized city whose reputation engaged the fancy of provincials and barbarians alike. The latter were perhaps mostly struck by the city's power in creating and organizing such a widespread empire and imposing her laws on so vast an area. Many educated provincials, on the other hand, regarded her as a beneficial force which had united so many disparate, warring peoples and had elevated and nurtured the creative arts.[5] Eutropius, as a typical senatorial, was convinced of the rightness of Roman domination. According to den Boer "he was apparently, or preferred to seem, oblivious of the fact that this situation gave rise to tension among subjected peoples. His manner of taking Rome's power for granted sometimes strikes us as cynical, although it probably springs rather from a naive consciousness of superiority."[6] Clearly not all accepted this view. The increasingly harsh burdens of taxation and the inability of the Roman government to protect large numbers of its provincial citizens not only from barbarian incursions but even from the depredations of its own soldiers and officials engendered a loss of confidence in Rome and sometimes outright hostility. The fourth century witnessed numerous local insurrections and desertions to the barbarians. According to Zosimus "every town was filled with tears and complaints, all calling out for the barbarians and begging their assistance".[7]

Aurelius Victor clearly did not belong to the ranks of the hopeless despite his rural North African origin. Certainly by 360 his position in Roman society was sufficiently privileged to ensure him a comfortable existence and well-founded aspirations. The Roman system, with all its imperfections, had allowed this provincial, on the basis of his education, to advance to a relatively important post in the bureaucratic hierarchy. It is hardly surprising, then, that he appears to have fallen in love with the stately city and what it stood for and to

have turned to the past nostalgically to escape the unpleasant reality of his day, the fact that Rome was no longer the grand, imperial capital. Thus any action which impaired the majesty of the city was viewed with horror by Victor and he bitterly criticized Nero (on the basis of extremely spurious evidence, as far as we can tell) for ordering the burning of Rome and the massacre of the plebs and senators by a general freeing of wild beasts. Even worse, Nero sought a new capital for his empire at the instigation of a Parthian ambassador.[8] Commodus, too, is singled out for building baths in the city which were *Romae potentia vix digna*.[9] Moreover, the praetorians and the other guards (*subsidia*) at Rome had become an object of hatred because they had proved more useful for factional conflicts than for the protection of the city. Hence they were rightly disbanded by Constantine who also forbade the bearing of arms and the wearing of uniforms in the city.[10] Finally, Victor notes with great sadness the lack of celebrations on the 1100th anniversary of Rome (348):

> "That is how much concern for the city declines day by day. Indeed, they say that this was foretold at the time by prodigies and portents of which I should briefly like to recall one. When the victims were being slaughtered according to pontifical ritual the genitals of a sow appeared on a boar's belly. The soothsayers interpreted this to portend the decadence of later generations and the worsening of vices."[11]

This is the most striking example of Victor's Roman patriotism, his cult of the Eternal City. According to Zosimus the abandoning of this venerable tradition was one of the causes of Rome's decadence, and he faults Constantine and Licinius for its occurrence.[12] To emphasize his resentment at the later emperors' neglect of Rome Victor specifically noted that Claudius, Antoninus and Philip celebrated the 800th, 900th and 1000th anniversaries of Rome in fitting fashion.[13]

As a corollary Victor carefully disclosed the names and enterprises of those emperors who adorned and embellished Rome. First, of course, came Augustus, to whom were dedicated temples, priests and sacral colleges both in the capital and in the most important provincial cities.[14] Vespasian rebuilt the Capitolium, the Temple of Peace and the monuments of Claudius, and constructed the Colosseum, among other works at Rome and abroad.[15] His son, Titus, completed the great amphitheatre.[16] Domitian finished off work on the numerous projects undertaken by his father and brother, in particular the Capitolium.[17] The much-extolled emperor Trajan

completed the forum which Domitian had undertaken besides building and decorating many other works.[18] His successor, Hadrian, showed concern in Rome for ceremonies, laws, gymnasia, a school for the liberal arts called the Athenaeum and the cults of Ceres and Libera and those of Eleusis.[19] Marcus Aurelius had temples, columns and priests decreed to him after his death by the joint action of the *patres* and the *vulgus*.[20]

Victor then shifts to a slightly different topic, imperial burials at Rome. The hint is unmistakable in view of his later statement (see below) about the anger of the Romans when Constantine was buried at Constantinople.[21] Roman emperors should be buried at Rome. So Victor reports that his fellow-countryman, Septimius Severus, was buried with due pomp at Rome in the tomb of Marcus Aurelius, as was his son, Caracalla, though the author notes that both emperors died far from the capital, at York in Britain and Edessa in Syria respectively.[22] Furthermore Caracalla brought Egyptian rites to the city and adorned it with a new road and beautiful baths.[23] Alexander Severus also constructed an outstanding building at Rome which may have been the Nympheum commemorated on coins and medallions in 226.[24] Next Victor praises the young Gordian for enlarging and consolidating the Capitoline Games which Nero had introduced.[25] Philip built a dam on the far side of the Tiber to offset an acute water shortage there. Possibly this was the *Naumachia Philippi*, a restoration of Augustus' *naumachia* which by Victor's time was regarded solely as a reservoir.[26] Even Decius, in his short reign, built edifices at Rome which Victor fails to specify.[27] The emperor Aurelian erected the magnificent Temple of the Sun and surrounded Rome with strong fortifications of a larger circumference than its previous ones.[28]

Drawing nearer to his own day, Victor tells us with obvious approbation that Diocletian attended to time-honoured religious observances and bedecked Rome's hilltops and other cities such as Carthage, Milan and Nicomedia with new and graceful additions. These, which Victor does not name, include the Baths of Diocletian, the original design and much of the original work on the Basilica of Maxentius, a reconstruction of the Curia in the Forum, the *cellae* of the Temple of Venus and Rome and the design of the Circus of Maxentius.[29] Finally Victor instructs us that the senate consecrated to Constantine all the buildings which Maxentius had put up with such magnificence, including the *Urbis fanum*, the Flavian Basilica and large public baths (on the Quirinal). Constantine also restored

with suitable magnificence the Circus Maximus.[30]

It appears likely that many of Victor's notices listed above derived from his source, for Eutropius carries several of them.[31] But Eutropius was far more interested in foreign wars and the expansion of the empire[32] and consequently accorded less prominence than Victor to the physical adornment of the city. The difference between them lies rather in emphasis than in opinion as Victor's comments on imperial expansion and related matters demonstrate.[33] Similarly their resentment of the new capital, Constantinople, is shared. Neither writer can bear to cite the new city by name. When it appears impossible to omit reference to it Victor first links it together with two other objects of his animosity. At the end of a sentence describing the crucifixion of Calocerus, a rebellious and insignificant *magister pecoris camelorum* in Cyprus, he briefly and disrespectfully adds that Constantine busied himself with "founding a city, forming religions and reshaping the military".[34] Yet the emperor's building schemes at Rome and even at Cirta (renamed Constantina) in Africa are elaborately documented earlier.[35] Victor obviously finds no difficulty in naming any provincial city but Constantinople.

Constantine died near Nicomedia, as Victor announces: he merely appends the fact that the emperor was buried in the city named after himself. Then comes the open anger and resentment: *quod sane populus Romanus aegerrime tulit* ....[36] Constantinople is thus tacitly ignored, though Rome is on display forty-one times and Carthage four, once as *terrarum decus*.[37]

Eutropius, too, writing some ten years later, prefers circumlocution when describing the foundation of Rome's rival. He writes: *primusque urbem nominis sui ad tantum fastigium evehere molitus est ut Romae aemulam faceret*.[38] Even the Epitomator, who took his work down to 395, mentions Constantinople but three times, with regard to the deaths of Constantine, Jovian and Theodosius.[39] He totally disregards the foundation of the new capital and merely states that Constantine was buried in Byzantium called Constantinople. The slight is surely quite intentional. Finally even Ammianus generally prefers to disregard the new capital, naming it only when events compelled him to do so.

The deep resentment, impotent anger and sorrow felt by Victor and other westerners, particularly of the upper and middle classes, was perhaps shared by many in the East. Constantinople was regarded as an upstart city, usurping the historically deserved position of Rome. It may have been the case that these emotional

considerations played a prominent role in Victor's desire to write a history of the empire and in so doing to stress the central importance of Rome.

Nevertheless, Victor was wrong in feeling that Constantine was mainly responsible for Rome's demise. Well over half a century before Constantine's decision to found his new city Gallienus had been forced by military needs to use Milan as his base of operations. Diocletian, too, had diagnosed the problem early in his reign: Rome was no longer viable as the imperial capital. It was a realization difficult for many to accept, and perhaps especially difficult for those who had grown up in the provinces in comfortable circumstances and had been carefully taught to regard Rome as the grand and noble centre of the far-flung empire bearing its name, indeed as the focal point of the civilized world.[40] "Rome was the symbol of supremacy .... Those who wished to deprive Rome of her original political and religious attributes were regarded by the nationalists as friends of the barbarians."[41] Victor, the African provincial, was one of these fourth-century nationalists, just as much as those Romans of considerable standing in the late fourth century, Q. Aurelius Symmachus, Petronius Probus, Vettius Agorius Praetextatus or Virius Nicomachus Flavianus. One can only conclude that the subsequent neglect of Rome by Valentinian I and that emperor's burial at Constantinople[42] would have reinforced Victor's feelings that imperial indifference to Rome and its traditions was at least partly to blame for the decay of the empire.

**Provincials and Provinces**

Victor hailed from Africa and on two occasions his pride in his native province is clearly displayed, first when he discusses Septimius Severus and again when he describes Carthage as *terrarum decus*.[43] Nevertheless he does not accord special prominence to Africa and its affairs and produces virtually no information about the province which does not derive from the mainstream of the tradition he inherited or the source he followed.[44] His attitude, then, towards provincials in general appears not to be specifically African and is perhaps concisely summarized for us in 11.12-13 where he writes:

> "Up to this time (i.e. by AD 96) men born in Rome or in Italy ruled the empire: thereafter foreigners also ruled. Perhaps, as in the case of Tarquinius Priscus, they were far better. Indeed, as far as I am concerned, after reading widely and hearing many discussions, I am fully convinced that the city of Rome has grown great mainly through the excellence of outsiders and imported skills."

Victor then goes on to ask who could be more prudent and moderate than the Cretan Nerva.[45] The Epitomator reproduces the above passage with some minor modifications but disagrees on one basic fact, Nerva's birthplace.[46] He correctly informs us that the emperor was born at Narnia. It seems clear that the Epitomator had followed Victor and the K.G. to this point but henceforth he parts company with Victor and very few passages show close similarity to the *De Caesaribus*.[47] Nixon argues convincingly that the eulogy of foreigners was in the basic source and that Victor's *prudentius maximeque moderatum* was a kind of "elegant" variation.[48] In addition he suggests that Victor's error *Cretensi* may be the result of a misread manuscript or work note combined with Victor's belief that Nerva was a foreigner.[49] If Nixon's views are accepted it detracts from Victor's original contributions to his history but the fact that he chose to include such sentiments whereas Eutropius did not implies that he shared them. Furthermore Nerva's Cretan origin fits into the context, for subsequently Trajan's Spanish origin is emphasized and that of Hadrian is also noted.[50] The former is, not unexpectedly, lavishly praised while Hadrian's eloquence and deep concern for laws, ceremonies, schools and men of learning are prominently displayed.[51] Such concern, writes Victor, was like that of the Greeks or Pompilius Numa (Rome's second king) and the author is pleased to mention the establishment of the Athenaeum and the Eleusinian rites at Rome.

Again, when Victor arrives at the period of his fellow African, Septimius Severus, the emperor is described as second to none in the state, though he came from a province which, because of some quirk of fate, is ungenerous in furnishing men of eminence. Yet it holds high those whom it has produced, each according to his merits.[52] Even Alexander Severus, whose reign, according to Victor, marked the watershed of the empire, is introduced as a Syrian and immediately praised.[53] None of Juvenal's bitter defamation is attached. Similarly Philip the Arab is presented as such totally without comment.[54] His reign, however, is commended particularly with regard to his concern for the thousandth anniversary of Rome, his building schemes in the capital and his well-intentioned attempt to check male prostitution.

The following emperor, Decius, is immediately on show as a native of Sirmium, a military usurper who none the less died valiantly in the service of the state.[55] Probus is likewise extolled and he, too, came from Sirmium.[56] Here Victor infuses a personal *exemplum*.

comparing Probus with Hannibal in using the army for agricultural tasks because, like Hannibal, Probus realized that idleness of the troops was a source of anxiety for the state and its leaders alike. The notice referring to the planting of vineyards in Gaul, Pannonia and Moesia presumably stood in the K.G., for all the epitomators and the *H.A.* make use of it; but only Victor draws the parallel with Hannibal.[57] What strikes one forcefully at this juncture is that the worst of the emperors during this period was, according to Victor and the other Latin sources, the hapless Gallienus who was Italian, *genere satis claro*.[58] It was his edict which Victor singled out for criticism after the assassination of the Pannonian Probus, in addition to the indolence of the senate. These factors permitted the military and the semi-barbarians to dominate the state.[59]

Carus and his sons hailed from Narbo (in Gaul) as Victor narrates without comment.[60] It was a peculiar anomaly, this short-lived Narbonese dynasty, but it excited no curiosity among our sources except for the *H.A.*, whose fanciful account is not to be taken seriously.[61]

Before proceeding to discussion of the tetrarchs Victor adds what appears to be another of his personal comments: "Why should I recall that many men, even foreigners, were admitted to partnership (in rule) for the sake of defending and extending Roman jurisdiction?"[62] It is shortly after this that he summarizes their general character:

> "Illyricum was, indeed, the homeland of all of these: thus, although they were lacking in culture, they were nevertheless sufficiently experienced in the tribulations of rural life and military service to be the best men for the state. Consequently it is agreed that men more readily become virtuous and sensible by undergoing hardship, whereas, on the other hand, those who are unacquainted with troubles, since they judge everyone by the standards of their own circumstances, are less considerate. But the harmony of these men has demonstrated very clearly that character and the experience of successful military service which they had mainly acquired from the system of Aurelian and Probus is almost sufficient to assure virtue."[63]

Illyricum is accorded prominence in the epitomators who provide us with scraps of precise information[64] and personal views. Victor, in particular, is quite illuminating. Licinius, for example, is granted one solitary positive quality, *parsimonia*, which Victor at once brands as *agrestis tantummodo*.[65] The word *agrestis* means boorish, crude, uncivilized, and is used only negatively by Victor. Thus he stigmatizes the parents of Alexander (who rebelled in Africa in 308) as

*agrestibus ac Pannonicis*, so that it was understandable that Alexander should be *vecordior* and seize power *stolide*.[66] Furthermore Vetranio is described as *litterarum prorsus expers et ingenio stolidior idcircoque agresti vecordia pessimus*, presumably because he was born *Moesiae superioris locis squalidioribus*.[67] Similar use is made of the word in describing the *manus agrestium ac latronum*, the Bagaudae, in Gaul, while Maximian is described as *semiagrestis* in the same sentence.[68]

Victor's concern with the origins of emperors is mainly derived from biographical tradition but it still gives us indications of his attitudes towards some of the provinces, particularly Pannonia and Moesia. He had, after all, been stationed at Sirmium, the hub of the Danubian provinces, and he appears to have realized the growing importance of this area in the third and fourth centuries when it supplied both the soldiers and the soldier-emperors responsible for safeguarding the empire. This realization stemmed not merely from his general reading and his source but also from his personal experiences. He knew the countryside, he probably knew some of the towns, particularly Sirmium. Hence one detects a certain ambivalence in his feelings about the Illyrians. While he certainly respected the toughness and fighting spirit of the Illyrians, especially of the emperors, he nevertheless despised their boorish rusticity and lack of education. He was himself a product of the long-established Graeco-Roman tradition which equated cities with civilization,[69] education with leadership and responsibility. Italy, Spain and Africa had produced emperors and private individuals possessing culture (*humanitas*), a quality Victor profoundly respected and which he found lacking in the Illyrians. The final evidence appears in his description of Galerius and Constantius Chlorus who:

> "were endowed with such remarkable natural talents that if these gifts had emanated from learned minds, and if they had not given offence by their uncouthness (*insulsitate*), they would certainly have been considered outstanding."[70]

Victor came from a relatively urbanized, sophisticated province and had received, so it would appear, a regular Roman education. He had therefore been taught to value those very qualities which the Illyrians did not possess and he had become more Roman than the Romans. This attitude is the subject of considerable falsification in the *H.A.* where the author discusses the origin of Carus and alleges that the emperor wished to be regarded as Roman, *id est Roma oriundum*.[71] Subsequently, in his fanciful description of

Carinus, he scornfully remarks upon the emperor's jewelled shoes and belt and his arrogant treatment of prefects and consuls. The majority of the Illyrians, he observes gratuitously, even greeted Carinus as King.[72] It is clear from this and further evidence that Victor was not alone in his distrust for and dislike of the Illyrian military hierarchy.[73]

Victor's contact with parts of the empire other than Africa, Italy and Illyricum seems to have been negligible in view of his stereotyped passing comments. On the Greeks he makes several negative observations. First he notes that they are fond of embellishing everything,[74] then he remarks upon Nero's shameful conduct which began with his public performances on the lyre for prizes, a Greek innovation, from which the emperor passed on to yet worse activities.[75] Finally, borrowing from Suetonius via the K.G. so it appears, he mentions Domitian's bed-wrestling, "which the emperor called *clinopalen* in the Greek language".[76] Yet on the cultural side he wrote positively of the Greeks in describing Hadrian's establishment of the Athenaeum and the Eleusinian rites at Rome.[77] This was done in the Greek manner or in that of Pompilius Numa, i.e. it also had Roman precedent. Furthermore, when Aurelian remitted what were in all probability uncollectable taxes in 274, he is said to have done so in the Greek manner.[78] Victor's view of the Greeks appears to have been as ambivalent as that of most westerners, a mixture of respect for their history and cultural attainments, scorn for their military and political insignificance and their supposed effeminacy and homosexual tendencies, and envy for their professional abilities.[79]

Concerning the Gauls Victor first notes the *famosae superstitiones* of the Druids which Claudius suppressed.[80] Much later he informs us that in Gaul a band of peasants and brigands, called Bagaudae by the inhabitants, had ravaged the countryside far and wide and invested most of the cities.[81] Furthermore, it was the Gauls who elevated Silvanus to the throne and again shattered the recent peace there. After all the Gauls are by nature a headstrong people.[82] Gaul is prominently on display in the *De Caesaribus*, being mentioned twenty times, twice as frequently as any other province.[83] This prominence is probably owed to its significance in the history of the period, for Eutropius' information on Gaul is of greater importance than that given for other provinces. Even Ammianus found it necessary to devote a brief chapter to Gallic *mores* in which he emphasizes their quarrelsome, insolent nature, their courage and

their addiction to wine.[84] Finally, the *H.A.* also informs us that the Gauls are always fond of rebellions, always troublesome and eager to create an emperor or an empire.[85] Once again it appears that Victor shared the *opinio communis* in his perception of the Gauls.[86]

Victor plainly did not despise provincial origin *per se*: he was, after all, a provincial himself. What he really objected to was the fact that so many provincials of peasant origin, predominantly Illyrians, had risen to positions of eminence in the army and in the imperial service. He considered, perhaps from personal experiences during his service at Sirmium, that such people were greedy, ruthless, uncultivated and excessively powerful.[87] They had taken over the offices of others who were better educated, they were incapable of performing the requisite duties, and they had corrupted the established cultural milieu with the unfortunate result, as far as he was concerned, that the empire had eventually been entrusted to men of inferior birth and inadequate training.[88] No province seems to have been singled out for conspicuous or repeated mention, nor was any provincial city with the possible exception of Carthage.[89] None the less since the majority of the later emperors hailed from Illyricum and this area had become the dynamic centre of the empire, he felt compelled to describe the qualities he observed in its inhabitants. In so doing he appears to have made a clear-sighted appraisal of the debt Rome owed in general to men of provincial origin, and his distaste for the crudeness of the Illyrians did not prevent him from appreciating *their* value to the empire as well as that of men from the more civilized provinces.

# 6

## EDUCATION AND CULTURE

One of the most conspicuous elements in the *De Caesaribus* is the author's emphasis on the importance of education and culture.[1] This attitude was not novel. Cicero had described Scipio as a *homo doctissimus atque humanissimus* in contrast to Verres, a man *sine ulla bona arte, sine humanitate, sine ingenio, sine litteris*.[2] Sallust prefaced his work on Jugurtha and Catiline with lengthy disquisitions on culture and intellectual pursuits which, despite Quintilian's harsh strictures,[3] must have had a considerable effect on generations of schoolboys who studied his works, not least Aurelius Victor. "Culture and learning are among man's noteworthy achievements and the words *humanitas* and *humanus* were often used by the Romans with special reference to this *animi cultura*."[4] Victor and his contemporaries, however, were separated by a wide gulf from these earlier writers. When Libanius wrote, "If we lose eloquence we shall become the same as the barbarians",[5] he was expressing a view shared by many if not most of the educated citizens of the empire. The third century and the first half of the fourth had witnessed social and political upheavals on a massive scale and these, in turn, had brought into being "a new leading class . . . which clearly had some difficulty in remembering the simple facts of Roman history. This explains why Eutropius and Festus were both commissioned by the emperor Valens to prepare a brief summary of Roman history."[6] Members of the military hierarchy and even many of the Greek senators of Constantinople, whose knowledge of Latin and Roman history was sketchy, found themselves in need of brief and basic handbooks akin to our modern potted histories or introductory outlines to psychology or literature, etc., to help them to function more readily in their respective social strata. Small wonder, then, that Eutropius' *Breviarium* and the anonymous *Epitome* quickly

became popular, unlike the *De Caesaribus*, mainly because they were easy to read, had a simple style and made no intellectual demands on their readers.[7] Yet even Eutropius' account appears to have been considered too long by Valens since he authorized Festus to compose an even more condensed version of Rome's history.[8]

It is quite evident that readers of these "poor and scrappy productions"[9] could hardly have been well-versed in Roman history for otherwise merely from their general school education they would have learned whatever these epitomizers had to offer and more besides. Nevertheless, despite den Boer's contention,[10] such works were not written for the masses but rather for the higher echelons of the military and for many members of the civil service who, as den Boer himself notes, were not very sophisticated.[11] Indeed, Constantius had offended many who had received the traditional classical education by promoting persons lacking this background to administrative positions. Moreover Julian, Ammianus, Themistius and the author of the *H.A.* all emphasized the importance of education for rulers and administrators.[12] Victor's constant stress on education and culture, therefore, and his criticism of those in power who lacked such refinements represent a further indication of this phenomenon.

In his account of Augustus' reign Victor remarks with unmistakable pleasure that the emperor cultivated men of learning *who abounded in those days* since he was extraordinarily devoted to the study of eloquence and religious observances.[13] Two points emerge from this statement. First, in Victor's estimation, at the beginning of the empire there was no shortage of educated men. Second, by linking eloquence with religious observances (the latter being customary Roman observances) the author may have been covertly reproaching Christianity which he almost certainly considered inimical to traditional Roman culture.[14]

Subsequently, after recounting the death of Vitellius, Victor maintains that all of the preceding emperors, particularly the Julio-Claudians, were so cultivated in literature and eloquence that if, with the exception of Augustus, they had not been excessive in all kinds of vices, their profound cultural attainments would certainly have concealed any moderate crimes. He adds that although good character may generally be considered pre-eminent both qualities are equally necessary in any good man, and especially in the emperor. If that should prove impossible, at least let him assume the *auctoritas eloquentiae atque eruditionis*.[15]

Victor begins his section on Vespasian by briefly mentioning the emperor's eloquence[16] and goes on to recount his manifold achievements. He ends on a note of comparison. In his own day integrity in public office is despised: the ignorant are mixed with the well-bred, the incompetent with those of ability. There can be no doubt that Victor believed that many of those currently administering the affairs of state were significantly less educated than their predecessors of the first century AD. Instead, they had become incompetent, corrupt and rapacious.[17] As if to emphasize these points Victor directly introduces Titus with a strongly adversative *ceterum* and informs his readers how the new emperor surpassed his father, incredible as it was, in literature, clemency and the performance of his duties.[18]

When Victor reaches Hadrian he immediately notes that emperor's eloquence and civil interests and dwells longingly on the fact that at Rome

> "According to the custom of the Greeks or Pompilius Numa, he began to concern himself with religious ceremonies, laws, schools and teachers to such a degree that he even established a school of liberal arts which they call the Athenaeum and Rome celebrated the rites of Ceres and Libera, called the Eleusinian mysteries, in the manner of the Athenians."[19]

Once again, as in the case of Augustus, religious matters are linked with learning, but this time Victor goes further to underscore the connection between Greek and Roman culture, stylistically creating a chiastic effect.[20] His use of the term *ingenuae artes* in this particular context is intriguing for it not only means 'liberal arts' but also gives the impression that they are somehow indigenous and the birthright of free-born citizens. Looking back at his comment in 11.13, *plane compertum urbem Romam externorum virtute atque insitivis artibus praecipue crevisse*, I am struck by the notion that Victor is informing his readers that the Graeco-Roman culture is a unity and a cohesive principle which is to be fostered and protected in the manner demonstrated by Hadrian and subsequently espoused by Julian.[21]

The account of the reign of Antonius Pius allows Victor little leeway to pursue his theme. We encounter merely a Platonic topos, namely that cities will be fortunate if their rulers are men of wisdom.[22] Nevertheless Marcus Aurelius is another matter. Indeed, the new emperor was so superior to his predecessor in his devotion to philosophy and eloquence, and so talented in philosophy and literature, that when he was setting out for the campaign against the Marcomanni a crowd of philosophers surrounded him and begged

him not to commit himself to battle before he had explained to them some difficult and obscure points in the doctrines of the various philosophical schools. Victor was plainly impressed by Aurelius' cultural attainments. He informs his readers that the *bonae artes* flourished to such an extent during this emperor's reign that he, Victor, considered it the glory of the times.[23] As a consequence scant attention was paid by the author to the very important German wars which occupied Aurelius for the greater part of his reign.

It is after Victor has briefly complimented Pertinax for being a man *doctrinae omnis ac moribus antiquissimis* that he makes his next significant statement, one concerning Didius Julianus, here confused with the jurist Salvius Julianus. Victor first praises him for his outstanding knowledge of the law, but feels bound to add that it is generally accepted that unless one's character assists in checking cupidity, learning by itself is a poor thing.[24] This discriminating distinction between character and extensive knowledge of the law shows some subtlety, according to den Boer: Victor's "judgement is clearcut, praise for the jurist and censure of the *ingenium* that gave rise to *saevi mores*."[25] Yet it is in keeping with other examples of Victor's discerning insight into the character of the Julio-Claudians and the tetrarchs. Still pursuing his theme, Victor compounds his confusion over Didius and Salvius Julianus. He informs us that Severus attempted to abolish the *decreta* of Salvius (meaning Didius) but failed. In order to explain this attempt (which never took place[26]) he asserts that the learned arts have such power that the memory of writers cannot be threatened however savage their character may be. Moreover punishment of this nature not only brings glory to the victims but also damns those who execute it, for all men, particularly those of later generations, feel that such talents could not be oppressed except by acts of villainy or madness.[27]

As is to be expected from the African author the cultural attainments of Septimius Severus are described in glowing terms:

> "He was given to philosophy and oratory, in short to all aspects of the liberal arts. Similarly he wrote an autobiography with equal elegance and candour."[28]

There may well be some understandable exaggeration here but in general Severus was well-educated, having studied at Athens and Rome, and, as even Dio admits though with some reserve, the emperor had a real regard for classical culture though he was not particularly gifted.[29] Allusions to his autobiography are to be found in Herodian, Dio and the *H.A.* so that it remains a possibility that

Victor had read it at some time or other, but the wealth of mistakes made by Victor in recounting this period merely indicates that he did not have it at hand during composition of the *De Caesaribus*.[30]

Victor pauses after describing the reign and death of Alexander Severus to impress upon the reader what he views as the critical turning point in the empire and the breakdown of the imperial system. Emperors paid more attention to tyrannizing their subjects than to subjugating foreign foes and this resulted in the headlong decline of the state and the indiscriminate elevation to the throne of good and bad, noble and ignoble, and even barbarians. Amid this universal chaos positions of administrative importance were seized by incompetents who *scientiam bonarum artium foede corrumpunt*.[31] As a prime instance of this he cites the choice of Maximinus as emperor in 235, a man *primus e militaribus, litterarum fere rudis*.[32] Thus began, as far as Victor was concerned, not only the political decline of Rome but also its intellectual, cultural and moral decline.[33]

A remarkable but understandable interval now occurs before the author makes any further mention of education, eloquence or culture. Apparently none of the military emperors possessed such attributes, in Victor's view. Either he was unaware of or chose to ignore the distinct cultural interests and attainments of Gallienus, that unfortunate victim of hostile senatorial propaganda. Yet Gallienus' literary and oratorical abilities are prominently displayed in the *H.A.*, although its author notes that however desirable these may be in orators or poets, *aliud in imperatore quaeritur*.[34]

The tetrarchs, who belonged to the long line of military emperors, shared one unfortunate blemish, *parum humanitatis*. This term, which Victor uses only here, denotes culture and refinement, as stated earlier. None the less the tetrarchs' experience of the hardships of rural and military life made them excellent rulers. Furthermore their harmony demonstrated most of all that character and military experience are almost sufficient in themselves to ensure virtue.[35] This is without doubt another topos[36] but one must give Victor credit for seeing the great difficulty and importance of imperial harmony. He had witnessed the disastrous disunity of Constantine's family which had led to a series of calamitous civil wars and was about to cause yet another. Quite possibly this is a plea to Constantius II and Julian to patch up their differences for the sake of the empire.

Galerius and Constantius I, in Victor's estimation, possessed remarkable natural talents which would certainly have been regarded as outstanding if only the two emperors had been *docti* and

had not given offence because of their lack of taste (*insulsitate*). It is at this juncture that Victor produces one of his major statements on education, culture and the necessary characteristics of an emperor:

> "Consequently it is generally agreed that learning, refinement and courtesy are especially necessary for princes since without such attributes natural good qualities are despised as inelegant or even uncouth: on the other hand those attributes brought eternal renown to Cyrus, King of the Persians. Moreover in my own day they elevated Constantine, through the prayers of all, to a place among the stars, although he was endowed with other virtues. Assuredly, if he had set a limit to his munificence, to his ambition and to those qualities through which more than anything else mature minds go too far in their eagerness for glory and achieve the opposite result, he would not have fallen far short of godliness."[37]

At this point Victor is, in general, elaborating on a theme he emphasized in 8.8, namely that *eruditio* and *elegantia* (here coupled with *comitas*) are essential qualifications for those in power. He considers it morally indefensible when men lacking such necessary qualifications like Maximinus or, in his own memory, Vetranio, usurp imperial authority. No wonder then that he waxes indignant at the latter's elevation for he was "completely illiterate, rather stupid and therefore, because of his rustic lack of sense, the worst possible choice".[38] A decisive contrast is made between the boorish Vetranio, who seized power at Mursa in Pannonia on March 1, 350, and the ostensibly eloquent emperor Constantius II who "deposed" him.[39]

> "In less than ten months Constantius, by the power of his eloquence, deposed (Vetranio) from his imperial power and removed him to private retirement. He alone, since the establishment of the empire, has gained this glory by his eloquence and clemency. For when the majority of both armies had gathered, an assembly similar to a trial was held and he accomplished by his eloquence what would have been difficult to obtain by force or much bloodshed. This occurrence has demonstrated quite clearly that not only in civilian matters but also in military affairs fluency of speech is paramount. It is precisely by means of such fluency that even difficult matters are more easily accomplished provided that the speaker excels in self-control and integrity."[40]

What Victor omits in his account of Vetranio's seizure of power is quite illuminating. Apparently the emperor's sister, Constantina, acted as an intermediary between Constantius and Vetranio, the *magister peditum* who was acclaimed emperor. The latter's coins bore Constantius' image and the two men met at Serdica and moved

westwards together to Naissus where, on Christmas Day, a general assembly of both armies took place at which Constantius made an eloquent speech that had been carefully prepared beforehand. Thereupon Vetranio laid down his imperial regalia and was granted an honourable retirement at Prusa in Bithynia.[41] In view of Constantius' intransigent and savage attitude to usurpers one is induced to infer either that the 'usurpation' had been arranged with Constantius' approval or that the supposedly simple-minded Vetranio had been able to convince the intensely suspicious emperor that he had acted in Constantius' interest. Presumably both considered it expedient to perpetuate the fiction of the usurpation to avoid giving the soldiers the impression they had been duped. The result was that while Vetranio's character suffered some vilification Constantius was able to acquire a reputation for clemency and eloquence.[42] Possibly Victor did not know of the surreptitious transactions, though I find this hard to believe in view of his position in the Pannonian bureaucracy. It appears more likely that he saw this as a striking opportunity to flatter the emperor and simultaneously to underline his theme that education and culture and in particular eloquence, an essential component of both, could achieve such remarkable effects and therefore were eminently worthy of imperial support. Accordingly it was not without good reason that in his summation of Constantius' character he depicted the emperor as *ad elegantiam prudens atque orandi genere leni iocundoque*.[43]

Victor was following a well-worn path. Quintilian had also pronounced upon the usefulness of eloquence in war as well as in peace and even Julian had praised Constantius for his feat which he portrayed as the equal of a military victory.[44] Furthermore the influence of Cicero is to be seen in the linking of virtue with eloquence.[45] Constantius was, therefore, applauded for his demonstration of learning, clemency, self-control and integrity in order to be held out as an example to others and also to be reminded that these were the qualities to be encouraged and sought in his administrative appointees. Possession or absence of culture had plainly become a major criterion for estimating the quality of rulers and administrators. In addition Victor had obviously accepted the late Republican conception of *boni*, that is *sapientes*, or *optimi*. Nevertheless, as in Cicero, the *boni* were a virtuous and cultured élite, not a hereditary one, for Victor plainly did not place much faith in heredity.[46] Hence Victor constantly commended those who were *litteris culti atque eloquentia* (8.7), *docti* or *doctiores* (1.5; 3.5; 40.12;

cf. 18.1), and who demonstrated *eruditio* (8.8; 40.13), *elegantia* (8.8; 40.13; 42.23), *eloquentia* (1.5; 8.7; 16.1; 42.3), *facundia* (9.1; 39.13) and *comitas* (40.13); and he regularly referred to *artes doctae* or *artes bonae* (14.3; 16.10; 20.2; 24.10) and *litterae* (8.7; 16.9; 42.23).[47]

As culture declined deeper and deeper into barbarism educated citizens of the later empire felt increasingly Roman and considered that they were the servants of the empire fulfilling a historic mission to preserve civilization and culture in face of the encroachments of the barbarians. This culture which they were defending meant the general classical tradition. It became a sort of special prerogative of the senatorial class and social climbers seeking access to it and to the higher reaches of the administration. All self-made men, however vulgar their origins, were as keen as aristocrats to promote classical culture. So Valentinian I called on Ausonius of Bordeaux to act as tutor for his son Gratian. The emperor's first aim should be to preserve the empire and Roman ideals, something inseparable from the old classical ideal of culture based upon the great literature of the past. Classical education, therefore, developed into the embodiment of the ideal of perfect humanity.[48] Both Constantius II and Julian kept the distinguished order of the *decuriae* of Rome for educated men who could appreciate literature and eloquence for it was "necessary to reward literary culture, the first of all virtues".[49]

The most significant single influence in perpetuating Roman literary tradition was the Roman school system. Despite the perceptible general decline of learning and culture schools gained in importance to become the guardians of tradition and, along with the army, the means of upward mobility. Following the example of several of his predecessors, such as Vespasian, Hadrian, the Antonines and Alexander Severus, Constantine paid a great deal of attention to the academic system. In 321, 326 and 333 the emperor reaffirmed by edict all previous enactments regarding the position of public teachers.[50] In addition teachers were exempted from various imperial and municipal *munera* but were still left free to accept local magistracies and honours. Professors were relieved of military service and expensive compulsory billeting while their wives and children enjoyed similar privileges. This was done, according to the emperor, *quo facilius liberalibus studiis multos instituant*. But perhaps the most striking example of the care which the emperors bestowed upon education is the Law of Gratian in 376, just two years before Ausonius became prefect of the Gauls, prescribing the salary levels of the several grades of professors.[51]

All this imperial concern for the educational system was hardly disinterested or idealistic. Not only was the bureaucracy dependent upon it for its recruits, but so were the professors, the engineers, architects, doctors and lawyers of the empire. The upper classes had always ensured that their children should be given the benefits of a sound education but they did not and could not supply either the bureaucracy or the professors with a sufficiency of well-trained personnel. It therefore remained for the schools to provide suitable recruits from among the youth of the middle classes with a small admixture of poor boys who had been fortunate enough to receive local bursaries.[52]

General education itself was, by modern standards, uniform and quite limited. Grammar and rhetoric were the main components, with a smattering of dialectic, arithmetic, geometry, music, astronomy and philosophy. Those authors whose works formed the backbone of the school curriculum in imperial times were Terence, Virgil, Sallust and Cicero.[53] Some Romans such as Cicero and Tacitus might have conceived ideals of a more broadly based liberal education[54] but these ideals had little effect on the system as a whole. It remained essentially one-sided so that "the almost exclusive addiction to linguistic and stylistic studies, the general neglect of natural and of social science, help to explain that perilous lack of resourcefulness and self-help which characterized Roman society after the second century".[55] Students were constantly induced to hark backwards to the masterpieces of ancient literature upon which they were supposed to model themselves. The basic aims of the system were clear and specific, to teach correct diction, an appreciation of the form and content of classical literature and, most importantly, the rules of rhetoric so that the students would be able to compose and deliver elegant and persuasive speeches.[56] This type of training had certainly been of practical use under the republic and even to a lesser extent in the early empire. In Victor's day this did not hold true. The subjects set for the students to illustrate their mastery of style and organization bore no relationship to everyday life but were chosen from history, mythology or the teacher's imagination. Innovation, whether in form or content, was frowned upon with the result that the system was conformist and sterile, those who passed through it capable only of pyrotechnic displays of pomp and stylistic ingenuity. This, then, was the cultural and educational heritage which Victor had received and which he chose to defend. It was the only one he knew but, just as significantly, it was the one which had

helped to create the social climate and opportunities whereby he had escaped his position as a rustic, provincial *humilior* and climbed into the ranks of the *honestiores*. The intellectual training of Roman schools and the imperial despotism which had come into being produced a habit of submission to authority and hindered originality and progress. Victor was therefore constrained not merely by his own limited abilities but also by the social and educational system under which he had grown up and from which he had undoubtedly benefited in his career. It would, indeed, have been remarkable if he had been sufficiently discerning and acute to criticize it.

Even non-military members of the fourth-century bureaucracy were seldom really well-educated or cultured[57] and Victor was no exception. Their general knowledge and philosophical reflections were superficial and flimsy. None the less these officials gained their positions by means of what education they had received and they despised and resented the military members of the bureaucracy.[58] In contrast they strove to assimilate the intellectual traditions of their predecessors. Openings at the imperial court, in the treasury, provincial governments and palatine ministries depended largely on education and eloquence. These accomplishments separated the bureaucrat from the common soldier or peasant and thus the standing of education had to be jealously maintained. Victor's work, then, appears to be, at least in part, a *cri du coeur* for he had plainly witnessed the erosion of education and its rewards and the preferment of military *agrestes*.[59] His sustained emphasis on culture and his defensive posture against the inroads of barbarism are therefore understandable and necessary consequences of his own experience and aspirations.[60]

# 7

## CAUSATION IN THE *DE CAESARIBUS*

Unlike his contemporaries Eutropius and Festus, Aurelius Victor did not write a simple, factual, biographical history as a neutral observer. He gave to his history a moralistic and occasionally philosophical tone somewhat in the manner of Sallust or Tacitus. But Victor was no philosopher; indeed, his work demonstrates no close contact with or appreciation of any major thinker of the ancient world.[1] Moreover, in spite of his many moralizations and his occasional reworking of traditional materials there appears to be no clear central thesis,[2] only a number of more or less important themes brought into the narrative rather haphazardly as a particular idea struck him.[3] This does not mean that Victor had not thought a great deal about history, politics and ethics: he claims, at any rate, that he had heard and read a lot and had considered his views with care.[4] Yet he did not possess the acute intellect, whether analytical or synthetical, necessary to construct a coherent philosophy of any kind.[5] Hence his ideas on historical causation tend to be ramshackle and self-contradictory.

Victor was a pagan, as his complete silence regarding Christianity, his obvious interest in portents and omens and his praise of Diocletian's concern for ancient beliefs prove.[6] His superstition, however, had its limits for on one occasion he accuses the *haruspices* of being totally ignorant of the truth. He proceeds to ask, "Who can be happy when decency is lost even if everything turns out well? If it is maintained intact everything else is tolerable."[7] The individual, therefore, is important and "there is nothing good or bad in the state which cannot be reversed by the character of those in power".[8] Furthermore Victor believed that the state, whatever its afflictions, could easily be set right by the virtues of its emperors and totally ruined by their faults.[9] In addition, the promotion of honest men and

the punishment of criminals were felt to have a historical effect.[10] Eutropius appears to share this view in his long, extremely positive eulogy of Antoninus Pius, particularly where he notes the emperor's selection of the most just men for his administration and his honouring of *boni*. The result was that friendly kings respected him as much as they feared him and very many barbarian nations put aside their arms, referred their disputes to him and obeyed his decisions.[11]

None the less the individual and the state were, according to Victor, sometimes at the mercy of forces beyond their control. Early in his work Victor maintains that the fact that the senate was unable to reassert itself after Caligula's assassination and that monarchical power was confirmed at Rome showed quite clearly that "human endeavours were unsupported by fortune and futile".[12] It is when he arrives at what he considered to be the watershed of Rome's history, however, that Victor makes his main statement of the relative importance of individuals and Fortune. Alexander Severus is first extolled for his respect for the senate and his love of justice. Victor goes on to note that the state grew in power gradually from the time of Romulus to that of Septimius and reached its pinnacle in Caracalla's reign. Alexander Severus' task was to ensure that it did not collapse. Unfortunately his successors were more interested in obtaining and maintaining power for themselves than in extending the empire, and the ensuing civil conflicts were ruinous for the state. Those who came to rule were a mixed bag, good and bad, some from the nobility, others from humble backgrounds and many of barbarian extraction. Victor blames the chaos which followed Alexander's death for making it possible for upstarts and incompetents to seize positions and responsibilities they could not handle and to downgrade educational achievements. Alexander's reign must have appeared to Victor to have been an extremely fortunate interlude between the disorder and debauchery of Elagabalus' brief rule and the period of anarchy after 235. It also provided the author with an example of the significance of the individual in history. But Victor still had somehow to explain the subsequent half-century of chaos. It is with the following highly rhetorical passage that he completed his personal reflections on Rome's decline in the third century:

> "In this way the power of Fortune obtains free play and drives mortals on through their pernicious lust. It was, to be sure, long held in check by virtue, as if by a wall, but after nearly all had been overcome by their disgraceful acts it entrusted the state to men of lowly birth and inadequate training."[14]

Victor's treatment of the relationship between virtue and Fortune generally accords with his belief that free will and human action are important in the course of history. Virtue, by itself, could bring success and good reputation, as in the case of Nerva, through the virtue of his successor, and of Constantine.[15] On the other hand Fortune, in a period of moral degeneracy, could throw the whole state into turmoil. This struggle between Fortune and virtue was occasioned by the introduction into Italy of the Hellenistic concept of *Fortuna-Tyche* which seems to have met with opposition from the Roman concept of *virtus* which Romans saw as a combination of those physical, mental and moral powers of the individual or state which created prosperity. Hence arose the peculiar Roman idea of a conflict between *virtus* and *fortuna* in which the good man could triumph because of his virtue. But if Roman *virtus* ever faltered, as it did according to Victor when Chaerea's *Romana virtus* removed the tyrant Caligula but was offset by the apathy of the citizenry, the result was wantonness, moral failure, greed and the destruction of liberty.[16] Fortune, unpredictable and often malicious, then dominated with disastrous results. The sluggish, timid Claudius was acclaimed emperor and he was followed by the monstrous Nero, civil wars and three unworthy upstarts. A similar occurrence followed Alexander Severus' death. That was how Maximinus, an almost illiterate soldier, had been able to seize power in 235 and set in motion a series of civil wars and calamities which were to continue for half a century. Victor could not explain it in any other way. Instead he seems to have recalled the readings and discussions of his schooldays and in particular Sallust whose disquisition on Fortune, avarice and ambition was presumably one of those purple passages dinned into generations of Roman schoolboys.[17]

Subsequently Victor remarks that Aemilianus was first declared a public enemy by the senate, then, upon the death of his predecessors, he was acclaimed emperor by the same body which bowed to Fortune, *as usual.*[18] The author further states that Aemilianus died of a disease. No other writer confirms either the senate's earlier *condemnatio* or Aemilianus' death by disease. Indeed, the Epitomator and Zosimus state explicitly that he was assassinated by his soldiers at Spoletium in Umbria,[19] while Eutropius merely notes that he died. It would appear that the K.G. was of little help to later writers at this point[20] and that Victor, left to his own devices, presumably inferred that Aemilianus was a victim of the plague and that the senate had condemned him as a public enemy since Gallus

and Volusianus were at Rome at the time of his acclamation. Victor then blamed Fortune for the senate's supposed turnabout.

Again, it was during the reign of an emperor who was to Victor and the Latin historians manifestly lacking in virtue, namely Gallienus, that chaos ensued in the Roman world so that men such as Marius seized power and respect for all virtues became a matter of scorn.[21] The phraseology seems once more to echo Sallust[22] and even though Fortune is not mentioned its influence is implied. Yet the emperor, in Victor's view, still retains his cardinal importance since his faults, however small, could readily be accepted as virtues and lead to imitation. Even Constantine, despite his undeniable good qualities, had appointed unworthy officials with dreadful consequences,[23]

The notion that Fortune was a powerful external force, the element of chance in human affairs, was hardly original.[24] For centuries poets and historians had exhibited a belief in her potent influence. Horace wrote:

> Fortuna saevo laeta negotio et
> ludum insolentem ludere pertinax
> transmutat incertos honores,
> nunc mihi, nunc alii benigna.[25]

Juvenal remarks that it is we ourselves who make Fortune a goddess,[26] while Pliny the Elder tells us that "We are so much at the mercy of chance that Chance is our god".[27] Nevertheless some, like Sallust in his preface to the *Jugurtha*,[28] had serious reservations. He forcefully argued there that what guides and controls human life is man's soul. In the *Catiline*, however, he wrote: "There can be no question that Fortune is supreme in all human affairs".[29] Subsequently he adds that when avarice and lust for power had destroyed integrity, honour and every other virtue Fortune turned nasty and confounded all Rome's enterprises.[30] Victor seems generally to follow this train of thought, though it is modified somewhat by his acceptance of the imperial system which could play no part in Sallust's thinking. Thus, in his final words after his eulogy of Constantius II,[31] he could state that the peace of the republic was ruled by the lives of good emperors. In those cases, one may infer, Fortune had met her match, overcome by the virtues of those in power.[32]

Stoicism entered Roman thought with Panaetius in the second century BC[33] and it appears to have introduced to the Romans the idea of inexorable Fate ('what will be').[34] Victor apparently accepted

its controlling power just as he accepted that of Fortune. The first instance of Fate playing a part in history in the *De Caesaribus* occurs in Victor's discussion of Titus' reign:

> "Do you see, he (Titus) said, that powers are granted by fate and it is vain to attempt a crime with the hope of gaining them or for fear of losing them?"[35]

This anecdote was originally in Suetonius[36] in a longer and more developed form and was presumably borrowed by Victor from the K.G. which had, in turn, taken it from the celebrated biographer. The notion that power was bestowed by an external force was clearly as appealing to Victor as it had been to earlier writers such as pseudo-Sallust and Dio.[37] Possibly it helped to explain for him the unfortunate brevity of the reign of this *generis humani deliciae* and the succession of that bane of the senate, Domitian. There may even have been a sort of natural law (as Victor remarks earlier) "which frequently, as if on purpose, creates bad men from good, uncultured men from quite learned ones".[38] Again this appears to be a topos which Victor found appropriate and convenient.[39] He may even have been rationalizing his own childlessness, actually believing that he might have produced a monster or an *agrestis* for a son.[40] Not only had Caligula, the son of Germanicus and grandson of Drusus, turned out thus, but so had Commodus, the son of Marcus Aurelius, as Victor observed.[41]

The next instance of Fate playing an important role in human affairs occurred in the reign of Carus. The emperor, so Victor avers, defeated the Persians but was driven by his excessive eagerness for glory to push on beyond Ctesiphon and was killed by a bolt of lightning. Certain authorities relate that he deserved this end for disregarding an oracle which declared that he would be allowed only to reach the city, whereas he determined to go far beyond:

> "Accordingly it is difficult to divert the fates and for that reason knowledge of the future is superfluous."[42]

Again Victor is to be distinguished from Eutropius, Festus and the Epitomator by virtue of his personal comments and his attitude towards Fate,[43] though all appear to have used the K.G. at this point.[44] The *H.A.*, on the other hand, takes a very strong stand against the timidity of such fatalists as Victor and its remarks on this event seem to be levelled directly against the latter.[45] It is possible that Victor was merely expressing an idea which may have derived from Cicero, that one cannot avoid what will be, so that it is useless to know the future.[46] This would imply a deterministic view of history.

Nevertheless Victor apparently contradicts himself shortly afterwards, when he attributes Diocletian's abdication in part to the emperor's investigations of the future which informed him that fate had in store civil wars and some kind of break-up of the Roman state.[47] Diocletian, so it seems, was superstitious and did investigate the future. Lactantius, his contemporary, retails the same information as Victor, though with a different objective in mind.[48] It is clear from Victor's final statement on Diocletian that there had been considerable discussion of the reasons for the emperor's abdication (as there still is) and Victor came down firmly on the side of Diocletian, as did Eutropius.[49] Furthermore, Victor seems to have believed that although the emperor could not alter what Fate had decreed for the state he could refuse to be party to the events, which would lead one to infer that he believed in a sort of limited free will. If one accepts this view it follows that Victor believed that Carus could have made a different decision after the capture of Ctesiphon which would have changed subsequent events. It is, however, also possible that Victor simply saw an opportunity to insert a *bon mot* to explain a historical event which Diocletian and his supporters had cleverly obfuscated. This would imply that Victor had not discerned any causal connection between his two statements and possessed an ambiguous view of free will and Fate.

Victor also appears to have believed in the cyclic theory of history espoused by the Stoics, that is to say he subscribed to a view of the natural law of the circle in human affairs. After discussing the reign of Aurelian he informs us that an *interregnum* occurred similar to that following Romulus' rule but much more glorious. He goes on to state:

> "This fact has particularly demonstrated that everything turns back on itself in the manner of a circle and that nothing takes place which the power of nature cannot reproduce in the space of time. In addition it shows that the state, whatever its afflictions, can easily be set right by the virtues of its emperors and totally ruined by their faults, however strong it is."[50]

Human societies, like man himself, grow from infancy to manhood, decline into old age and end in death, whereupon a new cycle begins afresh.[51] This biological or organic theory of ἀνακύκλωσις can be traced back to Anaximander and was subsequently set in a political context by Plato and Aristotle. Nevertheless the first historian to attempt to combine the schemes of growth-acme-decline and the cyclical movement appears to have been Polybius, although it has been argued by Momigliano that Polybius confined his meditations

on cycles to his theory of constitutions and forgot it when he was composing his historical narrative.[52] Sallust, in his extant works, also discusses the growth and decay of the state,[53] but he attributes the decline of the state to the caprice of Fortune without reference to a historical cycle. Whether in his lost works he advanced a view similar to that of Victor cannot, of course, be demonstrated; but Tacitus certainly admits the possibility of a cycle in all things in the *Annals*.[54]

Victor's statements in the passage quoted above seem to be an attempt to combine two theories, first that history can repeat itself, and second that history can be influenced by powerful individuals such as emperors.[55] But what of lesser individuals? Here we must turn to an earlier comment by Victor who remarks that Nero allowed a Parthian ambassador, who had demanded a free-born lyre player, to take whomsoever he wanted from among his (Nero's) subjects. This showed those who were present that no one could be considered free *sub imperio*.[56] The author, who must have witnessed numerous instances of incompetence, injustice and corruption,[57] presumably felt angry, frustrated and powerless in such cases. Here, as elsewhere, he appears simply to have expressed his strongly-felt emotions.[58] They generally conform with those of any moderately sensitive individual who has found himself oppressed or thwarted by agencies or officials more influential and powerful than himself. That the emperors understood this problem is demonstrated by the establishment of the office of *defensor civitatis* first recorded in 322 in Arabia and noted in Egypt after 330 and later in the reign of Valentinian and Valens. In general the *defensor* was to be the patron of the *plebs* against the injuries of the powerful and, although the office was not a total success, it did provide cheap and accessible courts of justice for the poor.[59]

A few years ago the celebrated physicist Erwin Schrödinger summarized the average person's attitude to history. He wrote:

> "The reason why man tends to regard history, in the narrower and the wider sense, as a predestined happening, controlled by rules and laws that he cannot change, is very obvious. It is because every individual feels that he, by himself, has very little say in the matter unless he can put his opinions over to many others and persuade them to regulate their behaviour accordingly."[60]

Schrödinger, in my opinion, sums up in a reasonably adequate manner what Victor felt about history. One of the reasons why Victor wrote the *De Caesaribus* was to publicize his views and persuade those who could influence the march of events to do so in a way

which he considered fitting and proper. Victor realistically supposed that most men act for purely selfish reasons rather than for the good of the state, for the sake of power rather than for reputation. For this reason, he notifies us, institutions and titles had been corrupted and all too often a man who had seized power by some criminal act and force of arms claimed to have removed a tyrant when in fact he had simply suppressed his adversaries to the public loss.[61] Nevertheless history would have its revenge.

> "If faith in history had not stood in opposition, for it does not allow honourable men to be cheated of the reward of being remembered or wicked men to achieve an everlasting, glorious reputation, virtue would be pursued in vain since that true and unique honour could be granted through partiality to the worst of men and impiously denied to the good."[62]

This, as far as one can tell, is Victor's notion of the *raison d'être* of history. It is traditional. Tacitus states that he regards it as history's highest function to let no worthy action go uncommemorated and to hold out the censure of posterity to obstruct evil words and deeds.[63] A similar sentiment is expressed in the preface of Livy's Roman History and of Diodorus Siculus' Universal History.[64] The Epitomator, too, after retailing Caligula's vices, is doubtful about the propriety of including such information in a historical work, "unless, perhaps, it is helpful to know everything about the emperor so that the wicked may shun such acts at least through fear of their reputation".[65] Victor concludes his disquisition on history by proclaiming that emperors and the best of men reach heaven or are worshipped like gods because of the glory of their lives rather than because of the titles they have collected.[66] Consequently one must infer that Victor felt it was the duty of the historian to ensure that all emperors, good or bad, obtained their just deserts. That is why Victor informed us that Gallienus would always be compared with the worst emperors and that his deification was obviously extorted. Neither Eutropius nor the Epitomator are nearly so vitriolic in their accounts of that emperor's reign.[67] They plainly perceived their task as historians in a different light and were more concerned to record events and allow them to be judged by the reader.[68] Victor, on the other hand, wished to persuade the reader to share his own views.

It appears likely that Victor had indeed asked himself most of these fundamental questions of historical causation so aptly summarized by Mazzolani:

> "Did history obey its own hidden laws? Were events determined

> by fate or the will of the gods? Was there an inscrutable power behind the workings of history or was that disconnected chain of events, that waste of human lives, that headlong race of every sovereign state towards its own end, merely the result of chance?"[69]

Nevertheless, as we have seen, Victor's conclusions are generally inconsistent. On occasions he emphasizes the important part played by the individual in shaping history[70] and views history as a struggle between virtue and unpredictable Fortune in which the virtue of the individual or the state can triumph. In periods of moral decadence, however, when virtue is disregarded, Fortune shows herself to be particularly malicious and potent. On other occasions Victor appears to be quite deterministic and is seen as such by the author of the *H.A.* who berates him soundly for it. Presumably, like most of his contemporaries in the fourth century, he was unaware of the illogicality of his ambiguous beliefs, although that illogicality had, in fact, been pointed out in the previous century by the philosopher Alexander of Aphrodisias.[71] Yet Victor did feel that the writing of history played a fundamental role in regulating the morality of rulers and through them of men in general.[72] Although this notion, too, was not original, it helped to set the *De Caesaribus* apart from the other abbreviated histories of the fourth century and imbued the work with a colour and tone entirely lacking in that of Victor's fellow abbreviators.

# 8

## STYLE AND LANGUAGE

Any reader of the *De Caesaribus* and of Eutropius' *Breviarium* will immediately notice striking differences. Eutropius viewed republican and imperial history as a whole. He was content to efface himself from his account, to give simply the salient facts and chronology of events without rendering judgement or providing psychological insights. Throughout he remained objective and wrote in such a clear and sober style that his work "became the textbook of the Middle Ages, of the Byzantine world, and of the humanists".[1] In contrast Victor restricted himself to imperial history. Furthermore, his personality frequently shines through his work. He used such terms as *ego*, *mihi*, *nos*, *nobis*, *meus* and verbs in the first person,[2] and he expressed his private views vigorously in the many moralizing passages.[3] To each reign he attempted to give a certain tone by his choice of material, his interpretation of events and his assessment of character. Finally, he often shifted from the transmission of significant facts to the narration of idle, jejune or even scurrilous anecdotes.[4] As a consequence the *De Caesaribus* is uneven in content and lacking in homogeneity, quite unlike the *Breviarium*. The reason: Victor was not only a moralist, he also attempted to be a stylist in the tradition of Sallust and Tacitus.[5] It is in those deeply personal, moralizing passages that Victor's language becomes tortuous, occasionally tantalizing and extremely perplexing to translate.[6] Sokolov, who translated the *De Caesaribus* into Russian, aptly described it as frequently bombastic and difficult[7] and Schanz branded it "aufgedunsen und überladen".[8]

The major influence on Victor's style was undoubtedly the historian Sallust, whose views of the importance of morality in historical writing and of the potency and whimsicality of Fortune in human affairs were apparently adopted by the fourth-century

author.[9] Sallust's fame and literary reputation were well-established by the first century AD and endured beyond the fourth.[10] He had become "the classic historian *par excellence – historiae maior auctor* ... whom the men of letters, scholars and teachers alike regarded as the first among Roman historians".[11] Victor had clearly studied Sallust at school and presumably read the republican historian subsequently in his more mature years with the result that there are a large number of Sallustian expressions or reminiscences in the *De Caesaribus*, most of which Wölfflin and Opitz collected approximately a century ago.[12] The following examples are indicative of Victor's indebtedness:

| VICTOR | SALLUST |
|---|---|
| satis compertum (5.3; 19.3); mihi plane compertum (11.13) | nobis satis cognitum est (*Jug.* 82.3); periculo atque negotiis compertum (*Cat.* 2.2) |
| quare compertum est (40.13); quibus rebus compertum habeo (39.5) | compertum ego habeo (*Cat.* 58.1) |
| luxus lasciviaque (14.6; 31.2); luxuria ludorumque cupidine (1.4); luxuriae aut etiam crudelitati (6.1); voluptati luxuriaeque (20.8); corrupto per licentiam ingenio (5.3); fortunae vis licentiam (24.11) | lubido atque luxuria (*Cat.* 28.4; *Jug.* 89.6); laetitia atque lascivia (*Cat.* 31. 1); licentia atque lascivia (*Jug.* 39.5); ludus et lascivia (*Jug.* 66.2); luxus atque licentia (*Hist.* 1.48.11D); sed postquam luxu atque desidia civitas corrupta est (*Cat.* 53.5) |
| annitente Tito (9.11); militibus annitentibus (24.1); cunctis annitentibus (40.4) | adnitente Crasso (*Cat.* 19.1); nullo circum adnitente (*Hist.* 4.61.14D) |
| Romanum statum quasi abrupto praecipitavere (24.9) | mores non paulatim ... sed torrentis modo praecipitati (*Hist.* 1. 12D) |
| aquae penuria fatigabat (28.1) | fames fatigabat (*Hist.* 3.34D; cf. inopia aquae fatigabat, Tac. *Hist.* 5.3) |
| adulescentis fluxo ingenio (32.4); fluxo cultu (3.12) | eorum (i.e. adulescentium) animi molles et fluxi (*Cat.* 14.5) |
| Ingebum ... imperandi cupido incessit (33.2) | tanta cupido gloriae incesserat (*Cat.* 7.3); lubido incesserat (*Cat.* 13.3) |
| par similisque semper ipsi habetur (33.29) | par similisque ceteris efficiebatur (*Cat.* 14.4) |
| milites frustra fore (37.3) | illi (i.e. nobiles) frustra sint (*Jug.* 85.6) |
| divitiarum usum affluentiamque (37. 7) | otium atque divitiae ... adfluerent (*Cat.* 36.4) |
| quo officio adulescentiam mercede exercuerat (39.20) | ibique iuventutem suam exercuit (*Cat.* 5.2) |

| VICTOR | SALLUST |
|---|---|
| incredibile quantum laetitia gaudioque senatus et plebes exultaverint (40.24) | plebs ... gaudium atque laetitiam agitabat (*Cat.* 48.1) |
| reipublicae permixtionem (41.14) | quasi permixtio terrae (*Jug.* 41.40) |
| cibi omnis, libidinis atque omnium cupidinum victor (42.23) | lubidinis et divitiarum victor (*Jug.* 63.2) |
| Claudius ... ventri foede oboediens (4.1) | velut pecora quae natura prona atque ventri oboedientia finxit (*Cat.* 1.1) |
| uti verum absolvam brevi (42.24) | uti paucis verum absolvam (*Cat.* 38. 3); cetera quam paucissumis absolvam (*Jug.* 17.2) |
| bonis initiis deinde perniciosus (2.1) | bonis initiis malos eventus habuit (*Cat.* 11.4) |
| suos pariter externosque (2.1) | suorum et hostium res pariter (*Jug.* 88.2) |
| flagitiis obtentui (2.2) | vitiis obtentui (*Hist.* 1.41.24) |
| carus acceptusque (3.4) | carus acceptusque (*Jug.* 12.3; 70.2; 108.1 *et al.*) |
| nactus potestatem (3.8); potestatem nacti summam (4.12); summam potestatem (31.1) | summam potestatem nacti (*Cat.* 38.1) |
| in pravum abstractus (4.5) | in pravum abstractus est (*Jug.* 29.2) |
| uti pigeat pudeatque (5.4) | pudeat magis an pigeat (*Jug.* 95.4; *Hist.* 1.48.14) |
| neque suae neque aliorum pudicitiae parcens (5.5) | si ipse pudicitiae ... pepercit (*Cat.* 52.33) |
| ni ... subvenisset, tantum facinus haud dubie patraretur (5.15); facinus patravere (35.8) | quod ni Catilina maturasset ... pessumum facinus patratum foret (*Cat.* 18.8) |
| vastare cuncta et polluere (6.1) | polluere et vastare omnia (*Jug.* 41.9) |
| propinquare hostes (8.6) | propinquare amnem (*Hist.* 4.62) |
| e tugurio, quo se abdiderat (8.6) | occultans se in tugurio (*Jug.* 12.5) |
| paucis attigi (8.7) | paucis ... attingere (*Jug.* 17.1) |
| exsanguem diu fessumque (9.1) | defessis et exanguibus (*Cat.* 39.4) |
| coepta seu patrata (9.7) | coeptum atque patratum (*Jug.* 21.2) |
| imperium adeptus (10.1) | imperium ... adepti sunt (*Jug.* 85.1) |
| ab mihi audienti multa legentique (11.13) | sed mihi multa legenti, multa audienti (*Cat.* 53.2) |
| nos rem in medio relinquemus (14.9) | nos eam rem in medio relinquemus (*Cat.* 19.6) |

| VICTOR | SALLUST |
|---|---|
| cum animo parum valeret (14.10) | parum animo valuisse (*Jug.* 11.5) |
| boni malique, nobiles atque ignobiles (24.9) | strenui boni, nobiles atque ignobiles (*Cat.* 20.7); boni malique, strenui et imbelles (*Jug.* 67.2) |
| cupientissimo vulgo imperium capit (29.3) | cupientissuma plebe consul factus (*Jug.* 84.1) |
| adulta aestate (32.3) | adulta aestas (*Hist. inc.* 112) |
| supra vota cedentibus (33.3) | rebus supra vota fluentibus (*Hist. inc.* 101) |
| ne imperium ad optimos nobilium transferretur (33.34) | imperium ad optumum quemque transfertur (*Cat.* 2.6) |
| palustri solo hiemalibus aquis (37.4) | planities limosa hiemalibus aquis paludem fecerat (*Jug.* 37.4) |
| inter implana urbis atque ipso sinu (27.2) | intra moenia atque in sinu urbis (*Cat.* 52.35) |
| uti passim domus fora viae templa cruore atque cadaveribus opplerentur (42.7) | fana atque domos spoliari, caedem incendia fieri, postremo armis cadaveribus cruore atque luctu omnia compleri (*Cat.* 51.9) |

Other Sallustian usages to be found in the *De Caesaribus* are *quis* for *quibus*,[13] *quippe*, *uti*, *ceterum*, *quidem*, *abunde*, *maturrime*, *igitur* at the beginning of sentences, the employment of frequentatives, historical infinitives, such words as *anteire*, *occipere*, *impensius*, *ea tempestate*, *immane quantum*, *res adflictae*. In addition Victor showed a predilection for the verbs *queo* and *nequeo*, as did Sallust, using *possum* only fifteen times.[14] Moreover Victor clearly preferred the third person plural form in *-ere* and used the regular form in *-erunt* only twice (*De Caes.* 11.9; 25.2). Tacitus had shown a similar inclination.

Even more striking, however, is Victor's fondness for *metus* (used twenty-eight times and found abundantly in Sallust), *libido* and *cupido* (never *cupiditas*), both of which Sallust plainly prefers. The following is a further list of words used by Victor and by Sallust in the *Catiline* and *Jugurtha* only:

| | VICTOR | SALLUST |
|---|---|---|
| aerumnae | 2 | 5 |
| agito | 6 | 47 |
| anxius | 3 | 9 |
| cupido | 4 | 19 |
| facundia | 2 | 5 |
| fatigo* | 1 | 11 |
| formido | 2 | 11 |

| | | |
|---|---|---|
| grassor | 4 | 2 |
| nitor | 3 | 18 |
| occulto | 4 | 6 |
| opulentus | 1 | 9 |
| patro | 7 | 9 |
| pergo | 2 | 17 |
| polleo | 1 | 7 |
| pravus | 3 | 6 |
| reor | 4 | 26 |
| socordia | 3 | 12 |
| sustento | 2 | 4 |
| tempto / tento | 11 | 27 |
| cassus | 1 | 1 |
| laetus | 2 | 9[15] |

Synonyms can also be instructive. Sallust showed a clear preference for certain adjectives and nouns and occasionally Victor's choice again appears to have been influenced by his republican predecessor.[16]

| | VICTOR | SALLUST |
|---|---|---|
| aerumnae | 2 | 6 |
| calamitas | 1 | 3 |
| miseria | 1 | 15 |
| crudelitas | 1 | 3 |
| saevitia | 5 | 8 |
| formido | 2 | 18 |
| metus | 28 | 59 |
| pavor | 0 | 1 |
| terror | 0 | 8 |
| timor | 0 | 13 |
| cupido | 4 | 23 |
| cupiditas | 0 | 3 |
| libido / lubido | 14 | 36 |
| desidia | 3 | 3 |
| ignavia[17] | 0 | 21 |
| inertia[17] | 0 | 5 |
| socordia | 3 | 17 |
| eloquentia | 4 | 2 |
| facundia | 2 | 7 |

One final point regarding 'Sallustian' vocabulary. Sallust seems to have created the neologism *favor*:[18] it also appears in *De Caesaribus* 13.13.

From the abundant examples noted above it is obvious that Victor was deeply indebted to Sallust in matters of style. What is not quite so clear is the extent to which he was influenced by other writers, in particular Tacitus. It was possibly the imperial historian's influence which caused him regularly to omit the auxiliary verb *esse*

and to use participial clauses for the sake of conciseness. Certainly the author of the *Annals* coloured Victor's opening remarks:[19]

| *DE CAESARIBUS* 1.1 | *ANNALS* 1.2 |
|---|---|
| illectis per dona militibus atque annonae curandae specie vulgo, ceteros haud difficulter subegit. | ubi militem donis, populum annona, cunctos dulcedine otii pellexit, insurgere paulatim ... |

Furthermore, in his description of Tiberius, Victor uses the phrase *subdolus et occultior* (2.1), a reflection of Tacitus' *occultum ac subdolum* (*Ann.* 6.51.5); it is given as the emperor's motive for his self-exile on Capri *dum urbem et conventus exsecratur* (2.2), recalling Tacitus' statement *perosus municipia et colonias* (*Ann.* 4.67.1). *Subdolus* is found seven times in the *Annals*, only once in Tacitus' other works, but its most striking use is in the depiction of Tiberius. This is the only occasion when it is employed by Victor. One may reasonably conclude that it was one of those Taciteanisms which can so readily remain imprinted in one's memory and did so in Victor's case.[20] Again, Victor's comparison of Julian with Tiberius and Galerius *subiecti aliis egregia pleraque, suo autem ductu atque auspicio minus paria experti sint* (42.19) seems to be a reflection of Tacitus' summation of Tiberius: *egregium vita famaque, quod privatus vel in imperiis sub Augusto fuit; occultum et subdolum ...* (*Ann.* 6.51.5).

In addition, Victor's remarkable, fatalistic utterance *quod factum edocuit, cuncta in orbis modo verti nihilque accidere, quod rursum naturae vis ferre nequeat aevi spatio* (35.13) echoes a statement to that effect by Tacitus: *nisi forte rebus cunctis inest quidam velut orbis, ut quemadmodum temporum vices, ita morum vertantur* (*Ann.* 3.55.6). Victor also invariably employs the conjunction *ni* to introduce negative conditions in the manner of Tacitus, reserving *nisi* for nouns or adjectives.[21] The earlier author uses *ni* sixty-seven times in his *Histories* and *Annals*.[22]

There are occasions, however, when one cannot be certain whether Victor was influenced primarily by Sallust or by Tacitus in his use of vocabulary, for Tacitus himself wrote while very much under the spell of the republican historian. Such words as *patro*, *sustento*, *socordia* and *cupido* which Victor employed were favourites of both earlier writers; *grassor* was used by Sallust but appeared more frequently in Tacitus' *Histories* and *Annals*. *Incuria*, *felicitas* and *verecundia*, on the other hand, are Tacitean words not attested in Sallust: Victor has them (33.20; 34.6; 5.10). There seems no reason to doubt, therefore, that both Sallust and Tacitus[23] served as stylistic models for the author of the *De Caesaribus*.

Victor's employment of participial clauses is instructive and is one feature which sets the *De Caesaribus* part from the *Epitome*. Again he may owe much to Tacitus although he clearly lacked the latter's ability and his use tends to be at times ill-judged and excessive.[24] For example, he can begin sentences with two ablative absolute constructions[25] and sometimes he actually constructs a single sentence with four ablative absolutes.[26] This attempt to condense a mass of information into a small compass is extremely clumsy. On other occasions Victor ends his periods weakly with participial constructions or ablative expressions, e.g. *eius ductu Persae, cum primum superavissent, ad extremum triumpho cessere, rege Vologeso*.[27] A further characteristic of Victor's style is the use of present participles in place of causal or relative clauses, often with tortuous consequences.[28] The resultant prose is understandably ugly and often so difficult to comprehend that it confused the scribes.[29] Victor was presumably trying to avoid a series of short and choppy sentences caused by his need to prune his material and accordingly this led to his combining incongruous scraps of information, as in 10.5:

> "Ita biennio post ac menses fere novem amphitheatri perfecto opere lautusque veneno interiit, anno aevi quadragesimo, cum eius pater septuagesimo obisset, imperator decennii."

As Nixon points out, this infelicitous and inappropriate association of architectural notices and vital statistics is further marred by the author's forgetfulness.[30] Victor also feels constrained occasionally to combine two anecdotes, with unfortunate consequences, as when he confusingly inserts the Parthian envoy to link two incidents exemplifying Nero's treacherous treatment of his subjects.[31]

As is the case with most authors Victor exhibits a significant number of personal preferences in his choice of words and expressions. The following is a list of his preferences additional to those already noted as Sallustian or Tacitean:

| | |
|---|---|
| abhinc | 13.12; 24.9; 37.5; 41.15 |
| adhuc | 3.2; 4.3; 9.8; 13.5; 24.6; 35.14; 39.23; 39.45; 40.20; 40.26; 41.23; 42.24 |
| aegre / aegerrime | 9.9; 11.10; 13.2; 33.25; 39.48; 40.23; 41.17; 42.20 |
| arduus / ardua | 16.9; 20.20; 33.13; 38.5; 41.6; 42.4 |
| confestim[32] | 11.2; 16.3; 17.10; 20.32; 24.2; 24.9; 41.23 |
| gratia + genitive | 4.11; 5.2; 20.20; 29.1; 39.16; 40.10; 41.6; 41.14 |

| | |
|---|---|
| hincque | 1.6; 11.6; 14.8; 16.5; 19.3; 23.1 |
| huiuscemodi | 3.5; 3.12; 5.4; 20.3; 20.12; 27.5; 35.7; 35.11; 39.12; 41.24 |
| longe | 2.1; 3.5; 5.2; 8.4; 9.2; 11.12; 14.9; 15.5; 16.1; 15.5; 16.1; 20.23; 28.8; 33.7; 35.12; 39.18 |
| magis magisque | 11.7; 12.4; 23.3; 39.12 |
| mortales = homines[33] | 3.20; 12.3; 16.14; 24.11; 28.7; 33.30 |
| plus quam | 11.2; 13.5; 20.13; 24.5; 39.3 |
| praecipue / praecipua | 8.7; 11.13; 17.1; 20.2; 40.12; 40.15 |
| sanus / sane | 3.17; 4.11; 5.6; 5.13; 10.6; 20.33; 27.1; 31.3; 33.29; 36.1; 37.3; 39.26; 39.32; 39.40; 39.46; 40.11; 41.6; 41.17; 41.23 |
| satellites | 4.10; 9.2; 17.7; 33.31 |
| usque | 13.3; 13.9; 16.13; 17.1; 33.3; 35.6; 40.20 |
| uti solet/uti mos est[34] | 5.14; 13.9; 16.7; 20.33; 29.2; 31.3; 32.2; 33.17; 34.8 |
| bonis indocti | 9.12 |
| boni malive / boni malique | 13.7; 24.9 |
| malos e bonis | 3.5 |

In the use of *ac* and *atque* Victor is particularly strict: before vowels *atque* is invariably employed, before consonants generally *ac* except before *c* when *et* is normally used.[35] In the choice of coordinating conjunctions, however, the author displays a good deal of variety although he reveals a distinct preference for *tamen*, which occurs thirty-three times, and *namque*, which occurs on twenty-nine occasions. His other favourites are *ita* (21), *nam* (18), *at* (17), *sed* and *igitur* (16 each), *qua causa* (10), *quin etiam* (8), *dein / deinde* (6), *ceterum* (5) and *idcirco / iccirco* (5). Other very common coordinatives such as *autem* (3), *itaque* (2) and *enim* (1) are conspicuous because of their rarity in the *De Caesaribus*.

On occasions Victor was clearly guilty of the monotonous repetition of certain words and constructions but in general he did strive for diversity. For example he admitted such abstract nouns as *honestas*, *humanitas*, *felicitas* and *sanitas* which are not to be found in Sallust's extant works.[36] Furthermore, like Tacitus, he sometimes couples nouns governed by *per* with modal ablatives or locatives[37] or recasts phrases in common use (*non modo domi, verum militiae quoque*).[38] Alliteration, which plays a large part in Sallust's style,[39] is employed by Victor too, mostly with moderation[40] but not always. In the final eighteen lines of his book commencing with *cum externis motibus modo civilibus exercetur, aegre ab armis abest. quis tyrannide tantorum* ..., he intemperately overworks the technique.

The *De Caesaribus* also includes a number of metaphors and *bon mots* to animate the narrative. Some were perhaps borrowed from previous writers like Suetonius, probably via the K.G.[41] or were commonplace[42] but one or two may have been original, such as the one traducing Julia Domna *quippe quae pudorem velamento exuerat*[43] or the anecdote about the pretender Marius:

> "Hinc denique ioculariter dictum nequaquam mirum videri, si rem Romanam Marius reficere contenderet, quam Marius eiusdem artis auctor stirpisque ac nominis solidavisset."[44]

Finally, in this regard, on several occasions Victor seems to have modified the plain wording of his source in order to introduce more impressive words and phrases or to give the narrative polish and elegance. Thus, whereas Eutropius in describing the death of Pertinax writes quite simply: *octogesimo imperii die praetorianum militum seditione et Iuliani scelere occisus est*,[45] Victor moralizes and elaborates: *eum milites, quis exhausto iam perditoque orbe satis videtur nihil, impulsore Didio foede iugulavere octogesimo imperii die*.[46] Immediately afterwards he eschews what was probably the K.G.'s unadorned statement of Julianus' background, *vir nobilis ac iure peritissimus*,[47] and concocts instead: *genus ei pernobile iurisque urbani praestans scientia*.[48] Further examples of Victor's embellishment of his source are probably to be seen in his descriptions of Valerian's capture, Aurelian's death, the reign of Tacitus, Diocletian's execution of Aper *et al.*[49]

Victor wrote in a style which he considered fitting for an educated man of his day and suitable for a moralistic interpretation of imperial history. In the fourth century that meant modelling oneself on one of the great republican writers, in particular Sallust, whose reputation had stood high since the first century AD and apparently never waned.[50] Unfortunately Victor lacked the ability to assimilate the style of his chosen model and make it his own. Furthermore he was incapable of animating his prose with a mordant phrase here and there or a striking figure of speech. He quite lacked the *immortalis velocitas* of Sallust or the majestic dignity of Tacitus and deliberately eschewed the easy simplicity of Eutropius. As a consequence Victor's Latin was heavily affected, its word order often tortuous, full of unnecessarily involved sentences and artificial conceits.[51] Probably it was his style more than any other aspect of his work which made the *De Caesaribus* unpopular in later years, when readers turned with apparent relief to the direct and unembellished account of Eutropius. The latter ended his work with the following

statement: *nam reliqua stylo maiore dicenda sunt: quae nunc non tam praetermittimus, quam ad maiorem scribendi diligentiam reservamus.*[52] Victor made no such disclaimer.

## APPENDIX I

### *EXEMPLA* IN THE *DE CAESARIBUS*

Victor's use of *exempla* is a conspicuous feature of his work. For the Romans these concise examples of memorable deeds or sayings (or both) formed an indispensable part of their education. They were gathered from the nation's history and many were actually mythical but were presented and received as historical fact.[1] Romans had a strong sense of history and a deep respect for the actions and opinions of their ancestors. They not only themselves judged antiquity, but believed that they would be likewise judged by posterity.[2] It was a belief which Victor clearly shared and explicitly stated.[3] In all probability he had been compelled, like his fellow students, to memorize lists of notable *exempla* at school.[4] Even by Cicero's time such lists had been categorized and published as works of reference.[5] Historians and biographers formed another important source of *exempla* as both Livy (in his preface) and Claudian note;[6] indeed, the fourth-century historians Ammianus and Eunapius make extensive use of them.[7] It is natural, then, that Victor as a historian and contemporary of the last-mentioned writers, should follow the prevailing fashion and include a selection of *exempla* in the *De Caesaribus*.

The *exempla* serve various purposes which often overlap but are, almost without exception, morally slanted. They show that Victor, like his more celebrated admirer, Ammianus, favoured a general moral reformation in keeping with his notion of the ideal ruler and administrator. Thus the *exempla* demonstrate to the reader which vices to avoid, which virtues to follow. Furthermore, examples embellish the narrative, display Victor's erudition, especially when he could furnish extra details to inform unenlightened readers, and underline a continuity with Rome's past. They also add to the reputation of the characters under discussion by means of comparisons with heroes of bygone ages and sometimes clarify recent

events by appeal to exploits and figures of the well-known past. Finally, they can serve as 'proof' to make the doubtful more plausible by analogy.

In addition to the introduction of monarchical, republican or early imperial stories, metaphors and similes as *exempla*, Victor seems to have shared Livy's conception of his work as almost a catalogue of examples. In his preface Livy writes:

> "The prime profit and utility of the study of historical events is that you may observe examples of every type of behaviour set down in glorious record, from which you can select what you and your country might imitate, and those of disgraceful inception and outcome which you can avoid."[8]

Victor, too, put forward many of his main characters and their activities as prime examples of virtues and vices, with the aim of influencing, if possible, the behaviour of his contemporaries and in particular those in power. Tacitus had already stated:

> "This I regard as history's highest function, to let no worthy action be uncommemorated, and to hold out the reprobation of posterity as a terror to evil words and deeds." (*Ann.* 3.65.1)

With this one should compare *De Caesaribus* 33.26 and 34.6 where a similar sentiment is clearly expressed.[9]

There are numerous *exempla* in the *De Caesaribus*, some brief, others extensive, eleven employing monarchical or republican figures, but the unifying factor in practically all is that they serve a moralistic purpose and tend to sharpen the points the author wishes to make. In Victor's view, as in that of Ammianus, virtue is regarded as a powerful historical agent and the author is convinced that the use of *exempla* (which is in keeping with the moral-didactic tradition of ancient historiography) is justified as a cogent, persuasive tool of the trade. As Blockley pointedly observes with regard to Ammianus Marcellinus:

> "Such expressions can be dismissed as mere rhetoric of a very artificial and self-conscious kind. But they would probably not have seemed so to a Roman of the fourth century A.D., who had been educated in the classical tradition, which did use *exempla* as one of its methods of inculcating standards of behaviour."[10]

| **De Caesaribus** | **Exempla** |
|---|---|
| 3.5-6 | Example of Caligula leads many wise men to remain childless. |
| 3.14-15 | Chaerea's assassination of Caligula might have been a repeat of Brutus' ejection of Tarquinius if Romans had served in the |

| De Caesaribus | Exempla |
|---|---|
| | army and their moral fibre had been intact. |
| 4.1; 4.5; 4.15 | Claudius as example of a dullard obedient to his advisers. When they were good the empire prospered. When Messalina and the freedmen were in charge tyranny resulted. |
| 5.3ff. | Nero at first was an example that age is no barrier to virtue, but the young are easily corrupted and disaster follows. |
| 11.12-13 | Foreigners like Tarquinius Priscus could be better rulers than native Romans. This looks forward to Nerva "the Cretan" as an exemplary ruler. |
| 13.6-7 | Anatolius, the exemplary administrator, demonstrates that all can be changed for good or bad by the character of those in power. |
| 13.9 | Trajan as an example of integrity. |
| 13.10 | Trajan as an example of how to control one's vices, in this case *vinolentia*. |
| 14.2-4 | Hadrian devotes himself to ceremonies, laws, schools and scholars like the Greeks or Pompilius Numa. |
| 14.9 | Hadrian's relationship with Antinous shows that friendship between men so disparate in age tends to arouse suspicion. |
| 15.3 | Antoninus Pius an example of how a faultless character cannot be spoilt by long peace and leisure. |
| 16.2 | Conduct of Marcus Aurelius' wife shows that even a blameless ruler can have his reputation marred by his wife. |
| 16.10 | Marcus Aurelius as example of the emperor as patron of *artes bonae*. |
| 17.1 | Commodus as example of the exceptional hatred engendered by those who corrupt their family reputation. |
| 18.1 | Pertinax recalls the old-fashioned virtues of the Curii and Fabricii. |
| 19.1 | Didius Julianus as example of the futility of learning if it is not accompanied by strength of character. |
| 20.2 | Overwhelming importance of *doctae artes* shown by the fact that Sept. Severus could not erase Julianus' "accomplishments". |
| 28.8-9 | Philip's failure to restrict male prostitution an example of man seeking more avidly what is dangerous and illicit. |
| 29.5 | Death of Decius an example of an emperor putting state above himself. |
| 33.11 | Marius the usurper recalls the republican hero and restorer of the state (ironic). |
| 33.13 | *Actuarii* as example of corruption in the army bureaucracy. |

| De Caesaribus | Exempla |
|---|---|
| 34.1ff. | Claudius II recalls the self-sacrifice of the republican Decii. |
| 37.2-4 | Probus likened to Hannibal in his use of troops for agricultural purposes. |
| 39.2-6 | Diocletian, like republican Marius, as an example of men of lowly origin, regardless of character, becoming excessively arrogant and ambitious. |
| 39.24 | Diocletian's marriage alliances likened to that of Augustus and Tiberius through Julia. |
| 39.48 | Diocletian's abdication: an example of a good emperor overcoming his ambition. |
| 40.12-15 | Constantius I and Galerius as examples of men of good character lacking education. Cyrus, King of Persia, acquired eternal repute by possessing *eruditio*, *elegantia*, *comitas*. |
| 42.18-19 | Julian compared with Tiberius and Galerius to show that some princes could achieve more under the direction of others than when ruling. |
| 42.22 | Constantius II established King for Sarmatians: compared with Pompey restoring Tigranes. |

## APPENDIX II

### VICTOR'S ESTIMATION OF THE EMPERORS

| Emperors | Positive Comments | Negative Comments |
|---|---|---|
| Augustus | gentle (1.1); urbane, charming, admired learning (1.4); honoured men of learning and his relatives, devoted to eloquence and religion (1.5); clement, given titles *pater patriae*, *trib. pot. perpetuo*; deified while alive and after death (1.6). | passion for luxury and games, liked sleep excessively (1.4). |
| Tiberius | | cunning, dissembling, hypercritical, sexually depraved, punished excessively both guilty and innocent, his relatives as well as others (2.1); neglected military matters, many areas under Roman rule destroyed (2.3). |
| Caligula | good lineage (3.2) | murder of innocent, of senators, of best men (3.9); sexually depraved (3.10); dressed himself as a god; had himself addressed as *Dominus* (3.13); wore crown, military fiasco (3.11); caused grain shortage at Rome (4.3). |
| Claudius | good counsellors, good laws, army properly supervised (4.2); extended empire, solved grain shortage (4.3); celebrated Rome's 800th anniversary in wonderful manner (4.14). | foolish (3.7; 4.1); slave to his stomach (4.1); absent-minded, fearful, indolent, controlled by others, in power of Messalina and his freedmen who behaved shamefully (4.5ff.). |

| Emperors | Positive Comments | Negative Comments |
|---|---|---|
| Nero | First five years good, extended empire, adorned Rome (5.2) | played lyre in public, sexually depraved (5.5); incestuous, matricide (5.12); set fire to Rome, loosed wild beasts on populace, sought new capital (5.14). |
| Galba | noble lineage (6.1). | extravagant, cruel, greedy (6.1-2). |
| Otho | | friend of Nero (7.1). |
| Vitellius | | arsonist, mercenary (8.5). |
| Vespasian | of new family, energetic, distinguished in war and peace (8.4); ennobled because of achievements; eloquent, generally upright (9.1); merciful (9.2); enacted good laws; set good example by his own life (9.5); not greedy, as often believed (9.6); restored cities and roads (9.8); renovated senate (9.9); militarily successful (9.10). | |
| Titus | better than father, esp. in clemency, letters and duties (10.1). | |
| Domitian | at first mild and active (11.2); defeated Daci and Chatti; completed building projects at Rome (11.4). | committed robbery, slaughter, vengeance (11.1); arrogant to senate; addressed as Lord and God (11.1-2); megalomaniac, cruel, debauched, indolent (11.4-5); pandered to army at the expense of the senate (11.9). |
| Nerva | wise, moderate, abdicated in favour of better man, not carried away by ambition (12.1-3). | addicted to wine (13.10). |
| Trajan | good provincial lineage (13.1); extended empire (13.3); built roads, bridged Danube (13.4); adorned and cared for Rome (13.5); improved *cursus publicus*, fair, merciful, patient, loyal to friends (13.8); returned to Italy at request of senate (13.11). | addicted to wine (13.10) [but he controlled it by forbidding orders issued after feasts to be carried out]. |

| Emperors | Positive Comments | Negative Comments |
|---|---|---|
| Hadrian | eloquent and widely educated; dedicated to religion, ceremonial, law, schools, learned men (14.1-2). | lived self-indulgently in luxurious villa, enjoyed feasts, statues and paintings like the wealthy (14.5-6); possibly homosexual (14.7); ordered execution of many senators (4.11). |
| Antoninus Pius | practically faultless; old family from Italian *municipium*; fair, honest (15.2-3); energetic [except in war]; celebrated 900th anniversary of Rome magnificently (15.4-5). | not energetic in war [excused: he did not seek glory; foreign nations feared him] (15.5). |
| Marcus Aurelius | of noble lineage from Italian *municipium*; outstanding in philosophy and eloquence (16.1); inspired in both military and civil activities (16.2); defeated Persians [Parthians] (16.4); wise, gentle, inoffensive, literate (16.9); supreme philosopher (16.9); fostered the arts, revamped legal system (16.11); founded, settled, restored, embellished many cities (16.12); defeated Marcomarus (16.13). | failed to restrain his wife's wantonness (16.2). |
| Commodus | energetic in war (17.2) | cruel (17.1); pitiless, savage, cowardly, bloodthirsty, distrusted by all, even by his followers (17.4-7). |
| Pertinax | old-fashioned morality and learning (18.1). | excessively frugal (18.1). |
| Didius Julianus | noble family, learned in the law, responsible for *edictum perpetuum* (19.2). | hypocrite (19.4). |
| Septimius Severus | none more outstanding in state (20.6); frugal (20.10); crushed conspiracies so as to be able to behave more mildly afterwards (20.13); fortunate and prudent esp. in war; militarily successful (20.14ff.); implacable in punishing crimes, rewarding hard work (20.20); scrutinized conduct | at first excessively clement in correcting morals (20.7); cruel, harsh (20.10) [explained away]; wife's adultery let him down; she plotted against him (20.23). |

| Emperors | Positive Comments | Negative Comments |
|---|---|---|
| Septimius Severus (cont.) | of associates (20.21); dedicated to philosophy, oratory, liberal arts, wrote elegantly and truthfully, established good laws (20.22-23). | |
| Caracalla | patient, affable, even-tempered (21.2); enlarged and adorned Rome (21.4). | killed brother (20.32) [his murder of Papinian denied by Victor (20.34); his incest with his mother blamed on her (21.3)]. |
| Macrinus | | cruel and crude (22.3). |
| Heliogabalus | | sexually depraved (23.2). |
| Alexander Severus | very intelligent, defeated Persians, firm handling of army; excellent building at Rome (24.2-5); respected nobility; dedicated to justice; left state strong in all respects (24.6-7); prevented Rome's decline (24.9). | excessively dutiful to mother (24.5). |
| Maximinus | defeated Germans (26.1). | practically illiterate, seized power through legions (25.1). |
| Gordian I | suppressed mutiny in Africa (26.2). | excessively versed in divination (26.4). |
| Gordian II | fought in distinguished manner against Persians (27.8). | |
| Philip | settled affairs in East; founded Philippopolis, constructed reservoir across Tiber, celebrated Rome's 1,000th anniversary in style (28.1); tried to abolish male prostitution (28.6). | |
| Decius | died bravely (29.5). | conspired to seize throne while of military rank (29.1). |
| Gallus and Volusianus | sollicitously and carefully arranged funerals of poorest citizens (30.2). | lacking in restraint in their luxury and wantonness (31.1). |
| Aemilianus | three months of moderate rule (31.3). | seized power by corrupting soldiers (31.1). |
| Valerian and | of distinguished family (32.2). | Tiber overflowed at Gallienus' accession, a bad omen |

| Emperors | Positive Comments | Negative Comments |
|---|---|---|
| Gallienus | defeated pretenders Ingebus and Regalienus (33.2). | which came true (32.3); allowed Goths to occupy Thrace, Macedon, Achaea, parts of Asia, Parthians to seize Mesopotamia, East to be ruled by brigands and a woman, Alamanni to penetrate Italy, Franks to plunder Gaul, occupy Spain, ravage Tarracona, reach Africa; lost Dacia (33.3ff.); plague blamed on him (33.5); frequented taverns and cook shops, enjoyed company of pimps and drunkards, indulged himself with his wife and with German princess, responsible for civil wars (33. 6-8); deceived people that all was well (33.15); indolent and cowardly (33.17); lustful (33. 17); forbade senators to pursue military career (33.34; 37.6). |
| Claudius | able to endure hard work, just, dedicated to the state (34.1); gave life for the state (34.5). | |
| Aurelian | defeated Persians (35.1); drove Germans from Gaul (35.3); defeated Tetricus, showed him mercy (35.5); crushed rebelling mint workers, adorned and fortified Rome, supplied pork to plebs at Rome, eliminated fiscal charges and informers, burned records and documents of those transactions, decreed amnesty, prosecuted greed and embezzlement and extortion against provincials (35.6-7); severe, incorruptible; these qualities caused army to refer choice of emperor to senate (35.12). | |
| Tacitus | gentle, consular (36.1). | |

| Emperors | Positive Comments | Negative Comments |
|---|---|---|
| Florianus | | seized power without consulting senate or army (36.2). |
| Probus | compared with Hannibal as an emperor outstanding in military science and ability to train soldiers (37.2); filled Gaul, Pannonia, Moesia with vineyards, defeated barbarians, put down pretenders, recovered and pacified lost territories, is said to have stated that soldiers would soon be unnecessary (37.3); undertook drainage scheme at Sirmium (37.4). | |
| Carus | defeated Persians (38.3). | excessively eager for glory, disregarded oracles (38.3-4). |
| Carinus | | lustful, adulterous, indolent (39.11-12). |
| Numerian | good and eloquent (39.13). | |
| Diocletian | intelligent, a great man (39.1); acted as father to state, sensible (39.8); merciful (39.14); deprived no one of property, reputation, rank (39.15); experienced in military hardships, best ruler for state, good and sensible, worked harmoniously with colleagues, good character and military experience (39.26-28); looked up to as father (39.29); self-controlled (39.32); bureaucracy restrained, *frumentarii* abolished, Rome's grain supply and the safety of taxpayers preserved, promoted honest, punished wicked, attended to ancient forms of religion, adorned Rome and provincial cities (39.44-45); excellence of character caused him to spurn ambition and abdicate (39.48). | haughty, vain, extravagant (39.3) [downplayed by Victor]; first since Caligula and Domitian to be addressed and treated as a god (39.4); uncultured (39.26); insufficiently honest and trustful of friends (39.46). |
| Maximian | loyal friend, good soldier, good character (39.17); | semi-rustic (39.17); somewhat uncultured (39.26); |

| Emperors | Positive Comments | Negative Comments |
|---|---|---|
| Maximian (cont.) | experienced in military hardships, best ruler for state, good and sensible, worked harmoniously with colleagues, good character and military experience (39. 26-28). | excessively wilful (39,46); gave up power reluctantly (39.48); lacked restraint (40. 21); treacherous to Constantine (40.22). |
| Constantius I | outstanding natural qualities (40.12). | somewhat uncultured (39.26); lacked refinement, not learned (40.12). |
| Galerius | cut down forests and drained Lake Pelso (40.9); outstanding natural qualities (40.12). | somewhat uncultured (39.26); lacked refinement, not learned (40.12). |
| Constantine | great and powerful spirit (40. 2); of many virtues (40.14); embellished Rome and provincial cities (40.26ff.); treated enemies well, merciful (41.4); abolished certain tortures, founded a city, reorganized religion and army (41.12); renewed Rome by his military ability, laws and clement rule (41.17); stopped burdensome requisitions on Tripolis and Nicaea (41.19); fiscal oppression minimized (41.20). | very ambitious (40.2); excessively ambitious and munificent (40.15); allowed unworthy men into public office (41.20). |
| Maxentius | | tyrant, devastated Carthage and loveliest parts of Africa; cruel, inhuman, lascivious, cowardly, unwarlike, indolent, unconcerned about father's death (40.18-20); cruel, tyrant, ordered praetorians to massacre people, imposed tax on senators and farmers for him to waste (40.23-24). |
| Licinius | frugal (41.3) [denigrated as rustic]. | tortured innocent philosophers and nobility (41.5). |
| Constans | | hasty, quick-tempered, avaricious, lustful, homosexual, depraved ministers (41.23-24). |

| | | |
|---|---|---|
| Magnentius | | cruel and savage barbarian (41.25). |
| Vetranio | | illiterate, dull, stupid, of squalid birth (41.26). |
| Nepotianus | | dull, murderous (42.7). |
| Constantius II | eloquent, merciful, self-restrained, honest (42.1-4); crushed Magnentius and Jewish revolt (42.10-11); put down rebellions, crushed Persians, appointed king for Sarmatians, calm, merciful, careful literary style approaching elegance, pleasant and affable speaker, endured work readily, wonderful bowman, in control of his appetites for food and all else, reasonably devout regarding his father, realized the peace of the state depended on the way of life of good rulers; no more outstanding emperor (42.23-25). | excessively concerned about own reputation, poor judge of those appointed as governors and generals, his ministers generally worthless, good men neglected, nothing worse than his subordinates (42. 23-25). |

## APPENDIX III

### VICTOR, EUTROPIUS AND THE EPITOMATOR: SOME COMPARATIVE TERMS DENOTING POWER

Victor uses the generally pejorative terms *dominatio* (9), *dominatus* (4), *dominans* (3) and *dominari* (1) seventeen times to indicate supreme power: *De Caesaribus* 3.17.6; 11.7.4; 17.1.1; 17.7.3; 20.9.3; 29.2.6; 37.1.1; 39.23.2; 41.26.4 (*dominatio*); 5.2.2; 19.1.3; 37.3.8; 40.17.2 (*dominatus*); 5.8.3; 24.9.2; 37.7.4 (*dominans*); 33.3.7 (*dominari*). In all occurrences the terms are set in explicitly or implicitly negative contexts. They usually refer to usurpers such as Lucius Priscus, Pescennius Niger, Achilles, Vetranio, Florianus, Alexander, Saturninus and Bonosus, or to unpopular emperors like Nero (and his mother), Domitian, Commodus, Didius Julianus and Gallienus, but twice they appear in pessimistic generalized statements. Eutropius eschews the terms entirely. The Epitomator, however, who produces the terms nine times (*Epit.* 1.21.3; 2.3.3; 6.3.2; 20.7.1; 31.2.2; 32.4.3; 41.8.1; 41.19.1; 41.23.5), mostly uses them in a neutral sense although on three occasions the context is negative (1.21.3; 32.4.3; 41.8.1).

In addition, the disparaging terms *tyrannis* (6) and *tyrannus* (4) appear in the *De Caesaribus* ten times (8.6.6; 9.2.1; 12.2.2; 33.24.3; 40.23.6; 42.21.2 (*tyrannis*); 4.5.3; 9.9.6; 40.18.2; 40.29.1 (*tyrannus*)), on all occasions but one with pejorative moral content. Only in 42.21.2 is *tyrannis* used in a quasi-technical sense to denote usurpation (for the use of *tyrannus* as usurper see *H.A. Tyr. Trig.* 1.1; *Prob.* 24.8; *Quad. tyr.* 1.1). Eutropius employs *tyrannus* (8.1) and *tyrannis* (10.13) only once each, on both occasions in a non-technical sense. The Epitomator's usage is more intriguing. He also employs *tyrannis* (4), *tyrannus* (6) ten times (*Epit.* 9.5.2; 16.11.2; 46.4.2; 47.7.2; (*tyrannis*); 9.11.2; 9.16.3; 13.10.3; 48.6.1; 48.7.1; 48.17.3 (*tyrannus*)). On the first four occasions, two if not three copied from Victor, the

terms are used non-technically, but from 16.11.2 onwards they take on the quasi-technical sense of usurper/usurpation. The Epitomator is no longer dependent on Victor from chapter 12 onwards, apart from 41.2.3, and seemingly reverts to his own frame of reference in which he equates these terms with usurpation, as does the author of the *H.A.*

Victor also employs the term *regnum* fifteen times to denote supreme power: 3.13.1; 5.14.3; 13.13.3; 15.3.3; 17.7.8; 20.27.3; 23.3.4; 27.6.3; 29.4.2; 33.9.2; 36.2.3; 39.48.4; 41.11.4; 41.16.5; 42.11.2. This word frequently appears in a neutral sense but when applied to Caligula (3.13.1), Nero (5.14.3), Plotina (13.13.3), Commodus (17.7.8) and the pretenders Marius (33.9.2), Calocerus (41.11.4) and Patricius (42.11.2) it is clearly used in a negative context. Eutropius has the term only twice (7.10; 7.11), on both occasions in reference to foreign kingdoms. The Epitomator makes use of *regnum* as supreme power six times (*Epit.* 19.1.3; 24.4.1; 26.2.1; 34.3.2; 45.7.1; 48.7.5), always in a negative context and mostly applied to pretenders.

Finally, Eutropius (7.8; 10.1; 10.5) and the Epitomator (*Epit.* 8.3.2; 15.2.2; 26.1.2) avail themselves of the neutral term *principatus* to denote supreme power. It is not found in Victor's work.

One possible inference to be drawn from the above data is that Victor was, indeed, more negative and despondent than his fellow abbreviators. His repeated usage of such emotionally-laden, depreciatory expressions of power as *dominatio*, *tyrannis* and *regnum*, when compared with their sparing and often different employment by Eutropius and the Epitomator, apparently denotes a personal pessimism not demonstrated by the other two writers.

## APPENDIX IV

### LIST OF PROVINCES / PROVINCIALS CITED BY VICTOR

| | |
|---|---|
| Aegyptus / Aegypti | 4.14; 20.9; 21.4; 39.23; 39.38 |
| Achaei | 33.3 |
| Africa | 26.1; 27.1; 33.3; 37.3; 39.22; 39.30; 39.39; 40.19; 40.28 |
| Alpes Cottiae | 5.2 |
| Aquitani | 33.14 |
| Arabia / Arabs | 4.14; 20.15; 28.1 |
| Armenia | 39.34 |
| Asia | 16.12; 33.3 |
| Bithynia | 16.12 |
| Britannia / Britanni | 4.2; 20.9; 20.18; 20.27; 24.4; 39.21; 40.2 |
| Cappadocia | 2.3 |
| Cretensis | 12.1 |
| Cyprus | 41.11 |
| Daci | 11.4; 13.3 |
| Dardanius | 13.3 |
| Epirus | 3.16 |
| Gallia / Galli | 4.2; 7.2; 13.3; 16.13; 20.9; 24.2; 33.1; 33.3; 33.8; 35.3; 37.3; 38.2; 39.17; 39.19; 39.30; 40.16; 42.9; 42.10; 42.15; 42.17 |
| Graecia / Graeci | 3.12; 5.5; 11.5; 14.2; 35.7 |
| Hispania | 5.15; 13.1; 33.3 |
| Illyricum / Illyrici | 1.2; 13.6; 29.1; 33.1; 37.2; 39.9; 39.26; 39.30; 40.1; 40.8; 41.26 |
| Iudaei | 8.1; 9.10; 42.11 |
| Macedones | 29.2; 33.3 |
| Mauri | 4.2 |
| Mesopotamia | 4.2; 32.5; 33.3; 38.2; 39.33 |

| | |
|---|---|
| Moesia | 8.2; 37.3; 39.11; 41.26 |
| Palaestina | 9.10 |
| Pannonia / Pannonicus | 8.2; 16.13; 33.2; 37.3; 40.7; 40.9 |
| Pontus | 5.2; 39.30 |
| Rhaetia | 1.2; 32.1; 33.17 |
| Syria / Syri / Syriacus | 8.3; 9.10; 13.11; 19.4; 21.5; 23.1; 24.1; 29.2 |
| Thracia | 27.3; 29.2; 33.3; 40.8; 41.8 |
| Valeria | 40.10 |
| Venetia / Veneti | 16.9; 39.10 |

## APPENDIX V

### WOMEN, EUNUCHS AND SEXUAL MORALITY

The author's attitude towards women is interesting. He never singles out a woman for praise but on numerous occasions he feels impelled to level various charges against them. Accordingly, in his first section dealing with Augustus he remarks that the emperor was very fortunate except for his children and his wife.[1] The *Augusta*, Livia, *gravis in rem publicam mater, gravis domui Caesarum noverca*,[2] does not deserve to be mentioned by name but Victor finds he cannot wholly ignore her baleful influence. With respect to sexual morality Victor also appears to hold extremely strong views. Tiberius' reprehensible sexual conduct is briefly noted,[3] as is the incest and adultery of Caligula.[4] In Claudius' reign the notorious Messalina is accorded ample space. She committed widespread adultery and, even worse, she encompassed the deaths of those who denied her improper advances by *using the well-known arts of women*, compelled men and women of noble birth to prostitute themselves and finally went so far as to celebrate marriage with C. Silius while her husband Claudius was at Ostia enjoying the pleasure of his mistresses. Victor was thoroughly shocked by such behaviour, but after the execution of Messalina Claudius seemingly showed even greater folly in marrying his niece, Agrippina. She poisoned her husband and subsequently *used her womanly wiles* to corrupt the guard in order to fake a natural death and ensure that her son Nero succeeded.[5] Her disgraceful behaviour, however, did not end there: her eagerness for power was such that (according to many) she even committed incest with Nero to ensure his subjection to her. Victor adds:

> "Although different writers give divergent reports, I believe this was true. Habituation to vice leads to novel and consequently more desirable perversions, and finally drives one to commit crimes against one's own family."[6]

Subsequently Victor goes on to discuss the well-known sexual depravity of Nero who spared neither his own nor anyone else's sense of shame. He celebrated a homosexual marriage in the presence of the senate, debauched a Vestal Virgin, committed acts of unspeakable bestiality including castration which the author considered a particularly heinous crime.[7] In keeping with his theme Victor ends his account of Nero with the statement that he was deserted in his final moments by all except for a eunuch whom he had tried to make into a woman.[8]

Domitian is also briefly criticized for his debauchery, as is his wife (not named) Domitilla, who preferred her actor lover to her husband.[9] Trajan's wife, Plotina, is cited by name when Victor retails the story that she forged her husband's will to place Hadrian on the throne.[10] Worse still, however, was the wife of M. Aurelius who sullied her husband's glorious reign by her lascivious conduct.[11] According to Victor, Septimius Severus suffered similarly because of his wife's improprieties.[12] She actually seduced her stepson, according to Victor, who plainly did not know she was Caracalla's mother and the whole story a piece of salacious gossip.[13]

Perhaps Victor's most telling statement regarding women appears when he describes Elagabalus: "Not even shameless and lewd women were more depraved than Heliogabalus."[14] Three other examples of Victor's misogyny occur. Zenobia, Queen of Palmyra, is not cited by name, but the author does state: "Bandits, or rather a woman controlled the East."[15] Gallienus either spent his time in cookshops or taverns with pimps and drunkards or gave himself up to his wife, Salonina, and indulged in an illicit affair with Pipa, daughter of the German king Attalus.[16] Finally, Victoria, mother of Victorinus the Gallic usurper, bribed the Gallic army with a large sum of money to make Tetricus emperor of Gaul in her dead son's place.[17]

Victor has nothing positive to say about women. He simply lists most of the *femmes fatales* of imperial history and recounts, in obvious horror, their various crimes, real or rumoured, choosing well-known topoi originally deriving from Suetonius' *Lives* or from lost *chroniques scandaleuses* which presumably abounded in imperial times. With the self-righteous fervour of a nineteenth-century moralist he chastised even heterosexual love if it was, in his estimation, illicit or excessive. Only one thing was worse, sexual deviation, one aspect of which involved castration. To emphasize the point Victor is full of praise for Philip the Arab who attempted to ban

male prostitution *honestissime*:

> "Nevertheless it remains: indeed merely change the circumstances and it is driven on by even worse crimes as long as human beings are more eager to search for dangerous and forbidden occupations."[18]

It may be opportune here to examine Eutropius' views on women:

> "In this summary of Roman history women are virtually ignored. Of course, the Sabine virgins, Lucretia and Virginia, are part of the stock repertoire, even for those who do no more than memorize the earliest history of Rome (1.7, 8-10, 8); no historians writing about Hadrian's accession could ignore Plotina's influence (VIII 6); no more could Cleopatra (VI 22, VII 6, 7) or Zenobia (IX 13) be disregarded. But this is the sum of the abbreviator's interest in the subject. Those who stress Suetonius' influence on Eutropius will not find a trace of it here, at any rate. No Livia, no Agrippinas, no Julias. The *magister memoriae* had no time for frivolous matters."[22]

None the less he did feel it necessary to mention (albeit briefly) Caligula's incest, lust and cruelty,[23] the depravity of Commodus[24] and the unfounded story of Caracalla's affair with his 'stepmother' Julia.[25] Nor was he able to ignore the notorious depravity of Elagabalus[26] and the supposed dissoluteness of Gallienus.[27] Such stories were too firmly rooted in the historical tradition to allow even the serious-minded Eutropius to disregard them entirely despite the severely circumscribed nature of his *breviarium*.

Even if most of Victor's anecdotes noted above probably appeared in the K.G., some may have been recalled from his earlier reading of Suetonius, Tacitus[28] and other writers. The point to note, however, is that Victor deliberately chose to retell these stories and occasionally added a personal commentary on them. In part, therefore, they must reflect the author's frame of mind. Like Ammianus,[29] Eutropius and Mamertinus,[30] Victor may have felt that Constantius' wives, Eusebia and Faustina, had wielded too much influence, hence the apparent emphasis on the pernicious power of women. Thus when he writes that Claudius was led into wicked ways by his wife Messalina and by his freedmen upon whom he was dependent, and that tyranny results whenever women and slaves control their weak-minded husbands and masters,[31] in all likelihood he was giving a broad hint to Constantius.[32]

Ammianus could be less ambiguous regarding Constantius. He lumps wives and eunuchs together in his complaint that the emperor was too much under their influence.[33] He is also scathing in his

condemnation of Eusebius, Constantius' head chamberlain, and full of praise for Domitian's popular law forbidding castration.[34] The Epitomator appears to echo these sentiments: he describes Constantius as *spadonum aulicorumque amori deditus et uxorum*.[35] The *H.A.*, too, includes a number of occasionally extensive and extremely negative remarks about eunuchs in the administration and commends Alexander Severus for his supposed limitation of their numbers and powers.[36] Finally, some years later, the poet Claudian is even more vitriolic regarding Arcadius' minister, Eutropius, against whom the main charge seems to have been that he was a eunuch.[37]

It appears from Victor's use of such stereotyped expressions as *pervagatis mulierum artibus* and *arte mulieris*[38] and the attention paid to several of the notorious women in Rome's imperial past like Messalina and Agrippina that the author disliked women in general and particularly resented empresses meddling in politics. It would of course have been unwise for him to be as explicit about Constantius' reign as later writers, notably Eutropius, Ammianus and the Epitomator, so he contented himself with exposing the damage done to previous emperors' reputations by their errant wives, hoping presumably that the emperor would understand the implications. The emperor was, as Victor frankly remarks, overly sensitive about his own reputation[39] and it is conceivable that Victor was shrewdly making use of Constantius' foible. Nevertheless, in order to insure himself against possible repercussions Victor adds that the emperor was aware *vita bonorum principum reipublicae quietem regi*.

Furthermore Victor seems to have found all forms of sexual perversion morally objectionable. He makes it abundantly clear that he felt repelled by the conduct of Caligula, Nero and Elagabalus and, in contrast, admired the attempt of Philip to abolish male prostitution. In his concluding remarks, surely appended after Julian had succeeded to the throne, he dwells upon the worthless character of the majority of Constantius' ministers. Presumably he was alluding here to Eusebius and the *spadones aulicique* expressly mentioned by Ammianus and the Epitomator, a motley band of atrocious *apparitores* whose shameful characters could ruin the state.[40]

Victor possessed a clearly-defined sense of decency and especially of proper conduct for emperors, officials and women. People in high positions had a duty to set good examples, hence the *exempla* scattered throughout the *De Caesaribus*. In part these were intended to display his historical knowledge but in addition they

were designed to encourage the powerful to behave with modesty and good judgement. His code was understandably conservative but essentially reasonable as befitted a *virum sobrietatis gratia aemulandum*.[41] He manifestly appreciated how much Rome had suffered through the excesses of imperial reprobates or the malign influence of dissolute consorts and counsellors. It is hardly surprising, then, that he concluded that such people should have no place in the affairs of state.

These explicitly stated opinions of Victor were personal and not intended for selfish political gains, but purely by chance they came to the attention of Julian when he found himself in need of loyal administrators. There can be little doubt that they enhanced the writer's standing with Julian when the latter interviewed him at Sirmium and read his *De Caesaribus*. Julian was an acknowledged ascetic and Libanius noted the emperor's complete lack of interest in sex. When Julian was appointed Caesar by Constantius in 355 he was immediately married to Constantius' sister, Helena, in what was clearly a political union. Libanius informs us that but for this single encounter Julian "would have ended his days knowing nothing of human sexual intercourse save by report".[42] It appears that the young emperor merely did his duty dynastically and felt no deep affection for his wife for he declared openly that he had never written her a letter which he would not have allowed to be read by the whole world.[43] Indeed, in all of his writings Helena is mentioned only three times. After her death at Vienne in Gaul in 360 Julian vowed to live in absolute chastity, a vow he kept. Ammianus also notes that Julian's enemies were quite incapable of discovering any charges of sexual liaisons against him or they would certainly have published them.[44] Later in his reign Julian was pestered by his entourage to remarry in order to produce a son to carry on the line. He allegedly replied that this actually deterred him because he might produce degenerate children with legal title to the throne who would bring ruin on themselves.[45] The example of Marcus Aurelius was firmly fixed in his mind.[46] In his *Caesares* Julian observes not only that Marcus Aurelius' wife was by no means virtuous but also that his son ruined the empire and himself.[47] Further criticism of that emperor follows for his attitude to his wife and son, but Julian partially exonerates him with parallels from Homer. According to Julian the emperor had behaved quite according to custom in honouring them both and handing down the succession to his son.[48] Clearly Julian was continually worried by the possibility that he might find himself in

the position of his favourite emperor and might make the same choice.

Victor was similarly worried by this possibility. He observes that there appears to be some kind of natural law which repeatedly, as if by design, produces bad men from good, uncultivated men from learned ones and so on, and precisely from the example of Caligula most wise men have decided that it is preferable to remain childless.[49] Furthermore, he adds that Commodus, Marcus Aurelius' son, was considered all the more detestable because people remembered the totally contrasting character of his ancestors and judged him and others like him as *corruptores generis*.[50]

These unambiguous expressions of views entirely in accord with the thinking of Julian, along with Victor's manifest *sobrietas*, experience in the bureaucracy of Pannonia, apparent paganism, esteem for efficient administration, and literary tendencies,[51] would have appealed strongly to the young emperor.[52]

## APPENDIX VI

### THE *DE CAESARIBUS* AND THE *HISTORIA AUGUSTA*

Quite apart from his modest importance as a historical source[1] and the information we derive from the *De Caesaribus* which helps us to understand the social framework of his era, Victor is of profound significance historiographically in the controversy surrounding the *Historia Augusta*. This was first noticed by Dessau in 1889. He argued that the close relationship between *De Caesaribus* 20.1 and 20.10-30 and *H.A. Sev.* 17.5 - 19.4, and between Eutropius *Breviarium* 8.11-14 and *H.A. Marc. Aur.* 15.3 - 19.12 could only be explained by the hypothesis that the *H.A.* derived this material from Victor and Eutropius. Since these authors composed their works in 359/360 and 369/370 the *H.A.* must have been written after 370. Yet there were six authors of the *H.A.*, according to manuscript tradition, Aelius Spartianus, Julius Capitolinus, Vulcacius Gallicanus, Aelius Lampridius, Trebellius Pollio and Flavius Vopiscus. Furthermore, some of the biographies were dedicated to Diocletian (284-305), others to Constantine (306-337). In view of the similarities of style and convention between the six and the numerous anachronisms in the *H.A.* Dessau concluded that the work was an imposture written by a single author at the end of the fourth century.[2] The appearance of Dessau's article initiated a lengthy and occasionally bitter controversy between conservative scholars who would preserve the traditional date and authorship of the *H.A.*, moderate conservatives who argued for a late fourth-century recension to account for the obvious anomalies in the *H.A.*, and so-called radical scholars who considered the *H.A.* to be a forgery.[3] The present survey limits itself to the relationship between the *De Caesaribus* and the *H.A.*, a relationship which Momigliano considered to be "the strongest single argument for a post-Constantinian date and, by implication, for a forgery".[4]

First, the similarity between *De Caes.* 20.1; 20.10-30 and *Sev.* 17.5 - 19.4. Evidently either the *H.A.* copied Victor, or Victor copied the *H.A.*, or both followed a common source. The second hypothesis is precluded by Victor's method of composition: he neither needed nor desired such an extensive source as the *H.A.* Hohl argued forcefully and persuasively for the first hypothesis and maintained that Victor was responsible for confusing Didius Julianus with Salvius Julianus.[5] In all probability Victor was also responsible for making Abgarus King of the Persians. Both of these errors are also in the *H.A.* but in no other source. Chastagnol comments that to invoke a common source for the two passages is a hypothesis which is based upon no solid argument and contradicts the indications furnished by a literal analysis of the two texts which are parallel in the succession of phrases, facts and ideas.[6]

Second, in the *life* of Alexander Severus the *H.A.* provides several indications of direct use of the *De Caesaribus*. Victor (24.6) erroneously states that Ulpian was made praetorian prefect by Elagabalus.[7] The *H.A.* has two versions (*Alex.* 26.5-6), the correct one, presumably from the common source, the 'Kaisergeschichte', and the incorrect one, probably from Victor. In addition, the alleged prefecture of Paul in the *H.A.* surely derives from a misreading of Victor. Eutropius, the Epitomator and Festus mention neither Ulpian's prefecture nor Paul.[8] Furthermore, in discussing the place where Alexander was murdered, Victor (24.4) writes: *nam cum tantae severitatis vim milites inhorrescunt ... agentem casu cum paucis vico Britanniae, cui vocabulum Sicilia, trucidavere*; *H.A. Alex.* 59.6 has: *denique agentem eum cum paucis in Britannia, ut alii volunt in Gallia, in vico cui Sicilia nomen est ... quidam milites ..., cum severum principem pati non possent, occiderunt.* Eutropius informs us (8.23) that Alexander *periit in Gallia militari tumultu.* The *H.A.* thus again betrays knowledge of Victor.[9] Finally, *Alex.* 24.4, *habuit in animo ut exsoletos vetaret, quod postea Philippus fecit, sed veritus est, ne prohibens publicum dedecus in privatas cupiditates converteret, cum homines inlicita magis prohibita poscant furore iactati*, is clearly a relocation of Victor's note and personal comments in *De Caes.* 28.6-7: *imperator Philippus ... usum virilis scorti removendum honestissime consultavit. verumtamen manet: quippe condicione loci mutata peioribus flagitiis agitatur, dum avidius periculosa quibusque prohibentur mortales petunt.*[10]

Third, in its account of the Gordians, Pupienus and Balbinus the *H.A.* states:

"Gordiani non, ut quidam imperiti scriptores loquuntur, duo sed tres fuerunt, idque docente Arriano, scriptore Graecae historiae, docente item Dexippo ...." (*Gord.* 2.1)

"sed multi non a Maximo, verum a Pupieno imperatore victum apud Aquileiam Maximinum esse dixerunt et ipsum cum Balbino esse occisum, ita ut Maximini nomen praetereant. tanta est autem historicorum inter se certantium imperitia vel usurpatio, ut multi eundem Maximum quem Pupienum velint dici, cum Herodianus vitae suae temporum scriptor, Maximum dicat, non Pupienum, cum et Dexippus, Graecorum scriptor, Maximum et Balbinum imperatores dicat factos contra Maximinum post Gordianos duos et a Maximo victum Maximinum, non a Pupieno. his accedit scriptorum imperitia, qua praefectum praetorii fuisse Gordianum parvulum dicunt, ignorantibus multis collo saepe vectum, ut militibus ostenderetur." (*Max.-Balb.* 15)

"sed apud Latinos scriptores plerosque Maximi nomen non invenio et cum Balbino Pupienum imperatorem reperio, usque adeo ut idem Pupienus cum Maximino apud Aquileiam pugnasse dicatur, cum memoratis historicis adserentibus ne Maximus quidem contra Maximinum pugnasse doceatur, sed resedisse apud Ravennam atque illic patratam audisse victoriam." (*Max.-Balb.* 16.7)

A similar pronouncement is made in *Max.-Duo* 33.2.

The *H.A.* must have known a Latin writer or writers (1) who knew of only two Gordians, (2) who identified Gordians II and III, and considered this person the praetorian prefect of Gordian I, (3) who did not know the *gentilicium* of M. Cl. Pupienus Maximus, and (4) who considered that Pupienus besieged and defeated Maximinus at Aquileia. Victor (*De Caes.* 26.7; 27.1-4) is the only extant writer guilty of all four errors. Indeed, Enmann was moved to write that "the similarity is so striking that one would have to accept that Capitolinus had Aurelius Victor before his eyes if one did not know that the former wrote under Constantine, the latter under Constantius II".[11] He therefore postulated that the K.G. was the source criticized by the *H.A.* and that it must have been written before the *H.A.* It has already been demonstrated, however, that the K.G. was written after Constantine's death;[12] consequently there is no longer any valid reason for not accepting that the *H.A.* was criticizing Victor at this juncture.

A number of other passages in the *H.A.* bear striking resemblance to passages in the *De Caesaribus*, e.g. *Carac.* 9.10; 10.1-2 = *De Caes.* 21.3-4; *Tyr. trig.* 11.4 = *De Caes.* 33.18; 33.20; *Aur.* 38.2 = *De Caes.* 35.6; *Aur.* 39.1 = *De Caes.* 35.5; *Aur.* 39.2-5 = *De Caes.* 35.7;

*Tac.* 13.6; 14.1 = *De Caes.* 36.2; *Tac.* 14.2 = *De Caes.* 37.1-2; *Prob.* 21.2 = *De Caes.* 37.4; *Car.* 7.1 = *De Caes.* 38.1-2. Perhaps the most significant of these are the passages dealing with Florianus. Victor writes (*De Caes.* 36.2): *Florianus, eiusdem frater, nullo senatus seu militum consulto imperium invaserat. qui uno mense aut altero vix retentata dominatione apud Tarsum ab suis interficitur.* The *H.A.*'s account (*Tac.* 14.1) is as follows: *hic frater Taciti germanus fuit, qui post fratrem arripuit imperium, non senatus auctoritate sed suo motu, quasi hereditarium esset imperium .... denique vix duobus mensibus imperium tenuit et occisus est Tarsi a militibus ....* Only Victor and the *H.A.* mistakenly observe that Florianus was Tacitus' brother and seized power without senatorial backing. The error and the theme of a short-lived senatorial resuscitation foundering because of the indolence of the senators themselves are Victor's.[13] The *H.A.*, therefore, must have taken this information from the *De Caesaribus.*

Finally, two engaging themes appear in the *De Caesaribus* which seemingly appealed to the author of the *H.A.* First, when Carus had defeated the Persians and passed beyond Ctesiphon he was supposedly killed by a thunderbolt.[14] Victor adds:

> "Id quidam iure ei accidisse referunt; nam cum oracula docuissent adusque oppidum memoratum perveniri victoria licere, longius delatus poenas luit. proinde arduum fatalia devertere, eoque futuri notio superflua." (*De Caes.* 38.4-5)

The *H.A.* retails the story, and completes it with a striking attack on the *timiditas* of such fatalists:

> "Plerique dicunt vim fati quandam esse, ut Romanus princeps Ctesiphontem transire non possit, ideoque Carum fulmine absumptum quod eos fines transgredi cuperet qui fataliter constituti sunt. sed sibi habet artes suas timiditas, calcanda virtutibus. licet plane ac licebit, ut per sacratissimum Caesarem Maximianum constitit, Persas vincere atque ultra eos progredi et futurum reor, si a nostris non deseratur promissus numinum favor." (*Car.* 9.1-3)

The second theme concerns childlessness. Victor informs us that Caligula turned out to be utterly unlike his ancestors, as if there were some natural law which appeared, as it were on purpose, to produce *malos e bonis, agrestes ex doctioribus* and so on. *Quo demum exemplo sapientium plures caruisse liberis utilius duxere* (*De Caes.* 3.5-6). Subsequently he labels Commodus and others like him as all the more detestable because they were *quasi corruptores generis* (*De Caes.* 17.1). In a lengthy disquisition, which closely follows the extended passage borrowed from Victor, the *H.A.* repeats and

expands upon the theme (*Sev.* 20.1 - 21.11). Perhaps his most telling comment is the following:

> "Et reputanti mihi, Diocletiane Auguste, neminem prope magnorum virorum optimum et utilem filium reliquisse satis claret. denique aut sine liberis veris interierunt aut tales habuerunt plerique, ut melius fuerit de rebus humanis sine posteritate discedere." (*Sev.* 20.4-5)

From the numerous and diverse indications noted above it must be clear that Aurelius Victor's work is cardinal to the dating and unmasking of the *H.A.*[15] The demonstrated use of the *De Caesaribus* by the *H.A.* not only gives a *terminus post quem* for the composition of the latter, it also, by implication, constitutes the most solid proof that the *H.A.* is an imposture.

# NOTES

The following frequently cited works are referred to throughout the Notes by author's name only:

A. Alföldi, *A Conflict of Ideas in the Late Roman Empire* (trans. Oxford, 1952)
W. den Boer, *Some Minor Roman Historians* (Leiden, 1972)
P. Dufraigne, *Aurelius Victor: Livre des Césars* (Paris, 1975)
C.E.V. Nixon, *An Historiographical Study of the Caesares of Sextus Aurelius Victor* (diss. Michigan, 1971)

Works listed in the Select Bibliography (pp.165-70) are not necessarily cited in full in the Notes. Other abbreviations are standard.

## NOTES TO INTRODUCTION

1 As noted by F. Lot, *The End of the Ancient World and the Beginning of the Middle Ages* (New York, 1961), p.171.

2 A. Alföldi, *The Conversion of Constantine and Pagan Rome* (trans. H. Mattingly, Oxford, 1948), pp.4, 69.

3 Den Boer, pp.222-23.

4 *De Caes.* 24.9. Victor followed ancient historical tradition in presenting violent rather than slow change. The so-called Edict of Gallienus may have been invented by Victor as a result of this attitude.

5 *De Caes.* 42.1ff.

6 *De Caes.* 35.14.

7 A. Momigliano, in discussing Ammianus, points out that what defined a man writing in Latin at Rome (in the fourth century), was what he thought about Christianity, the Germans and the role of the Senate (*Essays in Ancient and Modern Historiography* (Oxford, 1977), p.134). It is apparent that Victor would have added to that list. Momigliano proceeds to write that Ammianus did not make an issue of those factors and never treats the behaviour of the emperors towards the Senate as a test of the quality of their government. It will be evident that Victor did.

## NOTES TO CHAPTER 1

1 For dating see A. Momigliano, 'Some observations on the *Origo Gentis Romanae*', *JRS* 48 (1958), pp.56-73; for further observations see P.B. Corbett, 'The *Caesares* attributed to Aurelius Victor. Points arising out of an examination of the MSS, and of the Teubner edition of F. Pichlmayr', *Scriptorium* 3 (1949), pp.254-57; R.J. Tarrant, review of Dufraigne in *Gnomon* 50 (1978), pp.355-62. For the medieval manuscript tradition see S. D'Elia, *Studi sulla tradizione manoscritta di Aurelio Vittore* (Naples, 1969). Victor's *praenomen* appears both in the manuscript title of the *Epitome* and in a dedicatory inscription found in the Forum of Trajan (*CIL* VI 1186 = *ILS* 2945). Two basic works of reference used extensively for this reconstruction are A.H.M. Jones, *The Later Roman Empire* (Oxford, 1964), and A.H.M. Jones, J.R. Martindale and J. Morris, *The Prosopography of the Later Roman Empire* (Cambridge, 1971) (cited as *PLRE*).

2 *De Caes.* 20.5: *quo bonis omnibus ac mihi fidendum magis, qui rure ortus tenui atque indocto patre in haec tempora vitam praestiti studiis tantis honestiorem.* The compiler of the corpus which comprises the *Origo Gentis Romanae*, the *De Viris Illustribus Urbis Romae*, the *De Caesaribus* and the *Epitome de Caesaribus*, describes the author as Af(f)er in his preface. While not in themselves conclusive the frequent mentions of Africa in the *De Caes.* (16.12; 39.65; 40.17) and especially the description of Carthage as *terrarum decus* (40.19) bolster the generally accepted view. Invariably African cities are mentioned first in any list Victor gives (16.12; 39.45; 41.19). Finally the special mention given to Cirta, rebuilt and renamed Constantina by Constantine, in itself a relatively insignificant event to be included in such a brief history, leads me to think that Victor *may* have been born in the vicinity of that city. Constantinople is conspicuously overlooked here by the author and its name is never mentioned.

3 *Tenui* in *De Caes.* 20.5 standing for *humiliori* as Nixon, p.3, states. Cf. *Dig.* 50.4.6 where *tenues* is a term used to describe impoverished decurions. It may, however, have been conventional to exaggerate the modesty of one's means: cf. C.P. Jones, *The Roman World of Dio Chrysostom* (Cambridge, Mass. and London, 1978), p.7.

4 *De Caes.* 40.14; 41.17. Nixon, p.21, places his birthdate *ca* 325 while Dufraigne, p.xiv, opts for *ca* 327.

5 Ammianus 21.10.6; *ILS* 2945, *veterum principum clementiam sanctitudinem munificentiam supergresso d.n. Fl. Theodosio pio victori semper Augusto, Sex. Aur. Victor, v.c. urbi praef., iudex sacrarum cognitionum, d.n.m.q.e.* The only other mentions of Victor are Hieron. *Epist.* 10.3; Joh. Lydus *De Mag.* 3.7; Paul Diac. *Hist. Lang.* 2.18. A. Alföldi, *The Conversion of Constantine and Pagan Rome*, p.121, writes that Victor's statement in 41.17 is just a piece of flattery to please Constantius II. While this may be true of the second half of Victor's reference, the resentment of the Romans at having their city downgraded by Constantine's burial at Constantinople was very real. In mundane terms, they missed the show.

6 Jones, *The Later Roman Empire*, II p.997.

7 St Augustine *Confessions* 2.3(5) ff. Probably Victor was given the same advice as Augustine, that he should work hard at his grammar to get on in the world.

8 *De Caes.* 16.12; 26.2; 40.10; 40.28.

9 F. Schemmel, 'Die Schule von Karthago', *Phil. Woch.* 47 (1927), pp.1342-44; A. Audollent, *Carthage romaine* (Paris, 1901), pp.692-700.

10 *De Caes.* 41.17; 28.2. Both statements smack of autopsy, particularly the personal aside Victor makes in discussing the reign of Philip. Victor also notes that both the 800th anniversary of Rome (4.14) and the 900th anniversary (15.4) were lavishly celebrated.

11 H.I. Marrou, *A History of Education in Antiquity* (English trans., New York, 1964), p.399. Furthermore, Victor demonstrates knowledge of Salvius Julianus' codification of the *edictum tralaticium* even though he confuses Didius with Salvius Julianus (*De Caes.* 19.2). He also shows evidence of interest in legal matters elsewhere (20.13; 24.6; 28.6; 35.7; 39.31; 41.4). Nixon, p.5, notes that since Victor became a provincial governor and urban prefect and both posts involved much judicial work this *may* indicate that he had received some legal education.

12 Symm. *Ep.* 1.25.

13 John Chrys. *Adv. Opp.* 3.12.369; 3.13.371.

14 Auson. *Protr.* 43-44.

15 *Cod. Theod.* 14.9.1. *Cod. Theod.* 14.1.1, issued by Constantius and Julian, promised advancement to civil servants who gave evidence of education and literary skill.

16 *De Caes.* 20.28; 20.30-31.

17 *De Caes.* 20.5.

18 *De Caes.* 39.27. See 14.6, another sarcastic comment about those lucky enough to be rich.

19 *De Caes.* 39.44.

20 Jones, *The Later Roman Empire*, I pp.127-28; III p.22.

21 *PLRE* s.v. Procopius 4; Iovianus 1.

22 *Ibid.*, p.698.

23 *De Caes.* 39.31-32.

24 *De Caes.* 39.45.

25 *De Caes.* 41.19-20.

26 *De Caes.* 41.28.

27 *De Caes.* 13.6. Ammianus (19.11.2-3) confirms Victor's statement. Anatolius was a pagan and incorruptibly honest.

28 Cf. Plato *Leg.* 4.711b.

29 Nixon, p.12. His discussion of *De Caes.* 13.6-7 is astute: "Victor seldom inserts a topical comment, and even more seldom corrects a generalization, especially when it is on such a favourite theme as the decline of administration or the rascality of imperial officials. Clearly this exception impressed him ...." A similar view is put forward by Dufraigne, p.xi.

30 Ammianus, 20.10.6: *ubi* [Naissus] *Victorem apud Sirmium visum scriptorem historicum exinde venire praeceptum Pannoniae Secundae consularem praefectum* [Iulianus] *et honoravit aenea statua, virum sobrietatis gratia aemulandum, multo post urbi praefectum.*

31 Ammianus 16.10.21.

32 Ammianus 15.3.7.

33 Nixon, pp.12, 37.

34 Dufraigne, p.xi. Victor's final reproach (42.25) may imply autopsy, cf. Lib. *Orat.* 18.130. Libanius reveals that Julian was offended to find Constantius' court full of cooks, barbers, butlers, writers, eunuchs and sundry drones. He promptly dismissed a barber whose extravagant attire resembled that of a senior official (Ammianus 22.4.9). Victor's term *apparitores* clearly refers to such flunkeys.

35 On the *actuarii* see Daremberg-Saglio, I p.60 s.v. *actuarius*; *RE* I 301 s.v. *actuarii*; Jones, *The Later Roman Empire*, I pp.456-59; II pp.626-28. For a fuller discussion and a translation of the passage in question see ch. 4.

36 See Nixon, *loc.cit.* (n.33); I cannot accept W. den Boer's view of this passage, that Victor was worried about the increasing power of the civil service and the decline of senatorial influence and that this caused his outburst against the *actuarii* (see den Boer, 'Rome à travers trois auteurs du quatrième siècle', *Mnemosyne* 21 (1968), pp.263-65; id., *Some Minor Roman Historians*, pp.77-78.

37 Jones, *The Later Roman Empire*, II p.589.

38 1.1; 4.3; 9.6; 9.12; 13.5; 39.31-32; 39.45; 40.24; 41.19-20.

39 Provincial *tabularii* had by 337 usurped the title of *numerarii* and were ordered to revert to their old titles by 365. Victor often notes the subverting of titles and offices (*De Caes.* 9.12; 24.10; 33.24) and may be referring to this. See Jones, *The Later Roman Empire*, II p.594. Professor R.J. Penella informed me that Ammianus (19.11.2-3) also noted Anatolius' elimination of abuses in his administration of the postal system, but he had surely read the *De Caesaribus* and perhaps discussed the matter with Victor.

40 *De Caes.* 16.12; Ammianus 17.5.1; 17.7.1. Cerealis was prefect of the *annona* in 328, was at Sirmium 351-352, was urban prefect 352-358 and became consul in 358 (*PLRE*, pp.197-98; A. Chastagnol, *Les fastes de la préfecture du prétoire à Rome* (Paris, 1962), p.135). As urban prefect Cerealis may well have given Victor help with his career, hence the seemingly gratuitous mention here.

41 *De Caes.* 41.20.

42 J.R. Palanque, *Essai sur la préfecture du prétoire du Bas-Empire* (Paris, 1933), p.24.

43 See T.D. Barnes, *The Sources of the Historia Augusta* (Brussels, 1978), p.90, who thinks this may be an oblique reference to the proclamation of Julian as Augustus.

44 The *De Caesaribus* would not take him ninety minutes to read. Most modern scholars believe that Julian read Latin: see W.E. Kaegi, 'Research on Julian the Apostate 1945-1964', *CW* 58 (1965), p.235; J.F. Gilliam, 'Titus in Julian's *Caesares*', *AJP* 88 (1967), p.207; R. Browning, *The Emperor Julian* (London, 1975), p.34; C. Head, *The Emperor Julian* (Boston, 1976), pp.33, 41, 71, 74; G.W. Bowersock, *Julian the Apostate* (London and Cambridge, Mass., 1978), p.36; P. Athanassiadi-Fowden, *Julian and Hellenism: An Intellectual Biography* (Oxford, 1981), p.55. B. Baldwin, however, whose views are reminiscent of those of E.A. Thompson (*CR* 58 (1944), pp.49-51), is very sceptical and argues against Julian's use of Latin sources, but notes that it is reasonable to assume that the emperor was compelled by his need to be understood by the

soldiers in Gaul and to converse with western luminaries to develop fluency in Latin ('The *Caesares* of Julian', *Klio* 60 (1978), pp.453ff.). I accept Ammianus' statement, *super his aderat Latine quoque disserendi sufficiens sermo* (16.5.7) without cavil. Julian's civil and military administrative duties in Gaul would necessitate fluency in Latin. His popularity with the troops, Gallic and German, depended greatly upon his ability to communicate personally with them, which could only be done in Latin. When his army suffered severe deprivations on the Meuse in 358 the soldiers referred to him as an Asian and a Greekling (Ammianus 17.9.3). Had he not been able to appeal to them in a language they understood he would have had a full-scale mutiny on his hands. Furthermore Julian was clearly a gifted scholar: learning Latin would not have been hard for him. It cannot be established unequivocally that Julian was widely read in Latin, and by inclination he would naturally have turned to Greek authors such as Plutarch for biographical and historical information. Nevertheless even Baldwin admits Julian's fluency in Latin and a perusal of the *De Caesaribus* was not only within the emperor's abilities, it was also a handy way of acquainting himself with the views of a potential administrator.

45 G.W. Bowersock, *op.cit.* (n.44), p.59.

46 Ammianus 21.10.6.

47 *De Caes.* 37.3; 40.9.7; 40.17.

48 Ammianus *loc.cit.* (n.46).

49 *De Caes.* 13.6; 33.13; 35.7; 35.12 etc.

50 Jones, *The Later Roman Empire*, I pp.119-20.

51 Bowersock, *op.cit.* (n.44), pp.61-62.

52 Ammianus 21.9.4ff.; 21.10.7.

53 Jones, *The Later Roman Empire*, II pp.531-32. Dill describes the consulship of the fourth century AD as "one of those dignified fictions by which the Romans distinguished the vastness which separated them from the days of freedom" (*Roman Society in the Last Century of the Western Empire* (London, 1899), p.145). Den Boer's notion that Victor was already a senator (pp.25, 36) comes without substantiation or argument and is unlikely. Nixon, p.17, also believes that Julian adlected Victor to the senate, presumably prior to the official appointment as consular governor.

54 Nixon, p.16. He cites the example of Salutius who helped Valentinian gain the throne. Dufraigne, p.xii, thinks Victor may have played an active role in welcoming Julian to Sirmium.

55 Statues had become fashionable among senatorials according to Ammianus (14.6.8) and Victor would be flattered by this recognition.

56 Nixon, pp.16-17.

57 *Cod. Theod.* 8.5.27; Nixon, p.39.

58 Ammianus 21.10.6; *ILS* 2945, quoted in n.5.

59 Jones, *The Later Roman Empire*, I p.382, followed by Nixon, pp.18, 39.

60 C. Schuurmans, 'Valentinian I et le Sénat Romain', *L'Antiquité Classique* 18 (1949), pp.34-38.

61 Ammianus 26.1; Jones, *The Later Roman Empire*, I pp.139, 390, 392.

62 *PLRE*, p.497 s.v. Iulianus 37.

63 *Ibid.*, p.862, s.v. Syagrius 2; p.837, s.v. Severus 29; p.865, s.v. Symmachus 4. Cf. the lists of *legati proconsulis Africae* in *PLRE*, p.1075, and of *vicarii Africae*, p.1079. There are some strange inconsistencies and numerous errors in the *PLRE*; see T.D. Barnes, in *Phoenix* 26 (1972), pp.140ff. and *Phoenix* 27 (1973), pp.135ff.

64 Symm. *Or.* 4. See Sym. *Epist.* 2.66.2 where Symmachus notes a certain Victor as *spectabilis*. It is impossible to judge whether this was the historian or not but the possibility remains. For a full discussion see Nixon, pp.40-41.

65 *CIL* VI 1186 = *ILS* 2945.

66 See Chastagnol, *op.cit.* (n.40), pp.232ff.; R. Syme, *Ammianus and the Historia Augusta* (Oxford, 1968), p.9; Nixon, pp.19-20; 41-42. Nixon's discussion is full and reasonable.

67 Jones, *The Later Roman Empire*, I pp.385-86.

68 Nixon, p.42.

69 E.g. *Cod. Theod.* 14.1.1. See Alföldi, pp.107ff. The profoundly bureaucratic Egypt of the Pharaohs had a similar dependency on scribes and its educational system had as its primary aim the preparation of young men for positions in the state service.

70 *De Caes.* 20.5. See also *Pan. Lat.* 4.5.6; 7.23; Auson. *Protr.* 43-44; Symm. *Ep.* 1.25.

## NOTES TO CHAPTER TWO

1 A. Enmann, 'Eine verlorene Geschichte der römischen Kaiser', *Philologus* suppl. 4 (1884), pp.335-501, published in June 1883 (*Deutsche Literaturzeitung* 4 (1883)), p.861; A. Cohn, *Quibus e fontibus Sex. Aurelii Victoris et libri de Caesaribus et Epitomes XI capita priora fluxerint* (Berlin, 1884).

2 Cohn, *op.cit.*, p.48. P. Ebeling had already suggested this as a source for Eutropius (*Quaestiones Eutropionae* (Diss. Halle, 1881)).

3 Enmann, *op.cit.* (n.1), pp.407ff., 431f.

4 H. Dessau, 'Über Zeit und Persönlichkeit des S.H.A.', *Hermes* 24 (1889), pp.337ff.

5 T.D. Barnes, 'The Lost Kaisergeschichte and the Latin Historical Tradition', *BHAC* 1968/69 (1970), pp.13-43, esp. p.20; *The Sources of the Historia Augusta*, p.92. His view is shared by R. Syme, *Emperors and Biography: Studies in the Historia Augusta* (Oxford, 1971), p.222, but cf. *Ammianus and the Historia Augusta* (Oxford, 1968), p.106.

6 *De Caes.* 41.16-17; Eutrop. 10.8. Cf. den Boer, pp.21-22, 67-68, 116-19, who denies the importance of verbal parallels.

7 *De Caes.* 41.26; Eutrop. 10.10.

8 Nixon, p.341. However, he sensibly leaves open the possibility of a common source (p.344) while admitting the existence of the K.G. (p.364).

9 *De Caes.* 42.1-4; Eutrop. 10.11.

10 *De Caes.* 42.6; 42.8; Eutrop. *loc.cit.*

11 Barnes, 'The Lost Kaisergeschichte', p.14.

12 Den Boer, p.21.

13 S.I. Oost, review of den Boer in *CP* 71 (1976), pp.294-95. Ironically, Barnes' review article on Schlumberger's *Epitome de Caesaribus* appeared in the same issue.

14 A. Chastagnol, *BHAC* 1971 (1974), pp.55f.

15 Dufraigne, p.xxvii.

16 Rightly so, in my opinion, by Barnes, *The Sources of the Historia Augusta*, p.93.

17 Dufraigne, pp.xxx, xxxii, xxxiii, xxxv, xxxvii. Most of these are noted by R.J. Tarrant, *Gnomon* 50 (1978), p.356.

18 Den Boer, pp.92, 101, 110, 119. Yet he admits that we know next to nothing of the current education, camp stories or stock anecdotes of the imperial service (p.187).

19 See S. Dill, *Roman Society in the Last Century of the Western Empire*, p.399.

20 H.I. Marrou, *A History of Education in Antiquity*, pp.358ff.

21 C.E.V. Nixon, review of den Boer in *Phoenix* 27 (1973), p.408.

22 *De Caes.* 17.10; Eutrop. 8.16; *Epit.* 8.16; *H.A. Pert.* 4.3.

23 *De Caes.* 15.2; Eutrop. *loc.cit.*; *Epit. loc.cit.*; *H.A. Did.* 3.7; cf. *H.A. Pert.* 10.8ff. For the connection with Albinus see n.33.

24 Dio 73.9.10.

25 *De Caes.* 19.1; 20.1; Eutrop. 8.17.

26 Cf. Dio 74.17.

27 Dufraigne, p.122. He notes that Orosius had it (7.16.6).

28 Nixon, p.250, states that the hypothesis that Victor follows the K.G. here seems to be confirmed by this.

29 *De Caes.* 19.4.

30 *Epit.* 19.2. But at Savaria, not Carnuntum (*H.A. Sev.* 5.1). "Perhaps a simple mistake, due to the place's later importance. *Savaria* led to confusion with Niger's province, Syria." (A. Birley, *Septimius Severus: The African Emperor* (New York, 1972), p.158 n.1).

31 *De Caes.* 20.8; Eutrop. 8.18.

32 *De Caes.* 20.9; Eutrop. 8.18; *H.A. Sev.* 5.8.

33 *De Caes.* 20.9; Eutrop. 8.18; *H.A. Clod. Alb.* 1.1; 14.2; 14.6. This may have appeared in the official version of events in 193 and 195-196. Albinus and Julianus both had connections with Hadrumetum which would have assisted Severus, the self-styled avenger of Pertinax, as he sought to legitimize his actions against his opponents: see Birley, *op.cit.* (n.30), pp.12, 46, 71, 135, 155, 159, 169 and esp. 185.

34 *De Caes.* 20.14.

35 Dio 77.12.1a; 80.16.2; Herodian 3.9.3.

36 *H.A. Sev.* 18.1.

37 *De Caes.* 20.22.

38 Nixon, pp.256-97.

39 Barnes, *The Sources of the Historia Augusta*, pp.90ff.

40 Dufraigne, pp.xxviii, xxix.

41 Id., p.xxxi.

42 Nixon, p.149. Cf. Cohn, *op.cit.* (n.1), p.49.

43 *De Caes.* 11.13. The phrase is Sallustian but still completely credible.

44 *De Caes.* 5.8-9.

45 *De Caes.* 14.8; 20.10; 20.34; 29.5; 39.48.

46 *Op.cit.* (n.1), pp.49ff.

47 *De Caes.* 3.4.

48 Suet. *Calig.* 8.

49 *Ann.* 6.50.9. Tacitus and Suetonius generally use the *praenomen* Tiberius to denote Rome's second emperor.

50 *De Caes.* 3.1: cf. Suet. *Tib.* 73. I take Pichlmayr's reading of *Febri an* to be correct.

51 *Epit.* 2.10; 3.2.

52 Dufraigne, pp.70ff.

53 Suetonius (*Calig.* 1-7) actually writes a mini-biography of Germanicus in his life of Caligula though his treatment of Sejanus is extremely brief (*Tib.* 55).

54 *De Caes.* 4.14.

55 Tac. *Ann.* 6.28; Dio 58.27.1.

56 *N.H.* 10.2.5; also see Solinus 33.14.

57 Dufraigne, pp.xxx-xxxi, 80.

58 Sen. *Q.N.* 6.21.1; Dio 60.29.7; Oros. 7.6.13.

59 *Ibid.*

60 Dufraigne, p.xxxv: cf. Nixon, p.363.

61 Hieron. *Ep.* 10.3.

62 *Chron. praef.* 6-7 (Helm): Jerome dedicated his *De Viris Illustribus* to Nummius Aemilius Dexter who had apparently written a universal history (*De Vir. Ill. praef.* 132).

63 J.N.D. Kelly, *Jerome: His Life, Writing and Controversies* (London, 1975), pp.73-75; H. von Campenhausen, *The Fathers of the Latin Church* (Eng. trans., London, 1964), pp.147-48.

64 H. Hagendahl, *Latin Fathers and the Classics* (Göteborg, 1958), p.308. The description is quoted with apparent assent by R. Syme in *Ammianus and the Historia Augusta*, p.81.

65 For his manifest error in locating the Philippopolis of Philip the Arab in Thrace see Barnes, 'The Lost Kaisergeschichte', p.21.

66 The comparison is hazardous: Jerome was a scholar who dedicated most of his life to writing; Victor was an imperial bureaucrat who wrote, as far as we know, one short work in his spare time.

67 Dessau, *op.cit.* (n.4), p.381.

68 Dufraigne, p.xxxvii.

69 Nixon, p.330.

70 I should like to thank Professor A. Birley for making several helpful suggestions after reading the first draft of this chapter.

## NOTES TO CHAPTER THREE

1 Tac. *Hist.* 1.84.

2 *Res Gestae* 34.

3 The anonymous epitomator begins his work with almost identical words, but cf. Eutrop. 6.25 where Eutropius makes the *regia ac paene tyrannica* acts of Caesar and his resultant assassination the end of his sixth and final 'republican' book. Book seven deals with events from Caesar's death to that of Domitian.

4 *De Caes.* 3.14-15. Cf. Dio 59.29.1. He uses the word *libertas* only once, here, and significantly juxtaposes the term *libido*. The section ends in mock Tacitean fashion: *ita Romae regia potestas firmata* . . . (3.20). The plebs at this juncture combined with the soldiers against the senate in putting Claudius on the throne.

5 Tac. *Hist.* 4.8; R. Syme, *Tacitus* (Oxford, 1958), p.547.

6 See R.C. Blockley, *Ammianus Marcellinus: A Study of his Historiography and Political Thought* (Brussels, 1975), pp.157ff. Cf. Eutrop. 6.25, where Eutropius shows hostility to Caesar, who contraverted *libertas Romana*, and favour to the assassins and to the earlier Brutus who deposed Tarquinius Superbus.

7 Note particularly how Victor assigns Julian's success in Gaul to Constantius (*De Caes.* 42.18). It was normal imperial propaganda but Ammianus disapproved of it (Ammianus 16.12.65-70; see also 17.13.26-33).

8 A.D.E. Cameron, *Hermes* 92 (1964), p.375.

9 For Ammianus see Blockley, *op.cit.* (n.6), pp.32ff.

10 Ammianus 15.1.3; 29.5.46.

11 Festus 26; 28.

12 *De Caes.* 5.4; 8.8.

13 Blockley, *op.cit.* (n.6), p.33.

14 *De Caes.* 5.14.

15 *De Caes.* 9.2.

16 Dio Chrys. *Or.* 3.1.9. For a full list of virtues which might be used in a eulogy see Marrou, *A History of Education in Antiquity*, pp.272-73.

17 *De Caes.* 13.9. Cf. Eutrop. 8.5.

18 *De Caes.* 13.7. The Epitomator is similarly enthusiastic about Trajan and chooses that emperor's reign as the juncture at which he states his views on the ideal emperor: *cumque duo sint, quae ab egregiis principibus expectentur, sanctitas domi, in armis fortitudo, utrobique prudentia, tantus erat in eo maximarum rerum modus, ut quasi temperamento quodam virtutes miscuisse videretur* (*Epit.* 13.4). Eutropius, too, is full of praise for Trajan (8.4-5). Den Boer takes his statement "In my position as emperor I treat the common citizen as I should wish to be treated by an emperor if I were a common citizen" to imply his ideal of cooperation

between senate and emperor (p.151).

19 *De Caes.* 20.21.

20 *De Caes.* 20.24.

21 *De Caes.* 40.29-30.

22 *De Caes.* 41.20-21.

23 Even Caracalla is exculpated: his murder of Papinian is denied by Victor and his affair with his supposed stepmother is blamed on her (*De Caes.* 20.33-34). The story and the false statement that Julia was Caracalla's stepmother probably derives from the K.G. for it appears in Eutrop. 8.20, *Epit.* 21.5 and *H.A. Carac.* 10.1. Cf. Dio 78.24.1; Herod. 4.9.3, and J. Babelon, *Impératrices Syriennes* (Paris, 1957), p.65. On Vespasian's weakness for money cf. Eutrop. 7.19; *Epit.* 9.7; on Antoninus Pius' lack of military exploits cf. Eutrop. 8.8; *Epit.* 15.3; 15.6; on Severus' clemency and harshness cf. Eutrop. 8.18; *Epit.* 20.5-6.

24 Eutrop. 8.18-19.

25 Cf. Eutrop. 8.22.

26 Syme, *Ammianus and the Historia Augusta*, pp.118, 134-35; *Emperors and Biography*, pp.146-62.

27 *Ibid.*, p.160.

28 *Ibid.*, p.205.

29 *De Caes.* 33.30.

30 Cf. *H.A. Gall. Duo*; Eutrop. 9.7ff. The Epitomator noticeably does not share their views (*Epit.* 33.1-3).

31 *De Caes.* 33.34.

32 Eutrop. 9.8.

33 For a complete analysis of all the emperors see appendix II. Eutropius' descriptions of the emperors appear to be more stereotyped than those of Victor. Den Boer, pp.150ff., points out Eutropius' profound interest in the *consecratio* of the emperors and notes that "his interest in the emperors' origins, lively though it is, is not as intense as that of Aurelius Victor" (p.160).

34 *De Caes.* 8.7-8. According to R.C. Blockley, 'Constantius, Gallus and Julian as Caesars', *Latomus* 31 (1972), p.444, Ammianus made education the first prerequisite of a leader. For a fuller discussion of the views of Ammianus and others see Blockley, *loc.cit.* (n.6). Note Victor's major criticism of Alexander, Vetranio and Nepotianus: they were all stupid.

35 *De Caes.* 39.26. On the importance of character and education in the *De Caesaribus* see W. den Boer, 'Rome à travers trois auteurs du quatrième siècle', *Mnemosyne* 21 (1968), p.258.

36 *De Caes.* 40.12-13. This passage complements 8.7-8. Cf. *H.A. Car.* 18.4; Eutrop. 9.26-27.

37 For *senatus*: *De Caes.* 3.9; 3.16; 4.4; 5.5; 5.14; 9.9; 11.8; 14.11; 17.10; 20.1; 26.7; 32.3; 33.31; 33.34; 34.4; 36.1; 36.2; 37.5; 40.24. For *patres*: 3.8; 3.18; 10.3; 11.2; 13.11; 14.10; 14.13; 16.15; 25.2; 30.1; 33.27; 33.33; 35.9; 40.24; 40.26; 42.7. This does not include other terms used synonymously or with similar intent, e.g. *optimi*, *optimus quisque* (3.9; 5.13; 9.9; 24.6; 33.34; 35.12); *optimates* (11.10); *proceres* (1.1; 31.3; 36.1); cf. *sapientes* (3.6); *prudentes* (3.5; 9.12; 11.10; 32.4); *boni* (3.5; 4.2; 8.8; 9.12; 11.5; 20.5-

6; 20.12; 24.9; 28.8; 34.6; 42.24).

38 Alföldi, p.98.

39 C.G. Starr, 'Aurelius Victor: Historian of Empire', *AHR* 61 (1955/56), p.579; den Boer, p.25.

40 Symm. *Ep.* 1.52.

41 Syme, *Ammianus and the Historia Augusta*, p.152; J. Matthews, *Western Aristocracies and the Imperial Court* (Oxford, 1975), p.254.

42 Jones, *The Later Roman Empire*, I p.332; II pp.531, 537.

43 Alföldi, p.125.

44 *Ibid.* Note Eutropius' passionate defence of Trajan's relationship with the senate (Eutrop. 8.4).

45 For Tacitus see Syme, *Tacitus*, pp.547ff. and especially pp.564-65.

46 *De Caes.* 3.18-20.

47 *De Caes.* 4.1-2. Note the comments of Syme, *Tacitus*, p.438.

48 *De Caes.* 9.9.

49 *De Caes.* 3.5. Eutropius is likewise conscious of birth, giving the lineage of practically every emperor and castigating such *obscurissime nati* as Aemilianus (9.6), Postumus, Marius (9.9), Carausius (9.21). Even Constantine is not immune, *ex obscuriore matrimonio* (10.2).

50 *De Caes.* 8.4. Cf. Eutrop. 7.19.

51 *De Caes.* 10.3-4.

52 *De Caes.* 14.6.

53 *De Caes.* 14.13-14; cf. *Epit.* 14.9; Eutrop. 8.7.

54 *De Caes.* 15.1.

55 *H.A. Ant. Pius* 2.4.

56 *De Caes.* 16.15. When the *vulgus* acted in concert with the senate it was viewed by Victor positively, e.g. *De Caes.* 33.31; 40.24. It was viewed negatively when it acted with the praetorians or helped to install a pretender, e.g. 3.18; 29.3; 40.5; 42.6.

57 *De Caes.* 17.10. For positive mentions of the *plebs* when it acted in concert with the senate see 33.32; 40.24; 42.7; for a negative mention when it supported the army see 3.17.

58 *De Caes.* 24.6.

59 *De Caes.* 25.2. The Epitomator (*Epit.* 25.1) and the *H.A.* (*Max. Duo* 8.1) state that Maximinus came from the ranks of the soldiers. Eutropius (9.1) informs us that the army alone made the choice, that the senate had not intervened and that Maximinus was not a senator. Den Boer, p.151, thinks that the extreme brevity accorded to Maximinus by Eutropius is "inspired by contempt". It is far more likely that the brevity of all three epitomators regarding that emperor was caused by ignorance, that their common source, the K.G., had little information to impart. Den Boer also denies the existence of the K.G. (see chapter two) and is thereby compelled to resort to ingenuity. Note the cogent statements of G.M. Bersanetti, *Studi sull'imperatore Massimino il Trace* (Rome, 1940), pp.9ff.; Syme, *Emperors and Biography*, pp.189ff.

60 *De Caes.* 26.7. Victor gives Calvinus Balbinus the erroneous *nomen* Caecilius and wrongly designates both *Augusti* as *Caesares*.

61 H.M.D. Parker, *A History of the Roman World A.D. 138 to 337* (2nd ed. London, 1958), p.146.

62 *De Caes.* 27.1ff. Victor is singularly ill-informed about this period, confusing Gordian II with Gordian III, assigning him the rank of *Augustus* instead of *Caesar* and maintaining that Pupienus subdued the Maximini. Since Eutropius shares these errors (Eutrop. 9.1) it appears likely that both inherited them from their common source, the K.G. For the length of the reign see *Chron. Min.* 1.147.

63 *De Caes.* 29.3.

64 *De Caes.* 30.1.

65 *De Caes.* 31.3.

66 *De Caes.* 32.3.

67 *De Caes.* 33.27.

68 *De Caes.* 33.29.

69 P. Damerau, 'Kaiser Claudius II Gothicus', *Klio* Beiheft 33 (1934), pp.46-47.

70 Alföldi, p.66.

71 *De Caes.* 33.34.

72 Ammianus 21.16.9; 23.5.3; 30.8.8.

73 Ammianus 21.16.10; cf. Zon. 12.15.

74 *De Caes.* 34.4.

75 Eutrop. 9.11; *H.A. Claud.* 12.2; Zos. 1.46; Zon. 12.26; Sync. p.270; Malalas p.299.

76 *Epit.* 34.3.

77 *De Caes.* 34.6.

78 Ammianus 30.8.14; cf. 29.2.18; 25.3.18.

79 *De Caes.* 35.9-11.

80 *De Caes.* 35.14.

81 *De Caes.* 36.2; cf. *H.A. Tac.* 2.1-2.

82 Syme, *Emperors and Biography*, pp.237ff. Cf. *H.A. Aur.* 40.1ff.; *Tac.* 1.1ff.

83 *CIL* VIII 18848; *PIR*$^2$ II C. 1036.

84 *ILS* 569; *PIR*$^2$ J. 468.

85 Cf. *De Caes.* 36.1-2; *Epit.* 36.1; Eutrop. 9.16; *H.A. Tac.* 13.4. See E. Hohl, 'Vopiscus und die Biographie des Kaisers Tacitus', *Klio* 17 (1911), p.308.

86 *De Caes.* 36.2.

87 H. Mattingly, *Camb. Anc. Hist.* XII p.318; cf. Alföldi, pp.99ff.; Starr, *op.cit.* (n.39), p.579; A. Bellezza, 'Interpretazione di un passo di Aurelio Vittore (Caesares 33,34) sulla politica imperiale romana del III secolo', *Atti della Accademia Ligure di Scienze e Lettere* 17 (1960), pp.149ff.; Parker, *op.cit.* (n.61), pp.178-81; p.213.

88 Den Boer, p.87.

89 Alföldi, p.99.

90 Matthews, *op.cit.* (n.41), pp.28ff.

91 A. Chastagnol, *Les Fastes de la préfecture de Rome au bas-empire* (Paris,

1962), pp.218-229.

92 Jones, *The Later Roman Empire*, II pp.535-36. Some of these privileges were subsequently modified.

93 Matthews, *op.cit.* (n.41), p.17.

94 *Ibid.*; Dill, *Roman Society in the Last Days of the Western Empire*, p.249.

95 Den Boer, p.25; also see pp.35, 41. Nixon, p.16, disagrees, concluding with the present author that Victor was adlected into the senate in AD 361. See chapter one, n.53 (on p.131).

96 *De Caes.* 39.7; cf. Tac. *Ann.* 2.33. See Syme, *Tacitus*, II pp.566ff., for some sagacious remarks about the nobility of the early empire.

97 *De Caes.* 39.27.

98 Den Boer, pp.159, 151-54. For emphasis on obscure birth of emperors or pretenders see Eutrop. 9.6; 9.9; 9.19; 9.21; 10.2. For emphasis on bad treatment of senate see Eutrop. 7.2; 7.3; 7.14; 7.23; 9.1; 9.14; 10.11; cf. 8.4; 8.8; 8.13. For senate's acclamation of emperors see Eutrop. 8.16; 8.23; 9.11; 9.12.

99 *De Caes.* 25.2.

100 One final point needs elucidation. Victor frequently juxtaposes the senate and the people or the *aratores*, the first instance occurring in M. Aurelius' reign Like Ammianus (31.5.14) he seems to have believed that in M. Aurelius' time the Romans flourished because they were less hedonistic and were still prepared to fight and die for the state. Moreover, under an enlightened ruler such as M. Aurelius, Victor felt that the highest and lowest citizens could be made to work together. Obviously such a situation did not exist in Victor's time nor thirty years later when Ammianus was writing. What emerges is that Victor anticipated Ammianus in ascribing the disintegration of Rome to psychological causes, i.e. to a decline in personal morality. The theme was a commonplace, probably picked up by both writers from Sallust: indeed one may just as readily level against Victor Thompson's charge against Ammianus (*The Historical Work of Ammianus Marcellinus*, p.132): "He fails to see that a decline in personal morality is itself an historical phenomenon requiring explanation: it is merely a symptom of underlying social and economic causes."

101 *De Caes.* 37.7. Victor is certainly referring to his own day here.

102 Matthews, *op.cit.* (n.41), p.30. Cf. F. Lot, *The End of the Ancient World and the Beginning of the Middle Ages* (Eng. trans. by G. Downey, New York, 1961), pp.232-33.

103 A. Garzetti, *From Tiberius to the Antonines* (Eng. trans. by J.R. Foster, London, 1974), p.310, citing Plin. *Pan.* 4.1.

104 *De Caes.* 33.26.

105 R. Browning, *The Emperor Julian* (Berkeley, 1976), p.130.

106 See nn.10 and 11 and the text thereto (p.25).

## NOTES TO CHAPTER FOUR

1 M. Grant, *The Army of the Caesars* (London, 1974), p.xvi.

2 *De Caes.* 37.3; cf. Eutrop. 9.17: *brevi milites necessarios non futuros*; *H.A. Prob.* 20.3.

3 R.E. Smith, *Service in the Post-Marian Army* (Manchester, 1958), pp.73-74.

4 *De Caes.* 1.1; cf. Tac. *Ann.* 1.2.1.

5 *De Caes.* 2.3. Tiberius' concentration of the praetorians at Rome is plainly viewed negatively by Victor (2.4).

6 Eutrop. 7.11; *Epit.* 2.8-9.

7 *De Caes.* 3.14-15. Victor's term *externos*, like his subsequent term *advenae* (11.12) indicates non-Italians. The former, linked with *barbaros*, is a pejorative, the latter is clearly used in a positive sense. The word *barbarus* which Victor employs ten times (3.15; 29.4; 33.8; 34.5; 37.3; 37.7; 38.2; 39.21; 41.25; 42.15) appears to signify Germans or other northerners. Some of these had been transferred to depopulated Roman territories in the northern provinces.

8 Grant, *op.cit.* (n.1), pp.277-80. German *auxilia* formed the backbone of the Gallic mobile field army in Julian's day: see J. Hoffman, *Das spätrömische Bewegungsheer* (Düsseldorf, 1969), pp.137ff.

9 Suet. *Aug.* 49.

10 *De Caes.* 3.16.

11 *De Caes.* 3.20.

12 *De Caes.* 4.15. Cf. *Epit.* 4.12.

13 Tac. *Ann.* 12.69.

14 *De Caes.* 6.2; 8.3.

15 *De Caes.* 8.2-3.

16 *De Caes.* 24.9.

17 *De Caes.* 11.9-11. Cf. Suet. *Domit.* 23; *Epit.* 12.8.

18 Ammianus 29.4.1.

19 *De Caes.* 12.1-2. Nerva is described as Cretan; he took power *arbitrio legionum* and abdicated in his sixteenth month of power (*De Caes.* 12.1-2). Lactantius also has him abdicate (*De Mort. Persec.* 18.4). The story presumably stems from a tradition equating Nerva's adoption of Trajan with abdication: it is not in Eutropius or the *Epitome*, but cf. Pliny *Pan.* 6.3; 8.4. For a good discussion of Nerva in the epitomators see Nixon, pp.149-68.

20 A. Garzetti, *From Tiberius to the Antonines* (Eng. trans. by J.R. Foster, London, 1974), p.294.

21 Eutrop. 8.1; *Epit.* 11.11.

22 Garzetti, *op.cit.* (n.20), pp.303-307; Syme, *Tacitus*, pp.10-18.

23 *De Caes.* 18.1-2.

24 Eutrop. 8.16. Eutropius, the Epitomator and the *H.A.* note Julianus' complicity (Eutrop. *loc.cit.*; *Epit.* 18.2; *H.A. D.J.* 3.7; *Clod. Alb.* 14.2; 14.6). It is not verified by Dio or Herodian.

25 *De Caes.* 19.1.

26 Dio 73.7.1; Herod. 2.6.8; *H.A. D.J.* 2.6.

27 *De Caes.* 20.1. Cf. *H.A. Sev.* 17.5; Dio 74.1.1-2; Herod. 2.13.1ff.

28 *De Caes.* 22.1; 22.4.

29 Eutrop. 8.21; cf. *H.A. Carac.* 8.10; *Macr.* 2.1; 2.5; 5.1; Dio 78.14.2; Herod. 4.14.2; Zos. 1.10.

30 *Epit.* 22.

31 Cf. Eutrop. 8.22; *Epit.* 23.5.

32 See chapter three.

33 *De Caes.* 24.1-4. Eutropius (8.23) uses the same phrase, *militari tumultu*, to describe the assassination of both Heliogabalus and Alexander. The Epitomator elaborates somewhat (*Epit.* 24.4).

34 *De Caes.* 24.7-11. Victor's implicit suggestion that the Romans should pursue a vigorous foreign policy is intriguing in view of Constantius' poor record in this regard (Eutrop. 10.15; *Epit.* 42.18; Ammianus 21.16.15). Julian, after his successes in Gaul, decided upon a more aggressive policy.

35 Cf. Eutrop. 8.23; *H.A. Alex.* 41.5; 59.41.

36 Herod. 6.7.10; 8.3.

37 Herod. 6.4.7;Dio 80.3.1.

38 *H.A. Alex.* 25.2.

39 *H.A. Alex.* 64.1.

40 Cf. M. Cary and H.H. Scullard, *A History of Rome* (3rd ed., London, 1975), p.556.

41 Eutrop. 10.12.1; *Epit.* 42.4; *Cons. Constantinop. a.d.* 351.1; Zos. 2.46.2-53.1; Zon. 13.8.5-18.

42 *De Caes.* 42.11.

43 *De Caes.* 42.14-15; Eutrop. 10.13; *Epit.* 42.10-11; Ammianus 15.5.1-31; Hieron. *Chron.* p.321; Oros. 7.29.

44 *De Caes.* 42.18-19. So, too, Barnes, *The Sources of the Historia Augusta*, p.90.

45 *De Caes.* 3.20.

46 *De Caes.* 26.1. Cf. Eutrop. 9.1; *H.A. Max. Duo* 8.1. Presumably the information derives from the K.G.

47 *De Caes.* 26.6.

48 *De Caes.* 27.6.

49 *De Caes.* 28.11.

50 *De Caes.* 29.2.

51 *De Caes.* 31.1-2.

52 *De Caes.* 32.1-2.

53 *De Caes.* 33.1-7.

54 *De Caes.* 33.8-9.

55 *De Caes.* 33.12.

56 *De Caes.* 33.13.

57 Den Boer, p.78; *id.*, 'Rome à travers trois auteurs du quatrième siècle', *Mnemosyne* 21 (1968), pp.263-65.

58 Jones, *The Later Roman Empire*, I pp.456-59.

59 See *RE* I 301 s.v. *actuarius*; Daremberg-Saglio, I p.60 s.v. *actuarius*.

60 Ammianus 15.5.3; 25.10.7; 20.5.9.

61 Tac. *Ann.* 19.5.

62 *Cod. Theod.* 13.2; 16.3.6.7; 32.1; O. Seeck, *Geschichte des Untergangs der antiken Welt* II (2nd ed., Stuttgart, 1921), pp.101ff.; 330ff.; Alföldi, pp.28ff.; E.A. Thompson, *A Roman Reformer and Inventor* (Oxford, 1952), *passim*.

63 Victor describes himself as *rure ortus tenui atque indocto patre* (*De Caes.* 20.5).

64 See *Cod. Theod.* 8.1.14; 1.15, on actuaries falsifying accounts and drawing excessive supplies.

65 *De Caes.* 33.14.

66 *De Caes.* 33.20-21. Cf. *Epit.* 33.2.

67 *De Caes.* 33.23-26.

68 *De Caes.* 34.1.

69 *De Caes.* 35.7.

70 *De Caes.* 35.11.

71 *De Caes.* 35.4.

72 Eutrop. 9.13; cf. *Epit.* 35.7.

73 *De Caes.* 37.3-4. Cf. Eutrop. 9.17.

74 *De Caes.* 37.5-7; also 33.34; 35.9; cf. *H.A. Tac.* 2.1-6; Syme, *Emperors and Biography*, pp.109-207; 237-47.

75 *De Caes.* 40.7; 40.9; 40.16. Cf. Eutrop. 10.2.

76 *De Caes.* 42.16.

77 *De Caes.* 40.25.

78 *De Caes.* 41.26. F. Lot observes that "In the middle of the fourth century soldier, *miles*, was the synonym of *barbarus*" (*The End of the Ancient World and the Beginnings of the Middle Ages* (New York, 1961), p.232).

79 *De Caes.* 41.25. He was commander of the Jovians and Herculians. Silvanus, who revolted in 355 while serving as *magister peditum*, was one of many Franks *quorum ea tempestate in palatio multitudo florebat* (Ammianus 15.5.11). Three officers in Constantius' Rhine army in 354 were Alamans, Latinus, Agilo and Scudilo (Ammianus 14.10.8).

80 *De Caes.* 25.1.

81 Severus' position was similar to that of Constantine in 312. The latter, however, no longer needed troops at Rome and did not replace the praetorians. On the praetorians in 193 see M. Durry, *Les cohortes prétoriennes* (Paris, 1938), pp.245ff.; A. Passerini, *Le coorti pretorie* (Rome, 1939), pp.179-91, 198. Cassius Dio and the inhabitants of Rome were terrified by the Pannonian troops in 193 (Dio 74.2.2-3). Indeed, they had not seen frontier forces in the capital since the civil wars of 68/69. Even Severus found it difficult to control them (Dio 46.46.7; *H.A. Sev.* 7.6; 8.9) and Dio maintains that he, too, was frightened by them.

82 *De Caes.* 39.15. On Diocletian's seizure of power see H.W. Bird,

'Diocletian and the Deaths of Carus, Numerian and Carinus', *Latomus* 35 (1976), pp.123-32.

83 *Pan.* 3.5.3; *H.A. Car.* 15.6; Lact. *De Mort. Persec.* 11.8, cf. 7.11.

84 *De Caes.* 39.28. Cf. *Pan.* 2.9.3; 2.10.1; 3.6; 6.9.2; Lact. *De Mort. Persec.* 8.1.

85 *De Caes.* 39.48.

86 M. Cary and H.H. Scullard, *A History of Rome* (3rd ed., London, 1975), p.556.

87 *De Caes.* 4.1ff.

88 *De Caes.* 4.5-10. Cf. Tac. *Ann.* 11.28; Suet. *Claud.* 29.1; Dio 60.2.4; *Epit.* 4.3.

89 Cf. *De Caes.* 42.24-25.

90 *De Caes.* 9.6-9.

91 *De Caes.* 9.12.

92 *De Caes.* 13.5-7. For details on the *cursus publicus* see H.G. Pflaum, *Essai sur le cursus publicus sous le Haut-Empire romain* (Paris, 1940). On this passage see especially p.248.

93 Ammianus 19.11.2-3.

94 See chapter one and Ammianus 21.10.6.

95 *De Caes.* 20.21.

96 Eutrop. 8.19; *Epit.* 20.3-7.

97 *De Caes.* 42.24-25 leads one to conclude that many of Victor's statements, particularly his asides, were intended as advice for Constantius.

98 *De Caes.* 34.8.

99 *De Caes.* 35.7-8.

100 Cf. Eutrop. 9.15; *Epit.* 35.8; *H.A. Aur.* 35.5; Lact. *De Mort. Persec.* 6.2.

101 *H.A. Aur.* 39.3-5.

102 *De Caes.* 35.12.

103 *Quae sane illorum temporum modestia tolerabilis in perniciem processit his tempestatibus* (*De Caes.* 39.32).

104 Cf. *De Caes.* 9.12; 33.13; also 5.13; 27.3; 40.17; 41.10. *Tempestas* is not a neutral term in the *De Caesaribus* and its meaning can best be rendered by the expression "tempestuous (or turbulent) times".

105 Victor uses *sane* nineteen times; on all but one occasion it denotes strong emotion, mostly indignation: 3.17; 4.11; 5.6; 5.13; 10.6; 20.33; 27.1; 31.3; 33.29; 36.1; 37.3; 39.26; 39.31; 39.40; 39.46; 41.6; 41.17; 41.23. In 40.11 it is used neutrally.

106 *De Caes.* 39.44-45. On the *frumentarii* see Fiebiger, *RE* VII 122-25 s.v. *frumentarii*; W.G. Sinnigen, 'The Roman Secret Service', *CJ* 57 (1961), pp.66ff.; on the *agentes* see Seeck, *RE* I 776-79 s.v. *agentes in rebus*; Jones, *The Later Roman Empire*, II pp.578-82. The change of name may have been cosmetic. Cf. the arrangements for state security in the Soviet Union: the *Cheka* was replaced by the GPU in 1922 and the latter was given greater powers; in 1934 the NKVD replaced the GPU, only to be subdivided in 1943 into the NKVD and the NKGB; from 1946 to 1953 the two Commissariats were upgraded to Ministries (MVD; MGB),

which were merged after Stalin's death.

107 Jones, *The Later Roman Empire*, I p.127; II p.582; III p.170.

108 Lact. *De Mort. Persec.* 7.

109 A. Déléage, *La capitation du Bas-Empire* (Macon, 1945), pp.255ff.

110 Lact. *De Mort. Persec.* 9.11; cf. Euseb. *H.E.* 13.

111 Eutrop. 9.23.

112 Note Victor's statement in *De Caes.* 42.23: *cultu genitoris satis pius suique nimis custos*; cf. Ammianus 21.16.1ff.

113 *De Caes.* 41.20-21.

114 *De Caes.* 41.23; cf. Eutrop. 10.9; *Epit.* 41.22.

115 *De Caes.* 42.23. The feeling is shared by Starr, 'Aurelius Victor, Historian of Empire', p.582 n.27.

116 *H.A. Car.* 18.5.

117 O. Seeck, *op.cit.* (n.62), pp.101ff.; 330ff.; Alföldi, pp.28-47.

118 Ammianus, 24.4.2-5.

119 Ammianus 27.9.1ff.; 28.6.15ff.; 39.2.9-12; see Thompson, *op.cit.* (n.62), p.128.

120 R.C. Blockley, 'The Panegyric of Claudius Mamertinus on the Emperor Julian', *AJP* 93 (1972), pp.445, 449.

121 Rutil. Namat. 1.358ff.; Sulp. Sev. *Chron.* 2.49.3.

122 W. Goffart, 'Did Julian Combat Venal *Suffragium*? A Note on *C.Th.* 2.29.1', *CP* 65 (1970), pp.145-51; Jones, *The Later Roman Empire*, I pp.391-93; Alföldi, p.35.

123 Themist. *Or.* 10.136 A; Zos. 4.27.3; Liban. *Or.* 2.37ff.; 2.47.9ff.; 13.17.29ff. Army expenses made up about half the imperial budget in the principate (Pekary, *Historia* 8 (1959), pp.472ff.) and possibly a greater proportion in the late empire, despite Segré (*Byzantion* 16 (1942/43), p.437).

124 Ammianus 27.7.2.

125 *De Caes.* 13.7; 35.14.

126 People who *rapere aliena officia quae regere nequeunt* (*De Caes.* 24.10).

127 Ammianus 16.8.13.

128 Ammianus 15.1.2-3; 15.5.35-37.

129 Eutrop. 10.15.

130 Note how he downplays Constantius' poor performances in external wars in 42.20; cf. Eutrop. 10.15; *Epit.* 42.18; Ammianus 14.10.16; 21.16.1ff.

131 *De Caes.* 40.30. Cf. *H.A. Alex.* 65-66, where the author may have been thinking along similar lines in his severe criticism of bad friends and especially of eunuchs. He concludes his remarks with the following: *scio, imperator, quod periculo ista dicantur apud imperatorem qui talibus serviit, sed salva re publica posteaquam intellexisti quid mali clades istae habeant* ....

132 The term has various meanings, all indicating low-level subordinates, but here, appended as it is to the comment on provincial governors, military commanders and ministers, it can only refer to them.

133 *De Caes.* 24.10.

134 A. Momigliano, *Essays in Ancient and Modern Historiography* (Oxford, 1977), p.135.

135 Jones, *The Later Roman Empire*, I pp.128, 393, 391, 415, 430, 432, 451-52, 466; II pp.573, 578, 627-28, 831, 833; J. Bidez, *La Vie de l'empereur Julien* (Paris, 1930), pp.213ff.; 242ff.

136 R. Browning, *The Emperor Julian*, p.128. Blockley notes Ammianus' emphasis on Julian's civil administration (*Ammianus Marcellinus*, p.79). Yet religious affiliation did play a part in the selection of senior magistrates. The findings of R. Von Haehling, *Die Religionszugehörigkeit der hohen Beamten im römischen Reich von Constantins Alleinherrschaft bis zum Ende der theodosianischen Dynastie* (Diss. Bonn, 1975), pp.494-503, point to Julian's systematic exclusion of Christians from senior civilian posts and his maintenance of Christians in the highest military offices.

137 Goffart, *op.cit.* (n.122), p.149. His views were subsequently modified by T.D. Barnes, 'A Law of Julian', *CP* 69 (1974), pp.288-91.

138 Alföldi, p.31. His chapter on corruption is impassioned and cogent, if rather too sympathetic to Valentinian. It is superfluous to cite modern parallels.

## NOTES TO CHAPTER FIVE

1 Jones, *The Later Roman Empire*, II p.687.

2 F. Lot, *The End of the Ancient World and the Beginnings of the Middle Ages*, p.22.

3 Ammianus 16.13.

4 *De Caes.* 40.5; 40.16; 40.19-23; 41.23-25; 42.6-8. In general see Jones, *The Later Roman Empire*, II pp.687-711. Victor's remarks in 42.7-8 may indicate autopsy: "His (Nepotianus') stupid nature was so destructive to the people and senators of Rome that everywhere homes, fora, streets and temples were filled with blood and bodies like tombs. Nor was this due to him alone but also to the advancing troops of Magnentius who overthrew their enemy on the twenty-seventh day." But cf. T. Opitz, 'Sallustius und Aurelius Victor', *Neue Jahrbücher für Philologie und Paedagogik*, Abt. 1, Klass. Philolog. 29 (1883), p.222, who thinks this derived from Sall. *Cat.* 51.9.

5 Prudent. *Contra Sym.* 2.640; Oros. 5.2.1; Claud. *De Cons. Stilich.* 3.154; Rutil. Namat. 1.63; 83; 133; Ad. Arist. *Orat. Rom.* 10-13; 34-39; 59-66; 74-75; 90-91; 99-101; 109.

6 Den Boer, p.142. On this point see especially Eutrop. 7.10; 8.8.

7 Zos. 4.32. It should be noted here that Zosimus is impugning Theodosius I and the central government at that time located in Constantinople. For fuller discussions see L.S. Mazzolani, *The Idea of the City in Roman Thought* (Engl. trans. by S. O'Donnell, London, 1970), pp.201ff.; R. MacMullen, *Enemies of the Roman Order* (Cambridge, Mass., 1966), pp.163ff.; 192ff.; E.S. Gruen, *The Image of Rome* (Englewood Cliffs, 1969), pp.165ff. On Roman patriotism among upper-class pagans and Christians see F. Paschoud, *Roma Aeterna,*

*études sur le patriotisme romain dans l'occident à l'époque des grandes invasions* (Inst. Suisse de Rome, 1967); M. Fuhrmann, 'Die Romidee der Spätantike', *HZ* 207 (1968), pp.529-61.

8 *De Caes.* 15.4. Victor seems quite deliberately to have used the term *regnum* to describe Nero's rule. Eutropius (7.14) also states that Nero set fire to Rome *ut spectaculi eius imaginem cerneret, quasi olim Troia capta arserat.*

9 *De Caes.* 17.3; cf. *H.A. Comm.* 17.5-7.

10 *De Caes.* 40.25. Cf. Zos. 2.17.2; M. Durry, *Les cohortes prétoriennes* (Paris, 1938), pp.393-96; A. Chastagnol, *La préfecture urbaine* (Paris, 1960), pp.64-66.

11 *De Caes.* 28.2-6. Autopsy again seems to be implied by Victor's personal comments though the celebration of Rome's 1100th anniversary was probably in the K.G.; see Eutrop. 9.3; *Epit.* 28.3.

12 Zos. 2.7.2; Dufraigne, p.149.

13 *De Caes.* 4.14; 15.4; 28.1.

14 *De Caes.* 1.6.

15 *De Caes.* 9.7.

16 *De Caes.* 10.5. No notice of Titus' Arch is given.

17 *De Caes.* 11.4.

18 *De Caes.* 13.5. Victor fails to mention Trajan's Column and, subsequently, Constantine's Arch. His various omissions lead me to conclude that he had probably not consulted a handbook. Eutropius, too, has many of Victor's observations on buildings at Rome.

19 *De Caes.* 14.2-4; see Dufraigne, pp.107-108.

20 *De Caes.* 16.15.

21 *De Caes.* 41.17.

22 *De Caes.* 20.30; 21.5-6.

23 *Ibid.* The new street was probably the *Via Nova* running parallel to the Appian Way along the front of the *Thermae Antoninianae* or Baths of Caracalla. They were the most magnificent baths in Rome and even today their ruins are remarkable in size and splendour (E. Nash, *A Pictorial Dictionary of Ancient Rome*, II (London, 1962), pp.85, 434-41, figs. 1230-1241; D.R. Dudley, *Urbs Roma* (London, 1967), pp.203-205, plate 72).

24 *De Caes.* 24.5; H. Mattingly and R.A.G. Carson, *CREBM*, VI pp.63-64; S.B. Platner and T. Ashby, *A Topographical Dictionary of Ancient Rome* (Oxford, 1929), p.363.

25 *De Caes.* 27.7.

26 *De Caes.* 28.1; Platner and Ashby, *op.cit.* (n.24), p.258.

27 *De Caes.* 29.1. In fact he constructed the Decian Baths on the Aventine, restored the Colosseum after a fire and possibly built the *Porticus Decii* (Platner and Ashby, *op.cit.* (n.24), pp.6, 421, 526-27).

28 *De Caes.* 35.7; Platner and Ashby, *op.cit.* (n.24), pp.491ff.

29 *De Caes.* 39.45; S. Aurigemma, *Le Terme di Diocleziano ed il Museo Nazionale Romano* (Rome, 1955); G. Rodenwalt, *CAH*, XII pp.568-69; Ensslin, *RE* VII A 2475 s.v. Valerius.

30 *De Caes.* 40.26-27. Dudley, *op.cit.* (n.23), pp.116-17, identifies the *urbis fanum* with the Temple of Romulus. The Flavian Basilica was actually called the *Basilica Constantina* though its original name had been the *Basilica Nova*. Diocletian had planned it and Maxentius had continued its construction from 307. Constantine radically altered its design by turning its axis 90 degrees and placing its main entrance on the forum. He also added a Baptistry, the *Fons Constantini* (Platner and Ashby, *op.cit.* (n.24), pp.76-78).

31 I.e. 7.21, Titus built an amphitheatre at Rome; 7.24, Domitian constructed the *Capitolium*, the *Forum Transistorium*, the *Odeum*, the *Porticus*, the *Iseum et Serapeum* and a stadium; 8.5, Trajan built a forum and a column 144 feet high; 8.20, Caracalla erected outstanding baths; 8.23, Alexander *Romae quoque favorabilis fuit*; 9.3, Philip celebrated Rome's 1000th anniversary in magnificent fashion; 9.4, Decius built baths at Rome; 9.10, statue of Claudius set up on Capitol, a *clypeus aureus* was dedicated to him in the senate house; 9.15, Aurelian built walls and a Temple of the Sun at Rome.

32 Eutrop. 7.7; 7.9; 7.10; 8.2; 8.7; 9.8. Den Boer, p.148, notes that Eutropius considered civil wars totally reprehensible and was the first fourth-century writer to blame Constantius II for causing such a war.

33 E.g. *De Caes.* 1.2; 1.7; 2.3; 4.2; 5.2; 9.10; 10.4; 13.3-4; 15.5; 16.4; 16.13; 20.14-19; 33.3; 34.3ff.; 37.3; 38.3; 39.33ff.; 41.13; 41.18; 42.11; 42.17; 42.21.

34 *De Caes.* 41.12.

35 *De Caes.* 40.28.

36 *De Caes.* 41.17. On this and associated matters see A. Alföldi, *The Conversion of Constantine and Pagan Rome* (trans., Oxford, 1948), pp.110-123.

37 *De Caes.* 40.19. For a list of provinces mentioned by Victor see appendix IV.

38 Eutrop. 10.8.

39 *Epit.* 41.17; 44.4; 49.20.

40 Vienna, Paris, Berlin and London have suffered similar political depreciations in recent times.

41 Mazzolani, *op.cit.* (n.7), p.197.

42 Alföldi, pp.53-54; Ammianus 30.10.1.

43 *De Caes.* 20.6; 40.19.

44 Nixon, p.401. See appendix IV.

45 *De Caes.* 12.1.

46 *Epit.* 11.15-12.1. See Nixon, pp.149ff.

47 J. Schlumberger, *Die "Epitome de Caesaribus": Untersuchungen zur heidnischen Geschichtsschreibung des 4. Jahrhunderts n. Chr.* (Munich, 1974), pp.63-77; T.D. Barnes, 'The Epitome de Caesaribus and its Sources', *CP* 71 (1976), pp.260-62.

48 Nixon, p.154.

49 Nixon, p.156. Eutropius' information on Nerva's background is slender but more accurate, *nobilitatis mediae* (8.1); see Syme, *Tacitus*, pp.1ff. The error regarding Nerva's birthplace is another indication that Victor did not research his material very carefully.

50 *De Caes.* 13.1; 13.11.

51 *De Caes.* 14.2.

52 *De Caes.* 20.6.

53 *De Caes.* 24.1.

54 *De Caes.* 28.1. Eutropius also notes the celebration of Rome's 1000th anniversary (9.3) as does the Epitomator (*Epit.* 28.3). It was presumably in the K.G.

55 *De Caes.* 29.1ff.; cf. Eutrop. 9.4; *Epit.* 29.1; Syme, *Emperors and Biography*, p.222.

56 *De Caes.* 37.4; cf. Eutrop. 9.17; *Epit.* 37.1; *H.A. Prob.* 18.8; Hier. *Chron.* AD 280; T.D. Barnes, 'Three Notes on the vita Probi', *CQ* 20,1 (1970), pp.201-203.

57 Syme, *Emperors and Biography*, pp.224-25. Even Dufraigne, p.176, admits that the notice in all the ancient authors derives from a common source.

58 *De Caes.* 32.2; 32.4.

59 *De Caes.* 37.5-7.

60 *De Caes.* 39.12; cf. Eutrop. 9.18; *Epit.* 38.1; P. Meloni, *Il regno di Caro, Numeriano e Carino* (Cagliari, 1948), p.13; T.B. Jones, 'A note on Marcus Aurelius Carus', *CPh.* 37 (1942), pp.193-94.

61 *H.A. Car.* 4.1ff.

62 *De Caes.* 39.16.

63 *De Caes.* 39.26-28. For a discussion of this passage and its grudging praise see den Boer, p.90. Victor also notes the Illyrian birthplace of Severus and Maximinus (40.1), the lack of education of Galerius and Constantius (40.12).

64 Syme, *Emperors and Biography*, pp.231ff.; for Victor see appendix IV.

65 *De Caes.* 41.3.

66 *De Caes.* 40.17.

67 *De Caes.* 41.26; Eutropius (10.10) calls him *omnium liberalium artium expertem*; the Epitomator (41.25) describes him as *prope ad stultitiam simplicissimus*.

68 *De Caes.* 39.17. Victor had earlier used the term in one of his personal observations when he writes that there appears to be some sort of natural law which often, as if on purpose, produces bad men from good parents and *agrestes ex doctioribus* (3.5).

69 *De Caes.* 33.29, *dum urbes erunt*. This attitude is emphasized by A.N. Sherwin-White, *Racial Prejudice in Imperial Rome* (Cambridge, 1967), pp.3ff. etc. It is interesting to compare the remarks of Herodian and Dio concerning the Pannonians. The former (2.9.11) tells us that the Pannonians were tall men of fine physique, natural and ferocious fighters but dull and slow-witted. Dio (49.36.2) says that they led the most miserable existence of all people, but they were the bravest of any men known, extremely bold and bloodthirsty for they possessed nothing conducive to a civilized life. Ammianus notes the Pannonians' loyalty to Valentinian and Valens, their fellow-countrymen (26.1.6; 26.5.3), and has Procopius announce that a degenerate Pannonian had shaken and trampled upon the world to gain the throne (26.7.16). He further denounces the Pannonians Maximinus and Leo as cruel and vicious and

the latter as a Pannonian grave-robber (28.1.10-12).

70 *De Caes.* 40.12.

71 *H.A. Car.* 4.6-5.3.

72 *H.A. Car.* 17.1.

73 Alföldi, pp.48ff., 98ff.

74 *De Caes.* 3.12.

75 *De Caes.* 5.5.

76 *De Caes.* 11.5; cf. Suet. *Domit.* 22.1.

77 *De Caes.* 14.2.

78 *De Caes.* 35.7.

79 See Juv. *Sat.* 3.61ff.; 6.187-93; 6.295ff.; Sherwin-White, *op.cit.* (n.69), pp.67-86.

80 *De Caes.* 4.2.

81 *De Caes.* 39.17.

82 *De Caes.* 42.14-17.

83 See appendix IV.

84 Den Boer, p.166; Ammianus 15.12.1-6.

85 *H.A. Tyr. trig.* 3.7; *Firm.* 7.1. These comments may derive from Victor's statement (41.17) *ne quid apud Gallos natura praecipites novaretur.*

86 On earlier Roman attitudes to and prejudices against the Gauls see Sherwin-White, *op.cit.* (n.69), pp.21ff., 53ff.

87 *De Caes.* 25.1; 33.13.

88 *De Caes.* 24.10-11.

89 It is mentioned four times but Nicomedia, Mediolanum and Verona have three mentions each. Only Carthage, however, is termed *terrarum decus.* In general see appendix IV. For widely differing sentiments on Rome and the empire see E.M. Sanford, 'Contrasting Views of the Roman Empire', *AJP* 58 (1937), pp.437-56; R. MacMullen, *op.cit.* (n.7).

## NOTES TO CHAPTER SIX

1 C.G. Starr, 'Aurelius Victor: Historian of Empire', pp.581ff.; den Boer, p.26; Dufraigne, p.xviii; Nixon, pp.408ff.; R.J. Penella, 'A Lowly Born Historian of the Late Roman Empire: Some Observations on Aurelius Victor and his De Caesaribus', *Thought* 55 (1980), p.124.

2 Cic. *Verr. II* 4.44.98.

3 Quint. *Inst. Orat.* 3.8.9.

4 O.E. Nybakken, 'Humanitas Romana', *TAPA* 70 (1939), p.406. Nybakken notes Gellius' definition of 'humanitas': *eruditionem institutionemque in bonas artes* (13.17).

5 *Epist.* 369.9.

6 A. Momigliano, *The Conflict between Pagan and Christian Historiography in the Fourth Century* (Oxford, 1963), pp.85-86.

7 Dufraigne, p.li, notes several of the differences between Victor and Eutropius.

8 Eutropius' work is seventy-seven pages long in the Teubner text, that of Festus twenty-two, or more precisely 493 lines. A. Cameron, *CR* 19 (1969), p.305, criticizes Momigliano for "mischievously suggesting that Valens found Eutropius too long" and believes that Festus was initially commissioned to provide concise information on Rome's relations with Persia/Parthia in light of Valens' projected war with Persia. Den Boer sensibly regards the two views as "not necessarily exclusive" (p.173).

9 Syme, *Ammianus*, p.105.

10 Den Boer, p.44.

11 Den Boer, p.100. Professor Blockley has pointed out to me that modern bureaucrats would hardly be regarded as sophisticated by university professors of the humanities but may well possess considerable expertise in their particular fields of e.g. law and accounting.

12 R.C. Blockley, 'The Panegyric of Claudius Mamertinus', *AJP* 93 (1972), p.444; Julian *In Galilaeos* 229D-E; Ammianus 29.2.18; Themistius *Or.* 11.143C-146C; Syme, *Ammianus and the Historia Augusta*, p.126.

13 *De Caes.* 1.5.

14 Cf. *De Caes.* 39.45 where Diocletian is warmly praised for his great concern for *veterrimae religiones*.

15 *De Caes.* 8.7-8. For a full translation of this passage see chapter three, p.28.

16 *De Caes.* 9.1.

17 *De Caes.* 9.11-12.

18 *De Caes.* 10.1. Dufraigne, p.93, considers it a light adversative introduced by Sallust and common in imperial prose. In the *De Caesaribus*, however, Victor uses the word only twice, here and in 35.1, both times as a strong adversative, instead of the weaker *autem* (3.10; 29.5; 42.19) or the strong *tamen* used thirty-four times.

19 *De Caes.* 14.2-4.

20 *Graecorum more seu Pompilii Numae caerimonias leges gymnasia doctoresque* (Dufraigne, p.107).

21 For Julian's notion of *paideia* see P. Athanassiadi-Fowden, *Julian and Hellenism: An Intellectual Biography* (Oxford, 1981), pp.121ff.

22 Cf. Plato *Rep.* 5.473d; Cic. *Ad Quint. frat.* 1.1.29; *H.A. Aur.* 27.6-7; Prud. *Sym.* 1.30, cited by Dufraigne, p.110.

23 *De Caes.* 16.1; 16.9; 16.10.

24 *De Caes.* 19.3.

25 Den Boer, p.45.

26 See Dufraigne, p.122.

27 *De Caes.* 20.2.

28 *De Caes.* 20.22.

29 Dio 76.16.1 - 76.17.2; Eutrop. 8.19; *Epit.* 20.8; *H.A. Sev.* 18.5; *Get.* 2.2; Philostratus *VS* 2.2; *RE*$^2$ II 1943-48 s.v. Severus 13; M. Hammond, *Mem. Am. Acad. Rom.* 24 (1956), pp.139ff.

30 Herod. 9.4; Dio 75.7.3; *H.A. Sev.* 18.6. Cf. chapter two of the present work and Dufraigne, p.129.

31 *De Caes.* 24.10. The whole of this significant passage is translated in chapter four, p.45.

32 *De Caes.* 25.1. Cf. *H.A. Alex.* 63.2 where the writer notes Maximinus' *asperitas atque rusticitas.*

33 Cf. Sall. *Cat.* 8.1; Ps. Sall. 1 *ad Caes.* 1.1.

34 *H.A. Gall.* 11.6-9.

35 *De Caes.* 39.26-28.

36 Juv. *Sat.* 13.21; Ammianus 26.2.8; Tac. *Ann.* 4.4; Dufraigne, p.185.

37 *De Caes.* 40.13-15. There seems to be some disagreement on Constantine's intellectual achievements: cf. Eutrop. 10.4, *civilibus artibus et liberalibus studiis deditus*, and *Anon. Val.* 2.2, *litteris minus instructus* .... See Dufraigne, p.193, for additional citations. The remarks about Cyrus are probably a rhetorical commonplace ultimately derived from Xenophon's *Cyropaedia* and perhaps learned by Victor at school. For the most recent discussion see T.D. Barnes, *Constantine and Eusebius* (Oxford, 1981), pp.47-48.

38 *De Caes.* 41.26.

39 Cf. Eutrop. 10.10, which describes Vetranio as *omnium liberalium artium expertem*, and *Epit.* 41.25, *prope ad stultitiam simplicissimus.* There can be little doubt that Victor had talked to people who had been personally acquainted with Vetranio and would be well able to assess his educational level.

40 *De Caes.* 42.1. Cf. Eunapius frg. 46 Müller, *FHG* IV, = frg. 44,1 and 2 Blockley.

41 Ammianus 21.8.1; Julian *Or.* 1.25.31; 3.22.76-77; 1.26.33a; Zos. 2.44.3-4; Sozom. *H.E.* 4.4.2; Philostorg. *H.E.* 3.22; Socrat. 2.28; Zon. 13.7; Petr. Patr. frg. 16 in *FHG* IV 190.

42 N. Baynes, *Camb. Med. Hist.*, I p.60; E. Stein, *Histoire du Bas Empire* (rev. J.-R. Palanque, Paris, 1959), p.139; A. Piganiol, *L'Empire Chrétien* (Paris, 1947), pp.86ff.; Ensslin, *RE* VIII A (1958) 1838 s.v. Vetranio I.

43 *De Caes.* 42.23. Cf. Eutrop. 10.15; *Epit.* 42.18-19; Ammianus 21.16.1ff.

44 Quint. *Inst. Orat.* 2.16.8; Julian *Or.* 1.26.33a-b; Dufraigne, p.201.

45 Cic. *De Or.* 3.55. Cf. Quint. *Inst. Orat.* 12.1.11-12; Nybakken, *op.cit.* (n.4), pp.406ff.

46 Nixon, p.411; *De Caes.* 3.5, *quasi naturae lege, quae crebro tamquam ex industria malos e bonis, agrestes ex doctioribus et ceteros huiuscemodi seu contra gignit.*

47 Nixon, *loc.cit.*

48 Marrou, *A History of Education in Antiquity*, pp.412-416.

49 *Cod. Theod.* 14.1.1.

50 *Cod. Theod.* 13.3.1.2; 3.1.3; Marrou, *op.cit.* (n.48), pp.403ff.

51 *Cod. Theod.* 13.3.11; S. Dill, *Roman Society in the Last Century of the Western Empire* (2nd ed., London, 1899), p.402.

52 Marrou, *op.cit.* (n.48), pp.415ff.

53 *Ibid.* pp.374-75; Jones, *The Later Roman Empire*, II p.1003. Cf.

Eumenius' *Panegyric* of 298.

54 Cic. *De Orat.* 1.6; 2.30; Tac. *Dial. de Orat.* 30.

55 M. Cary and H.H. Scullard, *A History of Rome* (3rd ed., London, 1975), p.554; cf. F.W. Walbank, *The Awful Revolution* (Liverpool, 1969), pp.101ff.

56 Jones, *loc.cit.* (n.53).

57 Momigliano, *loc.cit.* (n.6); den Boer, p.100.

58 E.A. Thompson, *The Historical Work of Ammianus Marcellinus* (Cambridge, 1947), p.76.

59 *De Caes.* 8.8; 9.12; 42.24; den Boer, p.26, notes that Victor is spiritually akin to Ammianus (14.6.1; 21.10.8; 30.4.2).

60 Cf. Starr, 'Aurelius Victor: Historian of Empire', pp.581ff.; Dufraigne, p.xviii.

## NOTES TO CHAPTER SEVEN

1 Dufraigne, p.xvii.

2 Nixon, p.399.

3 E.g. the corruption of the army and bureaucracy, the influence of foreigners, the debility of the senate.

4 *De Caes.* 11.13; 5.9. Cf. Sallust, *Cat.* 53.2. For comment see R. Syme, *Sallust* (Cambridge, 1964), p.244.

5 The questions, "Must the historian also be a thinker?", "Are his ideas original, or at least coherent?" have been asked about Sallust (Syme, *Sallust*, p.240) and could equally well be asked of Livy, Tacitus or Ammianus Marcellinus. I cannot agree with Nixon (p.400) that Victor's superficiality was mainly the product of his times because he wrote at no watershed of history. To my mind civil war was imminent and Victor knew it (*De Caes.* 42.18-19). Moreover his book offers little evidence of original thought and it appears unlikely that he could have produced a first-rate history at any epoch. As Themistocles remarked, the Seriphian would not have been famous even if he had been an Athenian.

6 *De Caes.* 4.14; 9.4; 26.4; 28.3ff.; 32.3-4; 34.3; 38.4; 39.45.

7 *De Caes.* 28.9.

8 *De Caes.* 13.7.

9 *De Caes.* 35.14.

10 *De Caes.* 39.45; cf. 20.20; 42.4.

11 Eutrop. 8.8.

12 *De Caes.* 3.20: *vacuos a fortuna cassosque esse.* This is a topos, cf. Ammianus 23.5; Tac. *Hist.* 2.33; Dufraigne, p.76.

13 *De Caes.* 20.12.

14 *De Caes.* 24.11. For what immediately follows see Blockley, *Ammianus Marcellinus*, pp.170-72.

15 *De Caes.* 12.4; 40.14.

16 *De Caes.* 3.14; cf. Dio 59.29.2.

17 Sall. *Cat.* 8.1ff.; see also 20.7; *Jug.* 67.2; Ps. Sall. 1 *ad Caes.* 1.1; 2 *ad Caes.* 1.1; Juv. *Sat.* 10.363ff.; D.C. Earl, *The Political Thought of Sallust* (Cambridge, 1961), pp.7-12.

18 *De Caes.* 31.3.

19 *Epit.* 31.2; Zos. 1.29.1.

20 Cf. Eutrop. 9.6.

21 *De Caes.* 33.3-11.

22 *Quasi ventis undique saevientibus parvis maxima ima summis orbe toto miscebantur.* Cf. Sall. *Cat.* 10.1; *H.A. Gall.* 5.6.

23 *De Caes.* 41.20-21.

24 Polyb. *Hist.* 2.38.5; 10.5.8; 18.2.5; 29.21.

25 Hor. *Od.* 3.29.49-52.

26 Juv. *Sat.* 10.365.

27 Plin. *N.H.* 2.22.

28 Sall. *Jug.* 1.1. See G.M. Paul, *A Historical Commentary on Sallust's Bellum Jugurthinum* (Liverpool, 1984), pp.9f., 12.

29 Sall. *Cat.* 8.1.

30 *Ibid.* 10.1ff.

31 *De Caes.* 42.23.

32 Eutropius makes very little use of the term *Fortuna*, and then only to indicate good luck or advantage.

33 E. Zeller, *Stoics, Epicureans and Sceptics* (Eng. trans. by O. Reichel, New York, 1962), p.51.

34 For an interpretation of the Stoic views of Fate and Necessity see J. Rist, *Stoic Philosophy* (Cambridge, 1969), pp.112-132.

35 *De Caes.* 10.4.

36 Suet. *Tit.* 9.2.

37 Ps. Sall. 1 *ad Caes.* 1.1; Dio 68.3.2.

38 *De Caes.* 3.5.

39 Dufraigne, p.72.

40 *De Caes.* 3.6.

41 *De Caes.* 17.1; cf. *H.A. Comm.* 1.7-9; 2.6-9. See appendix I, pp.101, 102.

42 *De Caes.* 38.3-5. For a similar story in Ammianus regarding Julian ignoring omens see Blockley, *Ammianus Marcellinus*, pp.101, 174, and cf. Eutrop. 10.16.

43 Cf. Eutrop. 9.18; Fest. *Brev.* 24; *Epit.* 38.2.

44 T.D. Barnes, 'Three Notes on the *Vita Probi*', *CQ* 64 (1970), pp.198-203. On Carus' death see H.W. Bird, 'Diocletian and the Deaths of Carus, Numerian and Carinus', *Latomus* 35 (1976), pp.123ff.

45 *H.A. Car.* 9.1-3: "Many state that there is a certain decree of Fate that no Roman emperor may advance beyond Ctesiphon and that Carus was struck by lightning because he desired to pass beyond those boundaries which Fate has established. But let timidity keep its devices for itself and let it be stamped upon by courage. Clearly it is allowed and shall be allowed, as our most revered Caesar Maximian has shown, to conquer the Persians and to advance beyond them ...." For the oracle see J.

Straub, *Studien zur Historia Augusta* (Diss. Bern, 1952), pp.123-32.

46 Cic. *De Nat.* 3.6.14: *effugere enim nemo id potest quod futurum est. saepe enim ne utile quidem est scire id quod futurum sit.*

47 *De Caes.* 39.48: *namque imminentium scrutator, ubi fato intestinas clades et quasi fragorem quendam impendere comperit status Romani ....*

48 Lact. *De Mort. Persec.* 10.1: *ut erat pro timore scrutator rerum futurarum.* Zosimus (2.10.5) gives an account similar to that of Victor.

49 *De Caes. loc.cit.*; Eutrop. 9.28.

50 *De Caes.* 35.12-14. The second part of this comment has been noted earlier with reference to the individual's role in events.

51 B. Croce, *History, its Theory and Practice* (Eng. trans. by D. Ainslie, New York, 1960), pp.193-94. In general see A. Momigliano, 'Time in Ancient Historiography', in *Essays in Ancient and Modern Historiography* (Oxford, 1977), pp.189-90, 201.

52 Polyb. *Hist.* 6.3.1ff.; F.W. Walbank, *A Historical Commentary on Polybius*, I (Oxford, 1957), pp.643ff.; G. Cairns, *Philosophies of History* (London, 1963), pp.196-230. According to Momigliano, *op.cit.* (n.51), pp.186-204, the Greeks, followed by the Romans, chose a form of historical writing which was unlikely to lend itself to a cyclical view of history. He concludes that the Greek concept of cyclicality is generally misunderstood.

53 Sall. *Cat.* 6.1ff.; cf. *Jug.* 2.

54 *Ann.* 3.55.4: "Possibly there is in all things a kind of cycle, and there may be moral revolutions just as there are changes of seasons." Cf. Cic. *De Rep.* 6.22.24; *De Nat.* 2.51; Virg. *Buc.* 4.

55 See chapter three.

56 *De Caes.* 5.14. Dufraigne correctly notes that the Romans always connected the notions of monarchy and servitude (p.84); cf. Cic. *De Rep.* 1.47; Tac. *Hist.* 1.16.9; Philo *Leg. ad Gai.* 118.

57 See chapter four.

58 E.g. *De Caes.* 28.6-7; 33.13; 33.23ff.; 33.29ff.; 34.6ff.

59 Jones, *The Later Roman Empire*, I pp.144-45, 286, 403, 479-80, 496, 499, 500, 517, 521, II pp.600, 859, 897; H.F. Jolowicz and B. Nicholas, *Historical Introduction to the Study of Roman Law* (3rd ed., Cambridge, 1972), pp.430ff., 435, 446f.

60 Erwin Schrödinger, *What is Life? and Mind and Matter* (Cambridge, 1967), p.123. The subject was broached by Schrödinger in the Tarner Lectures at Trinity College, Cambridge in 1956.

61 *De Caes.* 33.23-24. The idea may derive from Sallust (*Cat.* 7.3; 10.4) but cf. Tac. *Hist.* 1.12.4; 1.15.

62 *De Caes.* 33.26.

63 Tac. *Ann.* 3.65; cf. *Agr.* 1.1.

64 Livy 1.1; Diod. Sic. 1.2.

65 *Epit.* 3.6.

66 *De Caes.* 33.30; cf. Cic. *De Rep.* 6.13; *De Nat.* 2.62. Eunapius treats Julian as almost divine, θεῖος, because of his virtues (frgs. 1 *ad fin.*, 18.6, 28.1-5 Blockley (= Müller *FHG* IV frgs. 1, 12, 23, 24). Both Ammianus (21.10.2; 22.9.14) and Mamertinus, in his panegyric of Julian (2.3),

describe Julian as a *sidus salutare*.

67 Cf. *De Caes.* 33.4ff.; Eutrop. 9.7.11; *Epit.* 33.1-3.

68 For Eutropius see den Boer, pp.114-72; Dufraigne, pp.l-lii; for the Epitomator see J. Schlumberger, *Die "Epitome de Caesaribus": Untersuchungen zur heidnischen Geschichtsschreibung des 4. Jahrhunderts n. Chr.* (Munich, 1947), pp.63-77.

69 L.S. Mazzolani, *Empire without End* (Eng. trans., New York, 1976), p.6.

70 Apart from the emperors one should note the role of Anatolius, praetorian prefect of Illyricum in 359, in organizing the *cursus publicus* in his prefecture (*De Caes.* 13.6). It is the *mores* of the *praesidentes* which alter events. Cf. Claudian *IV Cos. Hon.* 299-300 where Claudian remarks that the world is shaped after the example of its ruler.

71 *De Anima Mantissa*, p.182, 18 (Bruns). For Ammianus' views see Blockley, *Ammianus Marcellinus*, pp.168-76; W. Ensslin, *Zur Geschichtsschreibung und Weltanschauung des Ammianus Marcellinus* (Leipzig, 1926); C.P.T. Naudé, *Ammianus Marcellinus in die lig van die antiëke geskiedskrywing* (Leiden, 1956); 'Fortuna in Ammianus Marcellinus', *Ant. Class.* 7 (1964), pp.70-88; and in general F. Cumont, *Astrology and Religion amongst the Greeks and Romans* (New York, 1960).

72 Dufraigne, p.xxiii. For several other examples see Blockley, *Ammianus Marcellinus*, pp.160-61.

## NOTES TO CHAPTER EIGHT

1 Den Boer, p.170. On the usefulness and popularity of Eutropius, Festus and the *breviaria* in the fourth century and after see J. Eadie, *The Breviarium of Festus* (London, 1967), pp.19-20. A. Momigliano, however, notes that Victor's booklet was less jejune than those of Eutropius or Festus (*Essays in Ancient and Modern Historiography* (Oxford, 1977), p.132).

2 *De Caes.* 5.9; 8.7; 11.12-13; 20.6; 28.8; 39.48; 40.14; 41.10; 42.5; 42.22; 42.25. The terms *hac tempestate* and *his tempestatibus* might be included here, see 9.12; 33.13; 39.33.

3 The Epitomator also refrains from personal intrusions and judgements (E. Wölfflin, 'Aurelius Victor', *Rheinisches Museum* 29 (1874), p.285).

4 See in particular *De Caes.* 5.1ff.

5 See Nixon, p.405; Dufraigne, p.li. By way of contrast the Epitomator is described as a mechanical contaminator by Wölfflin, *op.cit.* (n.3), p.302.

6 Nixon, p.405; Dufraigne, p.lx. As examples see *De Caes.* 5.14; 8.8; 12.3; 20.31; 24.11; 33.13; 33.22ff.; 35.12; 37.6.

7 V.S. Sokolov, 'Sekst Aurelij Viktor, istoriograph IV v.n.e.', *Vestnik Drevnej Istorii* 86 (1963), p.216.

8 M. Schanz, *Geschichte der römischen Literatur bis zum Gesetzgebungswerk des Kaisers Justinian IV* (2nd ed., Munich, 1914), p.73.

9 See chapter seven and especially n.17. R. Syme (*Sallust* (Cambridge U.P., Berkeley & Los Angeles, 1964), p.296) states that Sallust and Tacitus each elected a theme of decline and fall. The same could be said of Victor whose pessimism is emphasized by den Boer, p.223.

10 Syme, *Sallust*, pp.274ff. For his influence on Tacitus see Syme, *Tacitus* (Oxford, 1958), pp.728-32; G.B.A. Fletcher, 'Some Certain or Possible Examples of Literary Reminiscences in Tacitus', *CR* 59 (1945), pp.45ff.

11 Marrou, *A History of Education in Antiquity*, p.374.

12 Wölfflin, *op.cit.* (n.3), pp.286ff.; T. Opitz, 'Sallustius und Aurelius Victor', *Neue Jahrbücher für Phil. und Paed.* 127 (1883), pp.217-222. I have added a few examples to their lists.

13 *De Caes.* 3.12; 18.2; 33.26; 38.7 (dative); 5.14; 6.2; 10.4; 26.1; 28.11; 35.2; 39.7; 40.15; 42.21 (ablative); *ex quis*: 28.3; *a quis*: 39.34; 41.16; 42.16. Tacitus preferred *quibus* (Syme, *Tacitus*, p.739).

14 Opitz, *op.cit.* (n.12), p.218 mistakenly counted only eight. *Queo* and *nequeo* are used in *De Caes.* 4.5; 8.8; 10.3; 12.3; 13.7; 16.8; 20.1; 24.10; 33.19; 35.13; 40.2; 41.2.

15 For Sallust's usage of these words see Syme, *Sallust*, pp.305-312.

16 It should naturally be observed that the *De Caesaribus* is much shorter than the extant works of Sallust.

17 The adjectives of both of these words were used twice by Victor.

18 Syme, *Sallust*, p.307.

19 Wölfflin, *op.cit.* (n.3), p.303.

20 Generations of students have recalled such striking statements as *omnium consensu capax imperii nisi imperasset* (*Hist.* 1.49), *ubi solitudinem faciunt, pacem appellant* (*Agr.* 30.7) and *ego facilius crediderim naturam margaritis deesse quam nobis avaritiam* (*Agr.* 12.7).

21 *Ni*: 5.5; 8.7; 19.3; 20.16; 33.26; 33.32; 39.36; 41.20; *nisi*: 1.3; 5.16; 9.2; 12.2; 16.8; 20.4; 20.14.

22 Syme, *Tacitus*, p.739.

23 Wölfflin, *op.cit.* (n.3), p.308 argues unconvincingly that Victor used Tacitus as a source, hence the Tacitean echoes: see chapter two for different conclusions.

24 E.g. *De Caes.* 19.4: *missique, qui fugientem insequerentur.*

25 *De Caes.* 26.5; 28.10; 29.3.

26 *De Caes.* 28.1; 41.12.

27 *De Caes.* 16.4; cf. 5.2; 17.7; 18.2; 20.14; 27.8; 32.3; 33.15; 33.28; 35.11; 37.6; 40.23.

28 *De Caes.* 3.16; 20.6; 20.31; 21.2; 33.13.

29 *De Caes.* 5.10; 9.12; 20.6; 33.31; noted by Nixon, p.405.

30 *Ibid.*

31 *De Caes.* 5.14; Nixon, *loc.cit.*

32 A word "shunned altogether" by Tacitus (Syme, *Tacitus*, p.734).

33 A Sallustian usage.

34 A further device of Sallust.

35 *De Caes.* 2.2; 3.5; 9.8; 10.4; 20.10; 20.25; 39.45; 42.18; but cf. 33.30; 42.7.

36 For Sallust see Syme, *Sallust*, p.309.

37 *De Caes.* 11.12; 37.5.

38 *De Caes.* 42.4.

39 E.g. *modus modestiaque, pudor pudicitiaeque, ius iudiciumque, fides fiducia.*

40 *De Caes.* 9.3; 9.12; 13.9; 24.9; 33.11; 39.48; 40.13.

41 E.g. *De Caes.* 11.5-6 (cf. Suet. *Domit.* 3.1; 22); *De Caes.* 20.6 (cf. Sen. *N.Q.* 18.4; *Epit.* 1.28); *De Caes.* 21.3 (cf. Cic. *Pro Quinct.* 30.94).

42 *De Caes.* 33.3.

43 *De Caes.* 21.3.

44 *De Caes.* 33.11.

45 Eutrop. 8.16; cf. *Epit.* 18.1ff.

46 *De Caes.* 18.2.

47 Eutrop. 8.17; *Epit.* 19.1.

48 *De Caes.* 19.2.

49 *De Caes.* 32.5 (cf. Eutrop. 9.7; *Epit.* 32.5); *De Caes.* 35.8 (cf. Eutrop. 9.15; *Epit.* 35.8); *De Caes.* 36.1-2 (cf. Eutrop. 9.16; *Epit.* 36.1); *De Caes.* 39.13 (cf. Eutrop. 9.20).

50 Syme, *Sallust*, pp.288-301; Starr, 'Aurelius Victor, Historian of Empire', p.575.

51 *Ibid.*, p.576.

52 Eutrop. 10.18. Cf. *H.A. Car.* 21.2-3.

## NOTES TO APPENDIX I

1 Marrou, *A History of Education in Antiquity*, p.317.

2 Blockley, *Ammianus Marcellinus*, p.160.

3 *De Caes.* 33.26.

4 For such lists see Marrou, *op.cit.* (n.1), p.383.

5 Cic *Or.* 120. Cf. Suet. *Aug.* 89.2. For further discussion see Blockley, *Ammianus Marcellinus*, pp.161ff.

6 Claud. *IV Cos. Hon.* 394-418.

7 Blockley, *Ammianus Marcellinus*, p.163.

8 Quoted by Blockley, *ibid.*, pp.162-63, with further examples.

9 Noted by P.L. Schmidt, 'S. Aurelius Victor', *RE* Suppl. Band XV (1978), 1667.

10 Blockley, *Ammianus Marcellinus*, p.167.

## NOTES TO APPENDIX V

1 *De Caes.* 1.7.

2 Tac. *Ann.* 1.10.5.

3 *De Caes.* 2.1.

4 *De Caes.* 3.10.

5 *De Caes.* 4.5; 4.12-15.

6 *De Caes.* 5.8-9.

7 *De Caes.* 5.5-7; 5.11.

8 *De Caes.* 5.16. Cf. Suet. *Ner.* 48; Dio 63.27, who inform us that Nero had four or three companions with him at his death.

9 *De Caes.* 11.5-7.

10 *De Caes.* 13.13.

11 *De Caes.* 16.2.

12 *De Caes.* 20.23.

13 *De Caes.* 21.3. The story also appears in *Epit.* 21.5; Eutrop. 8.20; *H.A. Carac.* 10.1-2; *Sev.* 21.7; Hieron. *Chron.* 213 (Helm$^2$); Oros. 7.18.2. For modern opinions see J. Babelon, *Impératrices Syriennes* (Paris, 1957), p.65; R.J. Penella, 'Caracalla and his Mother in the *Historia Augusta*', *Historia* 29 (1980), pp.382-84. Penella suggests that the negative tradition on Julia probably owed its origin to Plautian's vilification of her (Dio 75.15.6) but points out that Victor gives more emphasis to Julia's complicity than the *H.A.* which is more concerned with denigrating Caracalla.

14 *De Caes.* 23.2.

15 *De Caes.* 33.3.

16 *De Caes.* 33.6. Cf. *Epit.* 33.1; *H.A. Tyr. Trig.* 3.4; *Gall.* 21.3.

17 *De Caes.* 33.14.

18 *De Caes.* 28.6-7. Cf. *H.A. Alex.* 24.4, which is surely a relocation of Victor's factual observation and accompanying comment.

19 Suet. *Domit.* 7.

20 *Cod. Just.* 4. xlii. 1.

21 Jones, *The Later Roman Empire*, II p.852.

22 Den Boer, pp.163-64.

23 Eutrop. 7.12.

24 Eutrop. 8.15.

25 Eutrop. 8.20.

26 Eutrop. 8.22.

27 Eutrop. 9.8.

28 Suetonius has been described, somewhat unfairly, as a prurient scandal-monger by J. Wight Duff (*A Literary History of Rome in the Silver Age* (2nd ed., London, 1960), p.508) and accused of immorality by M. Schanz (*Geschichte der römischen Litteratur* III (3rd ed., Munich, 1959), p.51 §530) and H. Peter (*Geschichtliche Litteratur über die römische Kaiserzeit* II (Leipzig, 1897), pp.72, 332-33) for including so many scabrous details of the emperors' private lives. More recently, however, he has been judged less harshly by H. Ailloud (*Suétone: Vies des Douze Césars* (3rd ed., Paris, 1961), p.xxiii). Tacitus' *Annals* include numerous passages unflattering to various women (e.g. 1.14.1; 1.53; 5.1.5; 6.25; 11.1-4; 11.26ff.; 12.1ff.; 12.41.7ff.; 12.59; 12.67; 13.1; 13.5; 14.1ff.) but his respect for his mother-in-law and father-in-law's mother is very evident in the *Agricola* (4.2-3; 6.6; 45.5).

29 Ammianus 21.16.16.

30 Eutrop. 10.15: *uxoribus deditior*; Mamertinus *Pan. Jul.* 19.3-5.

31 *De Caes.* 4.5.

32 Cf. Alföldi, p.98, and Starr, 'Aurelius Victor: Historian of Empire', p.582. The former maintains that Victor may have been writing of the past but was striking at the present; the latter views the *De Caesaribus* as essentially an exhortation to Rome's rulers to follow the path of learning. Both appear to be correct, but Starr does not go far enough. Victor's implicit advice, which is aimed primarily at Constantius, extends over a wide spectrum.

33 Ammianus *loc.cit.* (n.29). Cf. Hieron. *Ep.* 22.16; Mamertinus *loc.cit.* (n.30).

34 Ammianus 18.4.5. Glover observes that eunuchs were particularly abhorrent to Ammianus (*Life and Letters in the Fourth Century*, p.44).

35 *Epit.* 42.19.

36 *H.A. Alex.* 23.6ff.; 34.3; 45.4-5; *Gord.* 24.2ff. Cf. T. Zawadski, 'Encore sur les buts et la date de composition de l'Histoire Auguste', *Studi clasice* 5 (1963), pp.249ff.; A.D.E. Cameron, 'Eunuchs in the Historia Augusta', *Latomus* 24 (1965), pp.155ff.

37 See A.D.E. Cameron, *Claudian: Poetry and Propaganda at the Court of Honorius* (Oxford, 1970), pp.124-55. Cameron describes Claudian's *In Eutropium* as "the cruellest invective in all ancient literature" (p.126) and adds that "Claudian simply exploits to the full (and beyond) the universal dislike and contempt in which eunuchs were held – an attitude even stronger in the West, where eunuchs were less common and less influential" (p.133). See also K. Hopkins, 'Eunuchs in Politics in the later Roman Empire', *Proc. Camb. Phil. Soc.* 189 (1963), pp.78-80.

38 *De Caes.* 4.6; 4.15.

39 *De Caes.* 42.23.

40 *De Caes.* 42.24-25; cf. 9.12; 13.7. On Victor's concluding remarks see R.J. Penella, 'A Lowly Born Historian of the Late Roman Empire', *Thought* 55 (No. 216) (1980), pp.130-31.

41 Ammianus 21.10.6. On the meaning of *sobrietas* see Dufraigne, p.xvii.

42 Lib. *Orat.* 18.179.

43 Julian, *Lettres*, ed. Bidez (2nd ed., 1960), no. 80, p.89: cf. Lib. *loc.cit.* This point is carefully noted by G.W. Bowersock, *Julian the Apostate* (London, 1978), pp.14-15 and C. Head, *The Emperor Julian* (Boston, 1976), p.48.

44 Ammianus 25.4.3; Lib. *Orat.* 18.179. In his *Caesares* (311D) Julian criticizes Hadrian for his passion for Antinous.

45 Lib. *Orat.* 18.181.

46 Bowersock, *op.cit.* (n.43), p.16.

47 *Caesares* 312B.

48 *Caesares* 334B-D.

49 *De Caes.* 3.5-6.

50 *De Caes.* 17.1. Cf. *H.A. Sev.* 20.1ff. for a continuation of the theme.

51 See chapter one.

52 For an intriguing digression on empresses and sexual morality see *Epit.* 42.19-21. The Epitomator is far less reticent than Victor in naming

empresses of importance and in noting sexual aberrations, e.g. 23.3. One final point: unlike the anonymous epitomator Victor never uses the term 'eunuch'. It might have been perilous to do so in view of the power and influence of Eusebius, Constantius' head chamberlain.

## NOTES TO APPENDIX VI

1 E.g. the alleged 'Edict of Gallienus' (*De Caes.* 33.33-34; 37.6-7), the existence of which several scholars have justifiably doubted, including W. Seston (*Dioclétien et la tétrarchie*, pt. 1 (Paris, 1946), p.317), B.H. Warmington (in H.M.D. Parker, *A History of the Roman World A.D. 138 to 337* (London, 1958), p.395); A. Bellezza ('Interpretazione di un passo di Aurelio Vittore (*Caesares* 33,34) sulla politica imperiale romana del III secolo', *Atti della Accademia Ligure di Scienze e Lettere* 17 (1960), pp.1ff.); R. Syme (*Emperors and Biography*, p.241). Also, Victor is the only extant author to note Hannibal's use of troops for agricultural purposes (37.3) (cf. Nepos *Hannibal* 7.1); and he perceptively realizes that Diocletian's seizure of Mesopotamia was the ultimate reason for Rome's continuous wars against Persia (*De Caes.* 39.37).

2 H. Dessau, 'Über Zeit und Persönlichkeit der S.H.A.', *Hermes* 24 (1889), pp.337ff.

3 For surveys of the voluminous literature engendered by this controversy see A. Momigliano, 'An Unsolved Problem of Historical Forgery; The *Scriptores Historiae Augustae*', in *Studies in Historiography* (London, 1966), pp.143-80; A. Chastagnol, 'Le Problème de l'Histoire Auguste: état de la question', *BHAC* (1963) (1964), pp.43ff.; 'Recherches sur l'Histoire Auguste de 1963 à 1969', *Antiquitas* 4 (6) (1970), pp.1-37; R. Syme, 'The Historia Augusta: A Call of Clarity', *Antiquitas* 4 (8) (1971), pp.38-44; T.D. Barnes, *The Sources of the Historia Augusta* (Brussels, 1978), pp.13, 23.

4 *Op.cit.* (n.3), p.152; cf. H. Stern, *Date et Destinaire de l'Histoire Auguste* (Paris, 1953), pp.17-27.

5 E. Hohl, 'Die Historia Augusta und die Caesares des Aurelius Victor', *Historia* 4 (1955), pp.220ff.; 'Über das Problem der Historia Augusta', *Wien. Stud.* 71 (1958), pp.132ff.

6 A. Chastagnol, 'L'Utilization des «Caesares» d'Aurélius Victor dans l'Histoire Auguste', *BHAC* (1966/67) (1968), p.56.

7 He was still *praefectus annonae* on March 31, 222 (*Cod. Just.* 8.37.4).

8 T.D. Barnes, 'The Lost Kaisergeschichte and the Latin Historical Tradition', *BHAC* (1968/69) (1970), p.35.

9 *Ibid.*, p.37; cf. Chastagnol, *op.cit.* (n.6), p.61.

10 A. Chastagnol, 'Emprunts de l'*Histoire Auguste* aux *Caesares* d'Aurélius Victor', *Rev. Phil.* 41 (1967), pp.85ff.

11 A. Enmann, 'Eine verlorene Geschichte der römischen Kaiser', *Philologus* Suppl. 4 (1884), pp.339-40.

12 Barnes, *op.cit.* (n.8), pp.15ff.; see also H.W. Bird, 'Further Observations on the Dating of Enmann's *Kaisergeschichte*', *CQ* 23 (1973), pp.375-77.

13 *De Caes.* 37.5-7; E. Hohl, 'Vopiscus und die Biographie des Kaisers

Tacitus', *Klio* 11 (1911), pp.310ff.; R. Syme, *op.cit.* (n.1), pp.245-46.

14 On which see H.W. Bird, 'Diocletian and the Deaths of Carus, Numerian and Carinus', *Latomus* 35 (1976), pp.123ff.

15 R. Syme, *Ammianus and the Historia Augusta* (Oxford, 1968), p.220; *Emperors and Biography*, pp.281-90. For new evidence supplied by computers see I. Marriott, 'The Authorship of the *Historia Augusta*: Two Computer Studies', *JRS* 69 (1979), p.65. These studies point to the conclusion that there was one author of the *H.A.* Not all, however, have been convinced: see among others den Boer, pp.55, 67, 92, 110; S.I. Oost, *CP* 71 (1976), pp.294-95; B. Baldwin, 'The *Caesares* of Julian', *Klio* 60 (1978), p.457; Dufraigne, pp.xxv-xxxv.

## TRANSLATIONS

Translations of Latin quotations in the main body of the text (apart from single words or very brief phrases) are offered below.

p.7 *ortus medie* . . .: born of a family of fairly humble means he was schooled first in letters, thereafter in the law. Deriving little satisfaction from the latter, as is common for (people in) poorly paid positions, while trying out and looking around for different and better employment . . .; after many dubious experiences (he received) the tokens of future honours . . .; those who are struggling remember the beginning of their good fortune and those who were responsible for it.

p.8 *his annis* . . .: in recent years Illyricum has regained its strength because of the improvements brought about by the prefect Anatolius.

p.10 *hac tempestate* . . .: at this time . . . many have made the title bereft of prestige and a symbol of arrogance to the unfortunate, given over to the worst of individuals and rapacious under the guise of collecting supplies.

*quae sane* . . .: it was no doubt tolerable in those times of careful administration but in these days it has become ruinous.

*vi eius* . . .: by his (Julian's) vigour but under the good fortune and planning of the emperor.

*quod adeo* . . .: this is so evident that Tiberius and Galerius, under the direction of others, performed many outstanding feats but achieved less success when acting on their own independent authority.

p.21 *ac mihi* . . .: and in my opinion, indeed, after many conversations and wide reading.

*atque inter* . . .: and in addition to this many consider that he even had intercourse with his own mother . . . . I personally believe this is true although other writers hold different views.

*tum quia natus* . . .: then because he was born in the barracks.

*Claudio febri* . . .: Claudius died of fever or through treachery.

p.22 *nunc addita* . . .: many things which I have most diligently excerpted from (Suetonius) Tranquillus and other notable historians have on some occasions been added, on other occasions conflated.

p.26 *quod moderatorem* . . .: because it certainly would not be right for the ruler of all to make mistakes.

p.28 *primum feliciter* . . .: first auspiciously, then reasonably, finally perniciously.

p.28 (cont.) *diu placidus* . . .: for a long time he was calm and controlled: subsequently he lapsed into all forms of lasciviousness and relaxed the reins of government with disgraceful indolence and despair.

p.30 *ita Romae* . . .: thus at Rome the royal power was confirmed and it was clearly revealed that the efforts of men are rendered vain and futile by fortune.

*quasi naturae* . . .: as if by some law of nature which frequently, as if by design, produces bad men from good, uncultivated men from learned ones and so on, or vice versa.

*generis humani* . . .: the delight of the human race.

p.43 *aemuli, ut inter* . . .: jealous, as is usual among them, lest they might appear different.

*ob amissionem* . . .: on account of their loss of perquisites and generous gifts.

*intemperantia militis* . . .: the excessive demands of the military which often afflicted the Roman state with its oppressive expenses.

p.46 *primus e militaribus* . . .: was the first soldier, though almost illiterate, to seize power by the vote of the legions.

*milites . . . genus* . . .: the soldiers . . . a class of men too greedy for gain and loyal and good solely for money.

*quae causa* . . .: for this reason civil wars also broke out and were of far greater ferocity.

p.50 *litterarum prorsus* . . .: completely illiterate and mentally rather dull and therefore the worst (choice) because of his rustic senselessness.

p.52 *Romanum statum* . . .: cast down the Roman state headlong, as it were.

*quippe stolidorum* . . .: for indeed the minds of fools are guided by those who advise them.

p.58 *quae res* . . .: which pernicious quality is the sustainer of vices.

*quippe humanae* . . .: for, indeed, human minds are more sharply offended when they are frustrated in their hopes of improvement and when their burden of troubles remains in spite of the removal of a shameful ruler.

*apparitorum plerisque* . . .: no one (lit. nothing) is more frightful than the majority of his associates.

*officia quae* . . .: duties which they cannot perform.

p.64 *quod sane* . . .: which certainly the Roman people bore with the greatest distress.

*primusque orbem* . . .: he was the first to attempt to elevate a city of his own name to such heights that he might make it rival Rome.

p.68 *manus agrestium* . . .: band of rustics and robbers.

p.71 *homo doctissimus* . . .: a most learned and cultivated man.

*sine ulla* . . .: without any training in the liberal arts, without cultivation, without talent, without literary skills.

p.73 *plane compertum* . . .: it is clearly known that the city of Rome grew great because of the accomplishments of its foreigners and imported skills.

p.74 *doctrinae omnis* . . .: of profound learning and completely old-

fashioned morality.

p.75 *aliud in imperatore* . . .: something else is required in an emperor.

p.77 *ad elegantiam* . . .: (possessing) a discreetly elegant literary style and a gentle, affable manner of speaking.

p.78 *quo facilius* . . .: in order that they might more readily furnish a copious supply of liberally-educated individuals.

p.84 *Fortuna saevo* . . .: Fortune, rejoicing in her cruel business, / stubbornly plays her insolent game, / shuffles her unsure rewards, / favouring first me, then someone else.

p.95 *illectis per dona* . . .: he won over the soldiers with bribes and the common people by appearing to attend to the grain supply; the rest he subdued without difficulty.

*ubi militem* . . .: when he had won over the soldiers with bribes, the populace with the grain supply and all people with the charm of leisure, he grew greater by degrees.

*quod factum* . . .: this fact showed that everything revolves in the manner of a circle and that nothing happens which the force of nature cannot repeat in the space of time.

*nisi forte* . . .: unless perhaps there is in all things some sort of circle so that there may be changes of morality just as there are changes of seasons.

p.96 *Ita biennio* . . .: thus after two years and about nine months, after work was completed on the amphitheatre, having bathed he died of poisoning in his fortieth year, although his father had died in his seventieth, having been emperor for ten.

p.98 *quippe quae* . . .: indeed, she had shed her modesty with her clothes.

*Hinc denique* . . .: Hence finally it was jokingly said that it was by no means surprising if a Marius was striving to restore the Roman state since Marius, of the same trade and founder of the family and name, had consolidated it.

*octogesimo imperii* . . .: on the eightieth day of his reign he was killed through a rebellion of the praetorian soldiers and the crime of Julianus.

*eum milites* . . .: the soldiers, whom nothing seemed to satisfy though the world was exhausted and already ruined, shamefully slaughtered him on the eightieth day of his reign at the instigation of Didius.

p.99 *nam reliqua* . . .: for what remains must be told in a more elevated style: we do not, for the present, so much omit it as reserve it for more careful composition.

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Sallust's *Bellum Jugurthinum* describes a war fought in North Africa at the end of the 2nd century B.C. between the imperial power of Rome and an ambitious native prince, Jugurtha. The difficulties for Rome of conducting an African campaign, the incompetence and (according to Sallust) venality of Rome's first commanders in the field, and the corruption (or prudence) of some senators, all rendered the first stages of the war inconclusive. But after Jugurtha's rash massacre of a group of Italian merchants at Cirta, Rome took the war more seriously, and eventually the command against Jugurtha was transferred to a 'new man', C. Marius, (cos. 107 B.C.), who systematically deprived Jugurtha of his bases and treasuries. The war ended when Jugurtha was handed over to the Romans by his father-in-law Bocchus, king of the Mauri. Sallust makes constant reference to political events at Rome affecting the progress of the war; and he analyses the political rivalries which were later to result in the civil strife of his own day. In this commentary on the *Bellum Jugurthinum*, G.M. Paul elucidates the narrative, supplementing and correcting it where appropriate, and clarifies the principles and methods of Sallust's historiography. He discusses fully such topics as the chronology and geography of the war, the customs of the Numidians, the conditions of political life in contemporary Rome, Sallust's sources, and Sallust's personal views. Textual, linguistic and literary problems are treated in so far as they relate to the historical and historiographical understanding of Sallust's account.

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